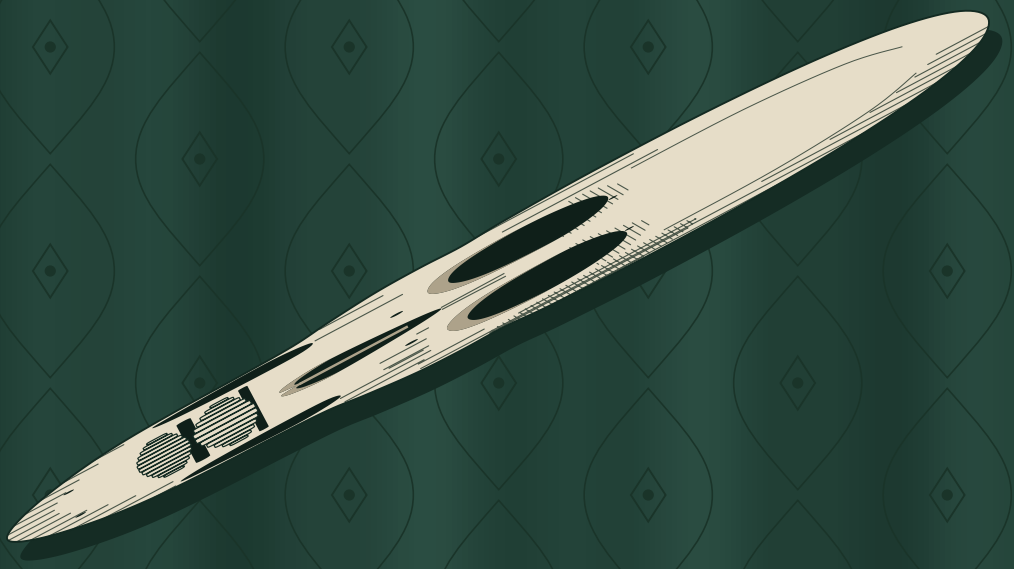
The Anamorphic Skull



Frontispiece. *Stretched 8 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 7° above the page, and it resolves.*

The Anamorphic Skull

Robert Greene, the Metic Sublime, and the Indirect Pedagogy of Power

A Comparative Genealogy of Strategic Wisdom from the Delphic Oracle to the Algorithmic Court

@ertertwert

November 10, 2026

A note on the plates. Each chapter opens on a plate in the green of the damask curtain in Hans Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533), across which lies the painting's skull, drawn here as a true anamorphosis. On the frontispiece it is stretched to eight times its length and is barely a shape at all; from chapter to chapter the stretch relaxes, until on the last page of the book the skull is seen whole. The distorted plates can be resolved as Holbein's was: hold the book nearly edge-on and sight along the length of the shape from its lower end, at the angle given beneath each plate.

Abstract

This dissertation offers a systematic, comparative, and architectonic reading of the corpus of Robert Greene—from *The 48 Laws of Power* (1998) through *The Art of Seduction* (2001), *The 33 Strategies of War* (2006), *The 50th Law* (2009, with Curtis "50 Cent" Jackson), *Mastery* (2012), *The Laws of Human Nature* (2018), and *The Daily Laws* (2021), to *The Law of the Sublime* (2026)—as a single macrotext whose significance exceeds both the commercial category of "self-help" to which it is routinely consigned and the moral panic that has attended its reception in correctional institutions, corporate cultures, and online subcultures. Situating the corpus within a transhistorical genre here designated *oracular-sapiential literature of power*—a lineage extending from the *Instruction of Ptahhotep* and the Delphic maxims through the *I Ching*, the *Arthaśāstra*, the *Han Feizi*, the Islamic, Byzantine, and Latin mirrors for princes, Machiavelli, the Tacitist literature of *arcana imperii*, Gracián's *Oráculo manual*, and the French *moralistes*—the dissertation argues that Greene's decisive achievement is formal before it is doctrinal. The "Law," with its fixed sequence of Judgment, Transgression, Observance, Interpretation, Keys, Image, Authority, and Reversal, fuses the emblem book, the oracle-text, Plutarchan *synkrisis*, the rhetorical *progymnasmata*, and the scholastic *quaestio* into an instrument designed to be consulted rather than read.

Upon this formal foundation the dissertation advances three interlocking propositions. First, the corpus is *anamorphic*. Like the distorted skull in Hans Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533), which resolves into legibility only when the viewer abandons the frontal position, the corpus presents, frontally, an encyclopedia of domination, seduction, and war, and discloses, from the oblique vantage of its terminal texts, a *memento mori* and a discipline of self-knowledge—an orientation that *The Law of the Sublime*, published on the date of this dissertation, renders explicit. Second, the anamorphosis operates as an *indirect pedagogy*, homologous to Kierkegaard's strategy of "deceiving into the truth," to the Mahāyāna doctrine of *upāya* (skillful means), to the Ovidian sequence of *Ars amatoria* and *Remedia amoris*, and to the Platonic palinode: the reader's appetite for power is solicited as the expedient means of its own transfiguration. Third, the experience at the terminus of this pedagogy is theorized

under a new concept, the *metic sublime*: the moment at which *mētis*—the polymorphic, anticipatory, cunning intelligence that Detienne and Vernant reconstructed as the suppressed epistemology of Greek antiquity—pursued to its limit, apprehends the vast impersonal field of forces (*fortuna*, *shi* 勢, friction, history, human nature, mortality) within which the strategist's own ego appears as a minor and transient configuration. The metic sublime is distinguished from its Longinian, Burkean, and Kantian antecedents by its social-historical object and by its terminus, which is not the reassertion of reason's supremacy but its humbling relativization.

Methodologically, the dissertation practices a *triangulated genealogy* that reads Greene's historical exempla against mythological archetypes (Metis and Athena, Hermes, Odysseus *polytropos*, Delilah, Krishna, Proteus, Reynard) and against speculative fiction, understood as the counterfactual laboratory of the sapiential tradition (Asimov's psychohistory and its Mule, Herbert's Bene Gesserit, Liu Cixin's Wallfacers, Le Guin's shadow, Card's Ender), while extending the comparative field to cinema, television, opera, painting, hip-hop, and digital games. Successive chapters reconstruct the genealogy of courtly reason (Chapter Two), the erotics of indirection (Chapter Three), the polemological self (Chapter Four), the paradox of transmissible genius (Chapter Five), and the return of the repressed in Greene's late anthropology (Chapter Six); the concluding chapter formalizes the metic sublime, rereads the corpus through Dumézil's trifunctional ideology and its proposed fourth function, and assesses the corpus's double status as courtier's manual and inoculation in an age of algorithmic persuasion. The dissertation concludes that Greene's corpus is a *pharmakon* whose remedy and poison are one substance, and that its emancipatory potential is activated only by a hermeneutic discipline—*reading backward from the skull*—which the corpus solicits but cannot compel.

Contents

Abstract 5

CHAPTER ONE 11

Oraculum Potentiae

Form, Genre, and the Anamorphic Architecture of the Greene Corpus

1.1 A Canon Without a Discipline 12 ¶ 1.2 The Corpus as Macrotext 13 ¶ 1.3 Anatomy of the Law: Emblem, Oracle, *Synkrisis*, *Progymnasma*, *Quaestio* 15 ¶ 1.4 Rubric: The Red and the Black 20 ¶ 1.5 From Ptahhotep to the Platform: A Genealogy of Oracular-Sapiential Literature 21 ¶ 1.6 The Anamorphic Skull: Statement of Thesis 25 ¶ 1.7 Method: Triangulated Genealogy 31 ¶ 1.8 The *Pharmakon* and the Arrested Reader: Ethics of the Inquiry 33 ¶ 1.9 Architecture of the Dissertation 35

CHAPTER TWO 41

Arcana for the Multitude

The 48 Laws of Power and the Genealogy of Courtly Reason

2.1 The Published Secret: *Arcana Imperii* and the Paradox of Exoteric Cunning 42 ¶ 2.2 The Effectual Truth: Machiavelli, *Fortuna*, and the Privatization of Reason of State 44 ¶ 2.3 The Theater of *Desengaño*: Gracián, Accetto, and Baroque Dissimulation 47 ¶ 2.4 *Amour-Propre* and the Royal Mechanism: La Rochefoucauld and Elias 49 ¶ 2.5 Reputation of Power Is Power: Hobbes and the Court Without a King 51 ¶ 2.6 Masks and *Ressentiment*: Nietzsche, Adler, Foucault 53 ¶ 2.7 A Grammar of the Forty-Eight 56 ¶ 2.8 Courts of Fiction: Shakespeare, the Beast Epic, Arrakis, Westeros, and the Cinema of Ascent 58 ¶ 2.9 The Reversal as Crack: Polycrates' Ring, Solon's Warning, and the Formless 61

CHAPTER THREE 67

Militat Omnis Amans

The Art of Seduction and the Erotics of Indirection

3.1 *Militat Omnis Amans*: Seduction as the Hinge Between Power and War 68 ¶ 3.2 The Siren's Epistemic Lure: Homer, Circe, Calypso, and the Mast 69 ¶ 3.3 Arts of Love: Ovid, Andreas, Ibn Ḥazm, Vātsyāyana, Murasaki, and the Rose 71 ¶ 3.4 The Seducer's Masks: Nine Characters and the Performance of Self 74 ¶ 3.5 The Grammar of Desire: Stendhal, Girard, Freud, Lacan 76 ¶ 3.6 The Diary and Its Despair: Kierkegaard, Laclos, Don Juan 78 ¶ 3.7 Coercion at the Edge: Isolation, Intermittence, and the Ethics of Consent 80 ¶ 3.8 Soft Seduction: Bernays, the Spectacle, and the Algorithmic Siren 83 ¶ 3.9 The Ladder and the Stone Guest: Seduction's Two Exits and the First Palinode 85

89 CHAPTER FOUR

Polemos Pantōn Patēr

The 33 Strategies of War, *The 50th Law*, and the Polemological Self

4.1 *Polemos Pantōn Patēr*: Heraclitus and the Warring Cosmos 90 ¶ 4.2 The Way of Deception and the Propensity of Things: Sun Tzu, *Shi*, and the Three Kingdoms 92 ¶ 4.3 Friction, Genius, and the Culminating Point: Clausewitz and His Heirs 95 ¶ 4.4 Friend and Enemy: Schmitt, Foucault, and the Privatization of War 97 ¶ 4.5 The Constitutive Metaphor: ARGUMENT IS WAR and the Petrifying Force 99 ¶ 4.6 The Epics of War: The *Iliad*, the *Mahābhārata*, and the Vision of Time 101 ¶ 4.7 Fearlessness: *The 50th Law*, the Street, and the Way of the Samurai 103 ¶ 4.8 Strategists of the Counterfactual: Ender, Yang Wen-li, the Swordholder, and the Game 106 ¶ 4.9 The Sky over Austerlitz: The Polemological Route to the Metic Sublime 108

111 CHAPTER FIVE

The Knife of Cook Ding

Mastery, *Mētis*, and the Paradox of Transmissible Genius

5.1 The Net of Hephaestus: From *Mētis* as Cunning to *Mētis* as Craft 112 ¶ 5.2 Habit, Hand, and Tacit Knowledge: Aristotle, Polanyi, Merleau-Ponty, Heidegger 113 ¶ 5.3 The Knife of Cook Ding and the Wheelwright's Dregs 115 ¶ 5.4 Stages of the Way: *Shuhari*, Dreyfus, Ericsson, and the Ideal Apprenticeship 117 ¶ 5.5 Become Who You Are: The Life's Task and the *Bildungsroman* 120 ¶ 5.6 The Mentor Dynamic: Outshining the Master 122 ¶ 5.7 Masters and Monsters on Screen: The Shortcut and Its Price 124 ¶ 5.8 Move 37: Mastery After the Machine 126 ¶ 5.9 The Ocean of Truth: Mastery and the Serene Sublime 129

133 CHAPTER SIX

The Shadow and the Skull

The Laws of Human Nature and the Return of the Repressed

6.1 Summa and Palinode: *The Laws of Human Nature* as the Corpus's Self-Interpretation 134 ¶ 6.2 The Charioteer and the Mirror: Irrationality and Narcissism 135 ¶ 6.3 Masks, Characters, and the Science of Faces 137 ¶ 6.4 The Shadow: Jung, Le Guin, and the Return of the Repressed 139 ¶ 6.5 Envy, the Crowd, and the Victim: The Group and Its Violence 141 ¶ 6.6 Grandiosity as Death Denial: Becker, Canetti, and the Survivor 143 ¶ 6.7 The Mortal Court: Siddhārtha's Palace, Ivan Ilyich, and *Ikiru* 145 ¶ 6.8 Meditate on Our Common Mortality: The Ethics of Finitude 148 ¶ 6.9 The Palinode Examined: Self-Knowledge, Pacification, and the Skull 150

155 CHAPTER SEVEN

The Metic Sublime

The Law of the Sublime and a Theory of Anamorphic Wisdom

7.1 The Destination Named: *The Law of the Sublime* and the Fourth Movement 156 ¶ 7.2 Toward a Definition: The Metic Sublime Among Its Antecedents 158 ¶ 7.3 A Typology of the Metic Sublime 160 ¶ 7.4 The View from Above: The Metic Sublime as Spiritual Exercise 161 ¶ 7.5 The Unjudged Apple: Dumézil, Allen, and the Tetrafunctional Architecture of the Corpus 163 ¶ 7.6 The Closures Compared: Gracián, Castiglione, Musashi, and the Secular Saint 165 ¶ 7.7 The Algorithmic Court and the Double Book: Manual and Inoculation 168 ¶ 7.8 Reading Backward from the Skull: Canons of Anamorphic Interpretation 169 ¶ 7.9 Conclusion: Nature Loves to Hide 171

175 *Selected Bibliography*

185 *Keywords*

Plates, Figures and Tables

PLATES

Frontispiece *The skull at eight to one* 2
Plate I *The skull, stretched* 10
Plate II *The skull, stretched* 40
Plate III *The skull, stretched* 66
Plate IV *The skull, stretched* 88
Plate V *The skull, stretched* 110
Plate VI *The skull, stretched* 132
Plate VII *The skull, stretched* 154
End *The skull, resolved* 186

FIGURES

Fig. 1.1 From the many to the one 16
Fig. 1.2 The Law as a glossed page 19
Fig. 1.3 The dial of the genre 26
Fig. 1.4 The two vantages 27
Fig. 2.1 An armorial of the forty-eight 57
Fig. 3.1 Seduction's two exits 86
Fig. 4.1 *Shi* 勢 93
Fig. 4.2 The culminating point 96
Fig. 5.1 Three ways of seeing an ox 116
Fig. 5.2 Stages of the way 119
Fig. 5.3 The fifth line 127
Fig. 6.1 The four sights 146
Fig. 7.1 The unjudged apple 166

TABLES

Table 2.1 The seven economies of *The 48 Laws of Power*. 56
Table 7.1 The five modes of the metic sublime. 160

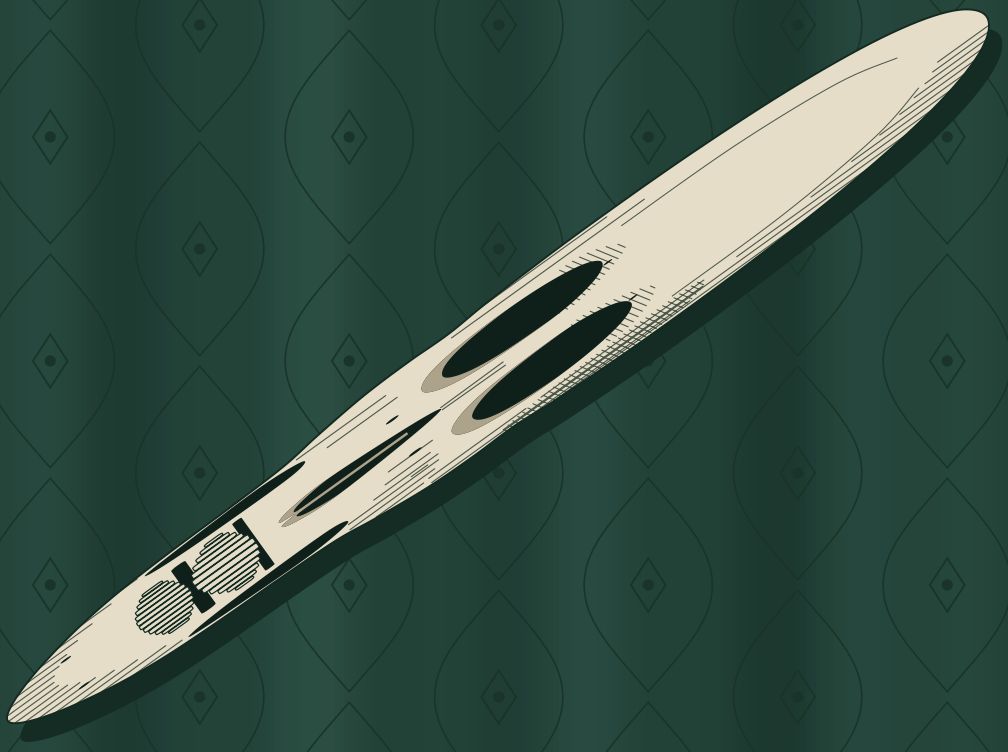


Plate I. *Stretched 7 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 8° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER ONE

Oraculum Potentiae

Form, Genre, and the Anamorphic Architecture of the Greene Corpus

Le soleil ni la mort ne se peuvent regarder fixement.
— La Rochefoucauld, *Maximes*, 26

φύσις κρύπτεσθαι φιλεῖ.
— Heraclitus, DK 22 B123

En una palabra, santo.
— Baltasar Gracián, *Oráculo manual y arte de prudencia*, §300

1.1 *A Canon Without a Discipline*

Few bodies of contemporary writing have achieved so wide a practical circulation while attracting so little sustained scholarly attention as the books of Robert Greene. Since the publication of *The 48 Laws of Power* in 1998, Greene's works have been translated into dozens of languages and absorbed into milieux that rarely share a bookshelf: the recording studio and the trading floor, the venture-capital pitch and the prison yard, the military staff college and the self-styled "seduction community," the startup incubator and the revivalist circles of popular Stoicism—the last of which descends in part from Greene's own workshop, through his former research assistant Ryan Holiday. *The 48 Laws* has, moreover, acquired the peculiar dignity of the forbidden book. Reports of its exclusion from the libraries of numerous American correctional institutions have conferred upon it an aura that no marketing could manufacture, analogous to the aura that the Pauline Index of 1559 conferred upon *Il Principe*. Hip-hop culture, which had already elaborated a vernacular Machiavellianism—Tupac Shakur's adoption of the persona "Makaveli" after reading the Florentine in prison is the emblematic instance—received Greene as the systematizer of a wisdom it had long practiced, a reception crystallized in *The 50th Law* (2009), co-authored with Curtis "50 Cent" Jackson. Concurrently the books migrated into the managerial imaginary of the technology sector and into the masculinist subcultures of the internet, where *The Art of Seduction* was read—selectively and, as this dissertation will argue, against the grain of its own text—as a manual of sexual conquest.

The academy's response has been, with scattered exceptions, a silence punctuated by condescension, and the silence is overdetermined. Disciplinarily, the corpus belongs nowhere: too historical for psychology, too psychological for history, too anecdotal for political theory, too prescriptive for literary studies, and too successful for any field whose self-understanding depends on a distinction between serious and popular knowledge. Generically, it has been shelved under "self-help," a category whose scholarly treatment—Micki McGee's *Self-Help, Inc.* (2005), Eva Illouz's *Saving the Modern Soul* (2008)—has tended to approach its objects as symptoms of neoliberal subjectivation rather than as texts possessing architectures, genealogies, and arguments of their own. Morally, the corpus offends: its surface amoralism, its refusal to subordinate the description of power to a normative theory of legitimacy, and its open instruction in deception place it beyond the pale of a liberal pedagogy

whose official ideal is transparent communication. The result is a canon without a discipline—a body of texts that functions, for millions of readers, as a practical philosophy, yet possesses neither a critical apparatus nor an interpretive tradition.

This dissertation proceeds from the conviction that the silence is an error of the same order as that which long allowed Gracián's *Oráculo manual* to be dismissed as a courtier's breviary and La Rochefoucauld's *Maximes* as the misanthropy of a disappointed *frondeur*. Both judgments were reversed by readers—Schopenhauer, who translated Gracián into German; Nietzsche, who numbered La Rochefoucauld among the masters of psychological observation—who perceived beneath the worldly surface a rigorous anthropology. The present inquiry neither canonizes Greene as a sage nor dismisses him as a merchant of manipulation. It treats the corpus as what it demonstrably is: the most widely read modern instance of an ancient and transcultural genre; a formally innovative synthesis of that genre's resources; and—this is the dissertation's central and most contestable claim—a single, architecturally coherent work whose final meaning inverts the meaning of its most famous part.

The Corpus as Macrotext 1.2

Before the corpus can be read as a whole, it must be shown to be one. The bibliographical facts are these. Greene (b. 1959), trained in classical studies at the University of California, Berkeley, and the University of Wisconsin–Madison, spent the years after his degree in an itinerant succession of occupations—construction, hotel work, translation, magazine editing, story development in the Hollywood studio system—an apprenticeship in the observation of hierarchies that *Mastery* would later theorize as the "Ideal Apprenticeship." In 1995, at Fabrica, the communications research center in Treviso, he met the Dutch book producer Joost Elffers, whose collaboration determined the visual and typographic identity of the first three books. The corpus thereafter unfolds in four movements.

Movements I–III

The first, which this dissertation calls the *agonistic triptych*, comprises *The 48 Laws of Power* (1998), *The Art of Seduction* (2001), and *The 33 Strategies of War* (2006): each organized as a numbered sequence of laws, strategies, or types; each constructed from historical exempla; each devoted to a modality of asymmetric influence. The second, transitional movement comprises *The 50th Law* (2009), which reframes the agonistic

material through the single affect of fear and closes, decisively, on a chapter devoted to the sublime, and *Mastery* (2012), which redirects the strategic intelligence of the triptych from the manipulation of others to the cultivation of a craft and locates the origin of every vocation in the "primal inclinations" of childhood. The third movement, *The Laws of Human Nature* (2018), is at once a summa and a palinode. It recapitulates the psychology latent in the earlier books, systematizes it into eighteen laws of human behavior, and internalizes the adversary: the reader's own narcissism, envy, grandiosity, conformity, and repressed "shadow" now occupy the position formerly reserved for rival courtiers and enemy generals; and it terminates in a meditation on mortality. *The Daily Laws* (2021), three hundred and sixty-six excerpted meditations, converts the preceding corpus into a liturgical calendar, completing its passage from treatise to oracle.

Movement IV

The fourth movement is inaugurated by *The Law of the Sublime* (2026), published on the date of this dissertation. Its publisher presents it as a guide to transcending one's limits through an experience that connects the subject to the immense forces of the universe, to the interior worlds of other people, and even to other species; that draws on science, mythology, history, the arts, and nature; and that returns the reader to the perceptual freshness of childhood, through stories of near-death encounters, discoveries, and transformations of consciousness accompanied by exercises and meditations (Penguin Random House). The present argument was constructed from the antecedent corpus. Its engagement with the new book is confined, here and in Chapter Seven, to the book's announced program, which it reads as the explicit thematization of a terminus that the architecture of the earlier works had already implied.

The claim that this sequence constitutes a *macrotext*—Maria Corti's term for a set of texts whose combination generates meanings irreducible to the sum of its components—rests on three kinds of evidence. The first is thematic recurrence with progressive transvaluation: the same figures and motifs (the mask, the court, timing, the elusive object, the confrontation with death) migrate across the books from instrumental to existential registers. The second is explicit retrospection: the late books reframe the early ones, so that the "power" of 1998 is reinterpreted, in 2018, as one expression of a more fundamental human nature whose study is primarily a study of oneself. The third, and most decisive, is architectonic. The terminal positions of the corpus's major units are occupied by figures of transcendence. *The 48 Laws* closes with "Assume Formlessness," a law that dissolves the very notion of a fixed strategic identity; *The 50th Law*

closes with the sublime; *The Laws of Human Nature* closes with death; and the corpus as a whole now closes with the sublime once more. Endings possess hermeneutic privilege in any structured sequence: they are the points from which the sequence asks to be reread. A corpus whose terminal points systematically gesture beyond the agonistic economy of its surface demands, as this dissertation will argue, to be read backward.

The very grammar of the titles records the trajectory. The corpus begins in the plural—forty-eight laws, twenty-four strategies of seduction, thirty-three strategies of war—passes through the singular of *The 50th Law* and the plurals of *The Laws of Human Nature* and *The Daily Laws*, and arrives at the singular of *The Law of the Sublime*. The movement from multiplicity to unity, from the polytropic repertoire of the strategist to a single law, recapitulates the Neoplatonic rhythm of procession and return (*proodos* and *epistrophē*), in which the many issue from the One and are drawn back toward it. Whether or not the rhythm was intended, it is legible, and legibility is what the present argument requires.

The objection from intention must be anticipated. To argue that the corpus means something its most famous book does not say is to risk the intentional fallacy in reverse: the attribution to an author of a design the texts do not avow. The present argument is indifferent to Greene's psychological intentions, which Wimsatt and Beardsley rightly excluded from the determination of literary meaning. It concerns the work's structure and the effects that structure can produce in readers. A macrotext may possess an architecture its author did not plan, as a cathedral built over three centuries may possess a unity none of its masons conceived. The biographical record supplies, at most, a poignant corroboration: the author of *The Laws of Human Nature* suffered a severe stroke in 2018, shortly before that book appeared, so that the corpus's meditation on mortality was published under the shadow of the contingency it describes, and *The Law of the Sublime* was composed in the long aftermath of that event. The dissertation notes the coincidence and declines to lean upon it.

1.3 *Anatomy of the Law: Emblem, Oracle,* Synkrisis, Progymnasma, Quaestio

Greene's most consequential innovation is a form. Each of the forty-eight laws unfolds through a fixed sequence of rubricated movements: the law itself, stated as an imperative; a "Judgment" that condenses it into a

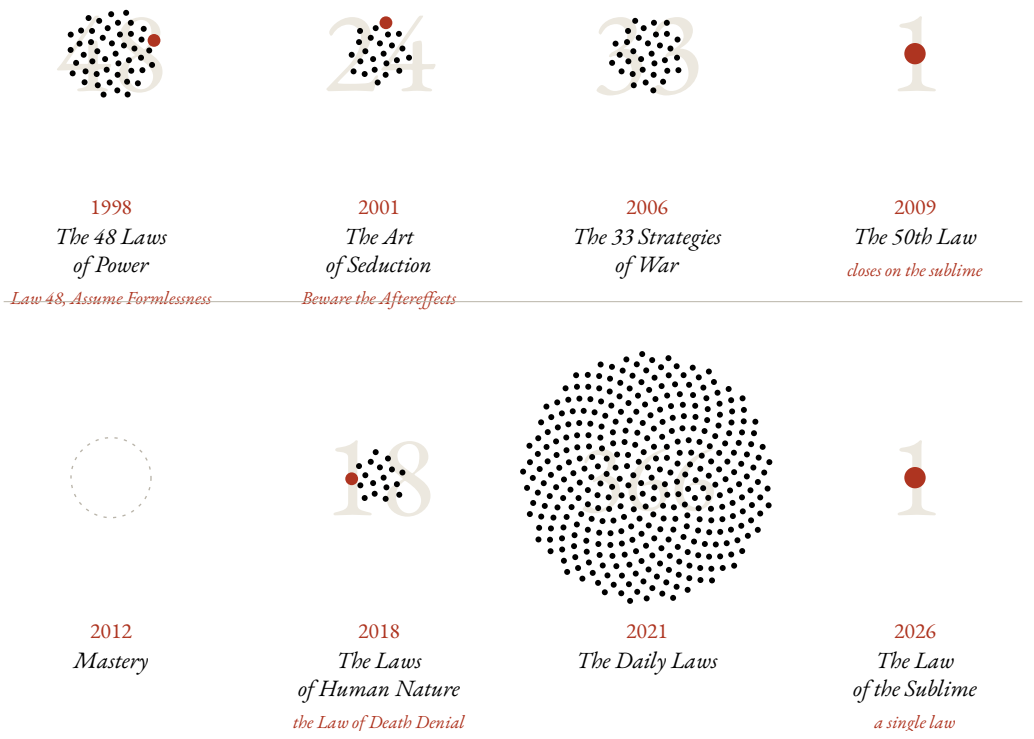


Fig. 1.1 *From the many to the one.* Each title of the corpus counted in the units it divides itself into: the plural fields of laws and strategies, the singular of *The 50th Law*, the plurals of *The Laws of Human Nature* and *The Daily Laws*, and the single law of 2026 (§1.2). Red marks a terminal position the essay names. *Mastery*, whose title counts nothing, is shown as a gap in the sequence.

paragraph of doctrine; one or more historical narratives in which the law is violated ("Transgression of the Law") or obeyed ("Observance of the Law"), each followed by an "Interpretation"; a discursive essay, "Keys to Power," that generalizes from the exempla; an "Image," a single allegorical figure rendered in prose; an "Authority," a quotation from a canonical source; and a "Reversal," which specifies the conditions under which the law must be suspended or inverted. Around this central column, in the margins, run sidebars: fables, anecdotes, and aphorisms drawn from Aesop and La Fontaine, from the Daoist and Legalist classics, and from the memoir literature of the European courts. *The Art of Seduction* and *The 33 Strategies of War* vary the template without abandoning its logic.

The form is overdetermined, and its overdetermination is the source of its power. It compresses at least five traditions of sapiential textuality into a single unit.

i. Emblem

The first is the Renaissance emblem book. Andrea Alciato's *Emblematum liber* (1531) inaugurated a genre whose canonical unit was tripartite: an *inscriptio* (motto), a *pictura* (image), and a *subscriptio* (an epigram explicating the relation between them). The emblem was a mnemonic device that fused maxim and figure, and it was a courtly form, circulating among humanist elites alongside the *imprese* through which individuals encoded their intentions in public. Greene's law reproduces the *inscriptio* in its imperative title, the *pictura* in its Image, and the *subscriptio* in its Judgment and Keys. Its Images are *emblemata* without engravings: ekphrases of absent pictures, drawn from nature, myth, and the bestiary.

ii. Oracle

The second is the oracle-text, and here the homology is so precise as to be startling. In the *I Ching* as rendered by Richard Wilhelm (1924), and in Cary F. Baynes's English version (1950) introduced by C. G. Jung, each hexagram is accompanied by a "Judgment" (*tuan* 彖) and an "Image" (*xiang* 象), followed by statements on individual lines that specify how the general situation mutates under particular conditions. Greene's law reproduces the sequence almost exactly: Judgment, Image, and a Reversal that, like the *I Ching*'s changing lines, marks the point at which a situation turns into its opposite. Whether the homology was designed or emerged from the deep grammar of the oracular genre is immaterial. Its effect is to present each law not as a proposition to be believed but as a situation to be recognized. One does not argue with a hexagram; one consults it, and the consultation is an act of self-diagnosis. The book's widely attested mode of use—opened at random, consulted at moments of crisis, quoted as scripture is quoted—confirms that readers grasp intuitively what the form encodes. *The Daily Laws* merely institutionalizes this bibliomantic practice.

iii. Synkrisis

The third is Plutarchan *synkrisis*. The *Parallel Lives* pair a Greek and a Roman and conclude, in most cases, with a formal comparison weighing the subjects against one another in respect of virtue and fortune. Greene's alternation of Transgression and Observance is a *synkrisis* compressed into a single law: the fall of Nicolas Fouquet, whose fête at Vaux-le-Vicomte in August 1661 so wounded Louis XIV's sense of preeminence that the superintendent was arrested within three weeks, set against Galileo's dedication of the satellites of Jupiter to the Medici as the "Medicean stars." The pairing is not merely illustrative but probative; it performs, at the scale of the anecdote, the comparative method that

Machiavelli claimed, in the *Discorsi*, to have learned from the reading of ancient histories.

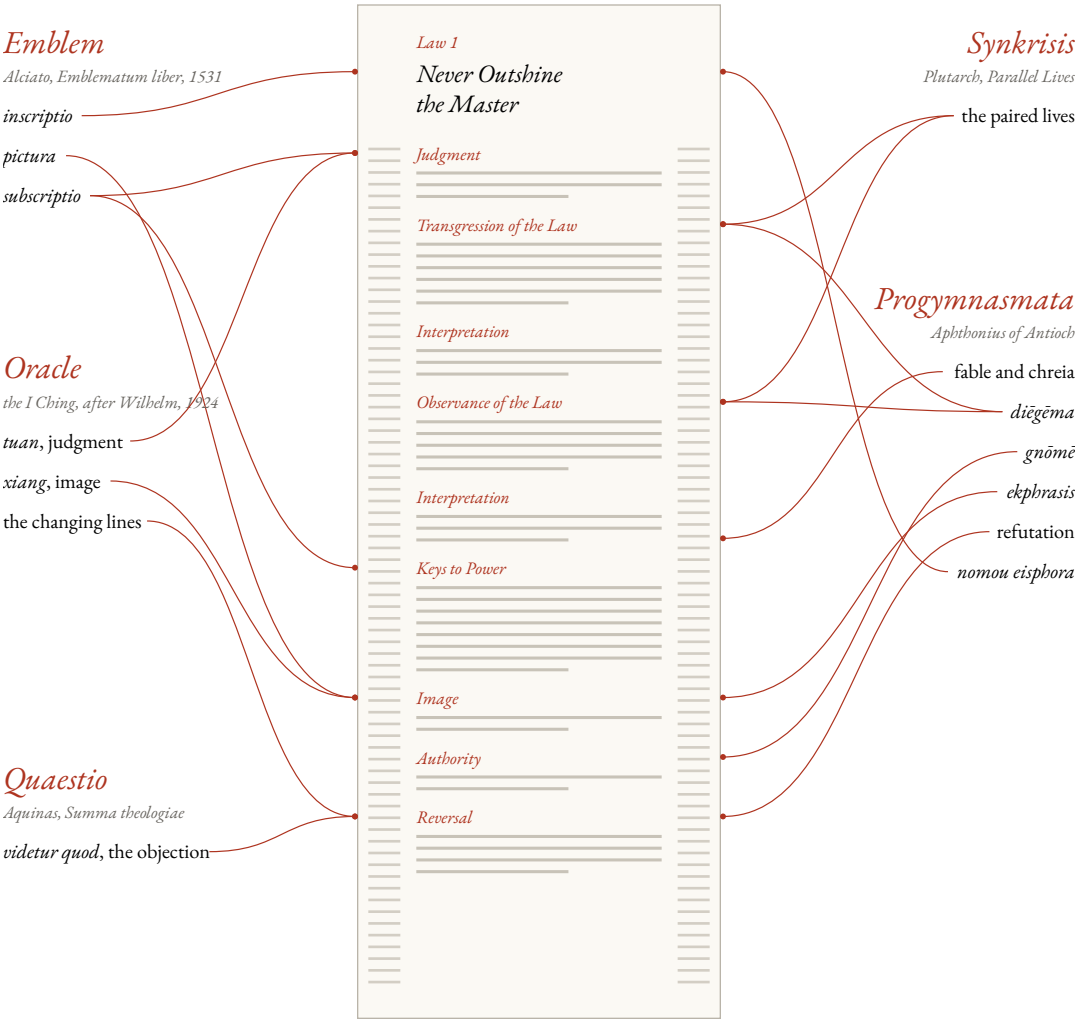
iv. Progymnasmata

The fourth is the curriculum of the rhetorical schools. The *progymnasmata*—the graded preliminary exercises codified by Theon, Hermogenes, and above all Aphthonius of Antioch, and transmitted through the Byzantine and Renaissance schoolroom to the humanist courtier—trained students successively in fable (*mythos*), narrative (*diēgēma*), anecdote (*chreia*), maxim (*gnōmē*), refutation and confirmation, commonplace, encomium and invective, comparison (*synkrisis*), characterization (*ēthopoiia*), description (*ekphrasis*), thesis, and, as the culminating exercise, the introduction of a law (*nomou eisphora*). The Greenean law enacts nearly this entire cycle: the sidebars supply fable and *chreia*, the Authority supplies *gnōmē*, Transgression and Observance supply *diēgēma* and *synkrisis*, the Image supplies *ekphrasis*, the Reversal supplies refutation, and the law itself is a *nomou eisphora*. The reader of *The 48 Laws* is, without knowing it, drilled in the preparatory curriculum that formed Castiglione's courtier and Shakespeare's grammar-school audience—a curriculum whose purpose was never mere eloquence but the cultivation of a supple, situationally responsive practical intelligence.

v. Quaestio

The fifth is the scholastic *quaestio*. The articles of Aquinas's *Summa theologiae* proceed through objections (*videtur quod*), a counter-authority (*sed contra*), the master's resolution (*respondeo*), and replies to the objections. The Reversal performs the function of the objection displaced to the end: having established the law, it introduces the cases that would falsify it. This feature, more than any other, distinguishes Greene's form from the dogmatic list-forms of popular self-help and aligns it with the tradition of discretion that Francesco Guicciardini opposed to Machiavelli. In the *Ricordi*, Guicciardini warned that worldly matters cannot be judged indiscriminately and by rule, since nearly all admit distinctions and exceptions that only *discrezione* can discern, and he mocked those who cite the Romans at every turn (*Ricordi* C 6, C 110). The Reversal is Guicciardini's *ricordo* inserted into Machiavelli's chapter: the self-correction of exemplary reasoning by the acknowledgment of circumstance.

Around this central column, the marginal sidebars create a polyphonic page. The layout recalls the glossed manuscripts of the medieval schools and, more strikingly, the Talmudic folio, in which the central text is enclosed by layers of commentary—Rashi on the inner margin, the Tosafot on the outer—that converse with it across centuries. The page is a theater of voices in Bakhtin's sense: Greene's expository voice is surrounded, interrupted, and occasionally contradicted by Aesop, Zhuangzi, Gracián,



The Law as a glossed page. The rubricated movements of a Greenean law down the central column, and the five traditions the form compresses (§1.3) set around it as commentary, in the manner of the Talmudic folio the chapter invokes. Rules join each tradition to the movements it supplies. *Fig. 1.2*

and the court memoirists. To read *The 48 Laws* is therefore not to follow an argument but to attend a disputation, in which the reader presides as judge.

1.4 *Rubric: The Red and the Black*

The visual identity that Elffers devised for *The 48 Laws*—black and red type, generous margins, a typographic austerity punctuated by red display capitals and marginal headings—is commonly treated as packaging. It is better understood as an argument. The alternation of red and black has a precise history in the Western book. Medieval scribes executed headings, initials, ritual instructions, and the names of feasts in red ink (*rubrica*, from *ruber*), whence the rubric: the red text that tells the reader how the black text is to be used. In the missal and the breviary, the rubrics prescribe the performance—when to kneel, when to speak, how the rite proceeds—while the black text supplies its words. A book printed in red and black announces itself as liturgical: not a narrative to be followed but an operational text, a script for action. The same convention migrated into the grimoire tradition, whose most influential exemplars—the *Clavicula Salomonis* and the *Lemegeton*, or *Lesser Key of Solomon*—present themselves precisely as keys: operational instructions for the summoning and binding of powers. It is not fanciful to observe that Greene's discursive core bears the heading "Keys to Power." The book adopts, in its typography and its rubrics, the double genealogy of the missal and the grimoire—the sanctioned script and the forbidden one.

The chromatic pairing carries a further, literary charge that bears directly on the thesis of this dissertation. Stendhal's *Le Rouge et le Noir* (1830) is the great nineteenth-century novel of a young man who governs his life by a manual of power. Julien Sorel, the carpenter's son of Verrières, reads Las Cases's *Mémorial de Sainte-Hélène* as scripture; he studies hypocrisy as a technique, memorizes the Latin New Testament to impress the clergy, conducts his seductions of Madame de Rênal and Mathilde de La Mole as military campaigns, and pursues the two careers that the Restoration offered the ambitious plebeian: the red of the army and the black of the cassock. Critics have also heard in the title the *rouge et noir* of the gaming table, which only deepens its relevance: *fortuna* as roulette. Julien's ascent ends in the courtroom and the cell, where, awaiting execution, he discovers that the happiness he had sacrificed to ambition lay in the very attachment he had treated as an instrument. The stratagems fall away; a lucidity before death replaces the calculus of advancement.

Le Rouge et le Noir is thus a prophetic allegory of the Greene corpus and of its reader: the manual of power, the campaign of seduction, the career conceived as war, and the late revelation, before mortality, of what the whole apparatus was for. Elffers's red and black may be read,

under this description, as an involuntary citation of Stendhal's—a sign that the book contains, from its first page, the trajectory that its sequels would complete. Julien Sorel is at once the corpus's ideal reader and its cautionary tale: the reader who mastered the laws of power and died before learning the laws of human nature.

From Ptahhotep to the Platform: A Genealogy of Oracular-Sapiential Literature 1.5

The genre within which the corpus must be placed is older than philosophy and wider than the West. Its earliest surviving monument, the *Instruction of Ptahhotep*, preserved in Middle Kingdom copies (notably Papyrus Prisse) but attributed to a vizier of the Fifth Dynasty, already counsels the official on conduct at the table of a superior: to take what is offered, to keep the eyes lowered, to speak only when addressed, to laugh when the great man laughs. The first law of courtly prudence—never outshine the master—is thus as old as written instruction itself. The Aramaic *Story of Ahiqar*, attested in fifth-century BCE papyri from Elephantine, adds the genre's characteristic narrative frame: the counselor of Assyrian kings, betrayed by the nephew he trained, survives by concealment and is restored by cunning, his proverbs embedded in the tale of his own vulnerability to the court. The sapiential books of the Hebrew Bible—Proverbs, with its warnings against the smooth-tongued "strange woman" (Prov. 7), and Ecclesiastes, with its season for every purpose—transpose the genre into a theological key without surrendering its worldly acuity.

In Greece the genre attained its most compressed form in the sentences inscribed at the temple of Apollo at Delphi. Of the three that ancient authors most often cite together (Plato, *Charmides* 165a)—γνῶθι σεαυτόν (know thyself), μηδὲν ἄγαν (nothing in excess), and ἐγγύα πάρα δ' ἄτη (a pledge, and ruin is at hand)—each corresponds with uncanny precision to a structural pillar of Greene's corpus: the third to Law 20, "Do Not Commit to Anyone"; the second to Law 47, "Do Not Go Past the Mark You Aimed For," and to the Law of Grandiosity; the first to the entire project of *The Laws of Human Nature*. The Delphic oracle is the archetype of the genre in a deeper sense as well. Its pronouncements were ambiguous situational judgments that demanded interpretation, and their misreading—Croesus's destruction of "a great empire" that proved to be his own (Herodotus 1.53, 1.91)—was itself the lesson. The oracle teaches by forcing the consultant to discover what he did not know

about himself. Xenophon's *Cyropaedia* supplied the narrative mirror for princes that Machiavelli would explicitly admire; Isocrates' *To Nicocles* and Seneca's *De clementia* supplied its hortatory and Stoic variants; and Plutarch's *Lives* and *Moralia* furnished the reservoir of exempla from which every subsequent compiler, Greene included, has drawn.

India and China developed the genre with a rigor the Mediterranean did not match until the sixteenth century. The *Arthaśāstra* attributed to Kauṭilya—a treatise on statecraft whose doctrines of espionage, poisoning, the corruption of enemy ministers, and the manipulation of religious belief prompted Max Weber to remark, in "Politik als Beruf" (1919), that beside it Machiavelli's *Prince* is harmless—articulates a systematic theory of the *maṇḍala*, the circle of states in which one's neighbor is a natural enemy and the neighbor's neighbor a natural ally. The *Pañcatantra*, a *nīti* text composed to educate dull princes through animal fables, entered the Islamic world as *Kalīla wa-Dimna* in the eighth-century Arabic of Ibn al-Muqaffaʿ, whose execution under the early Abbasids added his name to the long roll of theorists of power destroyed by power. Its frame tale —in which the jackal Dimna ingratiates himself with the lion-king and engineers the death of the king's favorite, the bull, through calculated insinuation—is a complete treatise on the courtly arts that Greene's Laws 14 and 33 would codify. In China, the Legalist Han Fei (d. 233 BCE) theorized the ruler's control through the "two handles" (*er bing* 二柄) of punishment and reward and counseled the sovereign to conceal his preferences so that ministers could not exploit them (*Han Feizi* 5, "Zhu dao"); his chapter on "The Difficulties of Persuasion" (*Shui nan* 說難) warned the counselor that the ruler is a dragon who may be ridden but who kills whoever brushes the reversed scales beneath its throat (*nilin* 逆鱗). Han Fei himself died by poison in a Qin prison, a casualty of the intrigues of his former fellow student Li Si. The *Sunzi bingfa* supplied the genre with its most influential aphorism—兵者，詭道也, war is the way of deception (*Sunzi* 1)—and with the concept of *shi* 勢, strategic configuration or potential, to which this dissertation will return as one of the objects of the metic sublime.

The Islamic mirrors for princes—the *Qābūs-nāma* (1082), composed by the Ziyarid prince Kai Kā'ūs for his son, and Niẓām al-Mulk's *Siyāsat-nāma*—and the Byzantine *Strategikon* of Kekaumenos (c. 1075–1078), a work of breathtaking suspicion that counsels its reader to trust no one, not even his guests, sustained the genre through the medieval centuries, while the Latin West produced its Christianized forms in John of Salisbury's *Policraticus* (1159), the pseudo-Aristotelian *Secretum*

secretorum, and Giles of Rome's *De regimine principum*. Then came the rupture. Machiavelli's *Il Principe* (composed 1513, printed 1532) appropriated the form of the mirror for princes in order to destroy its moral content. Where Cicero had declared that force belongs to the lion and fraud to the fox, both utterly alien to a human being (*De officiis* 1.41), Machiavelli instructed the prince to know how to be both (*Principe* XVIII); and where the mirrors had portrayed the prince as he ought to be, Machiavelli resolved to pursue *la verità effettuale della cosa*, the effectual truth of the matter (*Principe* XV). Greene's founding commitment—that power must be described as it operates rather than as moralists wish it would—is the direct inheritance of that programmatic phrase.

The century and a half after Machiavelli constitutes the genre's classical age, and from it Greene draws the largest share of his authorities. Castiglione's *Il Cortegiano* (1528) supplied the aesthetics of *sprezzatura*, the studied nonchalance *che nasconda l'arte*, that conceals art (I.26), which becomes Law 30. The Tacitist movement, launched by Justus Lipsius's edition of Tacitus and his *Politica* (1589), recovered the Roman historian as a covert teacher of the *arcana imperii*, the secrets of rule (*Annals* 2.36; *Histories* 1.4), and developed in Lipsius's doctrine of *prudentia mixta* a graduated theory of permissible deceit—light, middling, and grave—that married Neostoic constancy to political cunning. This marriage of Stoicism and stratagem is precisely the double inheritance of the Greene corpus, whose early books teach the fox and whose late books teach the sage. Giovanni Botero's *Della ragion di Stato* (1589), Arnold Clapmarius's *De arcanis rerumpublicarum* (1605), and Gabriel Naudé's *Considérations politiques sur les coups d'État* (1639) extended the literature of secret rule; Francis Bacon's *Essays* (1625) distinguished secrecy, dissimulation, and simulation with Aristotelian precision; and Torquato Accetto's *Della dissimulazione onesta* (1641), written under Spanish dominion in Naples, produced the most refined defense of concealment as the protection of interior freedom under tyranny.

The genre's summit is Baltasar Gracián's *Oráculo manual y arte de prudencia* (1647), and no source is more pervasively present in Greene. Gracián's three hundred aphorisms anticipate a remarkable number of the forty-eight laws, sometimes to the point of translation. *Excusar victorias del patrón* (§7), avoid victories over one's master, is Law 1. *Hacer depender* (§5), make others depend on you, is Law 11. *Hallarle su torcedor a cada uno* (§26), find each person's thumbscrew, is Law 33 in Gracián's own metaphor. *Sentir con los menos y hablar con los más* (§43), think with the few and speak with the many, is Law 38. *Llevar sus cosas con suspensión*

(§3), keep one's affairs in suspense, underlies Laws 3 and 17; *sin mentir, no decir todas las verdades* (§181), without lying, do not tell every truth, underlies Law 12. Most importantly for the present argument, Gracián's title designates the book an oracle—a hand-oracle, a portable divination—and its final aphorism, after three hundred lessons in worldly cunning, abruptly concludes: *En una palabra, santo*—in a word, a saint. The manual of prudence ends in sanctity. This terminal reversal, which may be called the *Gracián closure*, is the formal prototype of the anamorphic structure this dissertation attributes to Greene's corpus as a whole.

The French *moralistes* transformed the genre into a psychology. La Rochefoucauld's *Maximes* (1665), whose epigraph declares that our virtues are most often vices in disguise; La Bruyère's *Caractères* (1688), a typology of courtly character that prefigures Greene's taxonomies of seducers, victims, and personality types; the memoirs of the Cardinal de Retz and of Saint-Simon, the latter an ethnography of Versailles—these are the works in which the courtier becomes the first modern psychologist. Norbert Elias reconstructed the sociogenesis of that figure in *Die höfische Gesellschaft* (1969): the court, by making advancement dependent on the favor of a single sovereign and on the opinion of a dense network of rivals, compelled its inhabitants to observe one another with unprecedented attention, to read faces, to restrain affects, and to calculate the long-term consequences of every gesture. Elias's account of court rationality is the sociological key to the corpus. *The Laws of Human Nature* is the court's psychology generalized to the species.

The genre's modern history is a history of democratization and degradation. Lord Chesterfield's *Letters to His Son* (1774) carried courtly prudence into the bourgeois household. Frederick the Great's *Anti-Machiavel* (1740), edited by Voltaire and followed within months by the invasion of Silesia, exposed the gap between the denunciation of Machiavellianism and its practice. Balzac's Vautrin, in *Le Père Goriot* (1835), instructed Rastignac that there are no principles, only events, and no laws, only circumstances—an anti-law that haunts every subsequent attempt to legislate for fortune. Samuel Smiles's *Self-Help* (1859) and Dale Carnegie's *How to Win Friends and Influence People* (1936) recast the genre in the idioms of Victorian character and American salesmanship, the latter teaching, under a veneer of sincerity, the technique Greene would codify as the confirmation of the other's self-opinion. The postwar decades produced the immediate precursors: Antony Jay's *Management and Machiavelli* (1967), whose author would co-create *Yes Minister*, the finest comic anatomy of bureaucratic courtiership in any

medium; Richard Christie and Florence Geis's *Studies in Machiavellianism* (1970), which operationalized the Florentine's name as a personality construct measurable on the Mach-IV scale and thereby inaugurated the psychology that would later rebrand the cunning disposition as one corner of the "Dark Triad" (Paulhus and Williams 2002); Michael Korda's *Power! How to Get It, How to Use It* (1975); and Robert Cialdini's *Influence* (1984), the laboratory science of compliance to which Greene would supply a historical humanities.

Greene's intervention of 1998 thus arrived at a precise conjuncture: the dissolution of the Cold War's bipolar order, the dot-com expansion of entrepreneurial precarity, and the consolidation of what Foucault, in his lectures of 1978–79, had diagnosed as the neoliberal transformation of *homo economicus* into an "entrepreneur of himself." The court had been abolished as an institution and universalized as a condition. Every office had become a Versailles, every career a campaign, every self a brand; the subjects of this new and decentralized court required a manual. The final stage of the genealogy is still unfolding. Platform economies have converted Law 6, "Court Attention at All Costs," from a counsel of prudence into a business model; they have made *sprezzatura* the visual grammar of the curated feed; and they have produced, in recommender systems and persuasive language models, agents capable of executing the corpus's stratagems at a scale and speed no courtier could imagine. The genealogy that began with the vizier at the pharaoh's table thus arrives at what this dissertation calls the *algorithmic court*: a court without a visible sovereign, in which the favor that confers advancement is dispensed by opaque systems that observe, rank, and reward their subjects. Velázquez anticipated its structure in *Las Meninas* (1656), where the king and queen appear only as a reflection in a distant mirror—everywhere present as the organizing gaze of the scene, nowhere present as bodies within it.

The Anamorphic Skull: Statement of Thesis 1.6

In the National Gallery in London hangs a painting that may serve as the emblem of the corpus and of this dissertation. Hans Holbein the Younger's *The Ambassadors* (1533) presents two men of power and learning—Jean de Dinteville, French ambassador to the court of Henry VIII, and Georges de Selve, bishop of Lavaur—standing on either side of a two-tiered stand crowded with the instruments of worldly mastery. On the upper shelf lie the tools of the celestial sciences: a celestial globe,

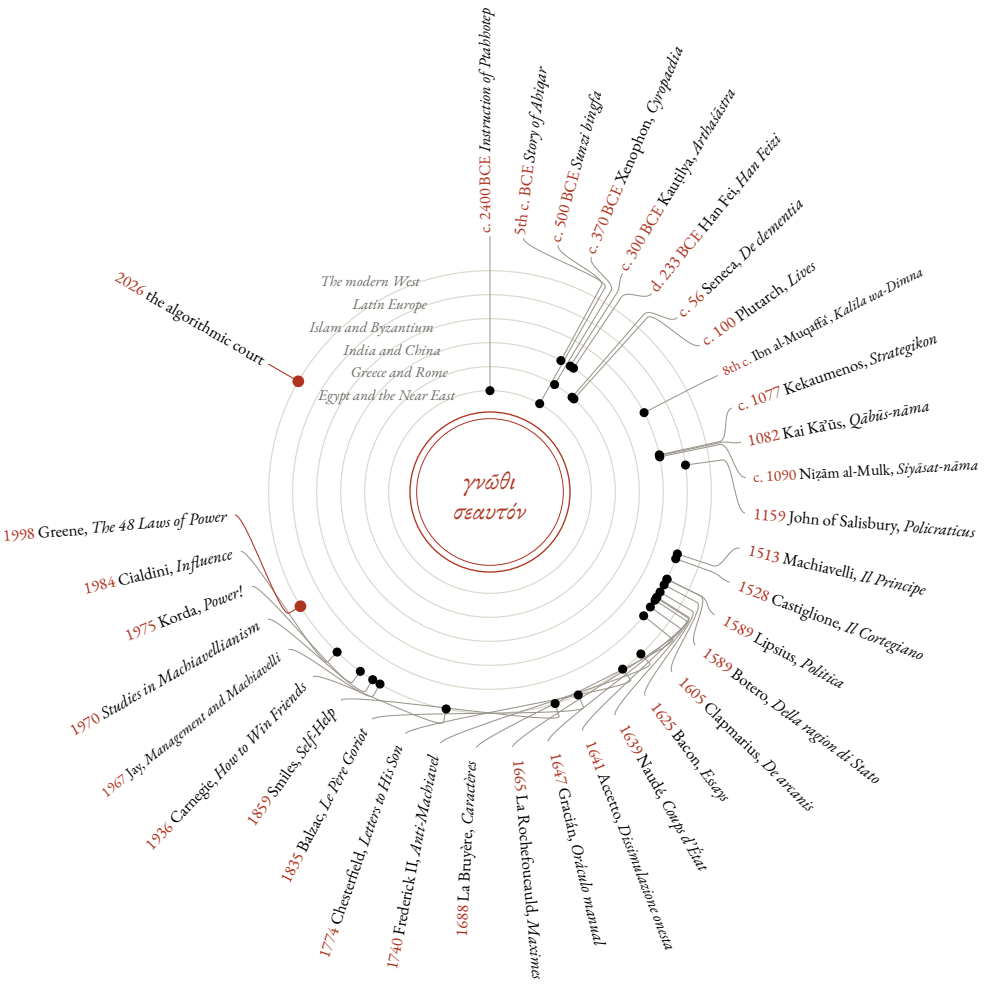
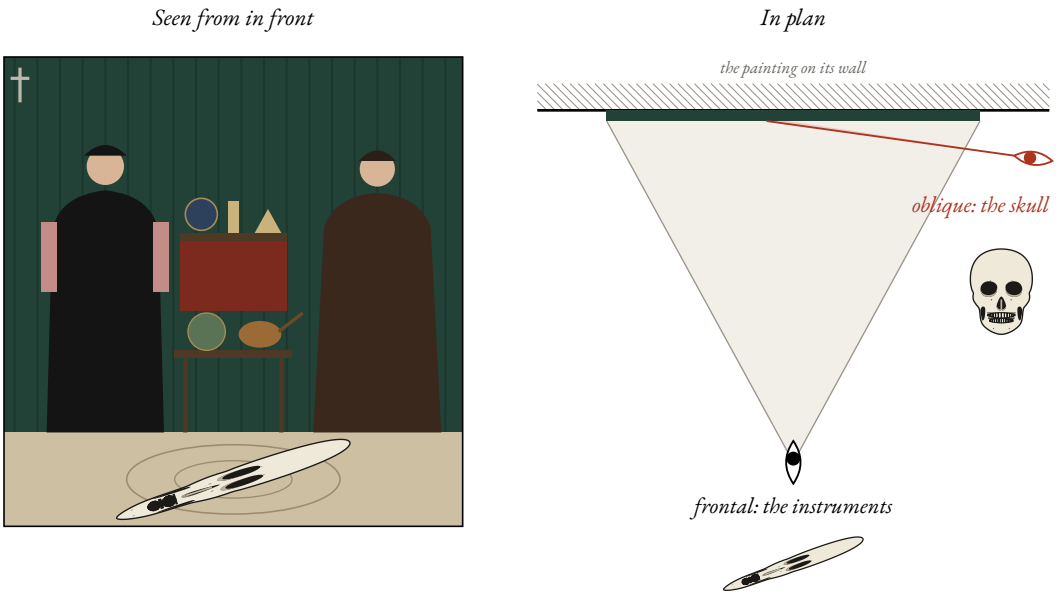


Fig. 1.3 *The dial of the genre.* Works named in §1.5, from the vizier's instruction to the algorithmic court, read clockwise from the top. The scale is logarithmic in years before 2026, so the remote centuries close up and the crowded modern ones open out; the rings separate traditions, and labels are spread where dates crowd. Dates are those the chapter gives, or conventional.

a cylindrical sundial, a polyhedral dial, a torquetum. On the lower shelf lie those of the terrestrial and social arts: a terrestrial globe, a merchant's arithmetic, a case of flutes, a Lutheran hymnal, and a lute with a broken string, long read as a sign of discord—religious, political, and harmonic. The painting is an inventory of the quadrivium, of diplomacy, of commerce, of music's power to move: an encyclopedia of the means by which



The two vantages. Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533) in plan. From in front, the instruments are in focus and the shape across the floor is a smear; from the side, near the plane of the picture, the smear contracts into a skull and the instruments dissolve (§1.6). *Fig. 1.4*

men act upon the world and upon one another. Across the floor, slanting between the two men, lies a pale, distorted shape that resists recognition from the frontal position. Only when the viewer moves to the side, nearly to the edge of the picture plane, and looks back across the canvas at a raking angle does the shape resolve into a human skull. In the upper left corner, half-concealed by the green damask curtain, hangs a small silver crucifix.

The composition is a complete theory of worldly knowledge and its limit. Viewed frontally, it celebrates the instruments of power; viewed obliquely, it is a *memento mori*; and the two views cannot be held at once. When the instruments are in focus, the skull is a smear; when the skull is in focus, the instruments dissolve. The crucifix sits at the margin of both views, legible from either position and central to neither: the transcendent as the edge of the frame. Jurgis Baltrušaitis, in his classic study of anamorphosis, and Jacques Lacan, in the eleventh seminar, both recognized in the painting a demonstration that the subject who masters the world through sight is himself captured by a gaze he cannot master. The skull marks the point at which the viewer's position of command is revealed as a position of mortality.

This dissertation argues that the corpus of Robert Greene possesses the architecture of *The Ambassadors*. Read frontally—in the order of its fame and publication, and in the posture of the ambitious reader in search of instruments—it is an encyclopedia of the means of worldly mastery: the laws of power arrayed like the instruments on Holbein's shelves, the arts of seduction like the lute, the strategies of war like the torquetum's calculations. Read obliquely—from the vantage of its terminal texts, which require the reader to step to the side of his own ambitions—it resolves into a discipline of mortality and self-knowledge, with the sublime hanging, like Holbein's crucifix, at the edge of every view, until *The Law of the Sublime* moves it to the center. The thesis is articulated in three propositions and one critical corollary.

Proposition I: structural

The first proposition is structural: the corpus is anamorphic. Its meaning depends on the position from which it is read, and the two principal positions yield incompatible images. The frontal reading—the reading that has made *The 48 Laws* a forbidden book in prisons and a cult object in boardrooms—is not a misreading; it is one of the two images the corpus contains. But it is a partial image, and the corpus itself, through its terminal positions and its progressive internalization of the adversary, supplies the instructions for the lateral step that reveals the other. La Rochefoucauld furnishes the epistemological warrant for this structure in his twenty-sixth maxim: *le soleil ni la mort ne se peuvent regarder fixement*—neither the sun nor death can be looked at steadily. If death cannot be contemplated frontally, it can be approached only obliquely; and a pedagogy of mortality that sought to reach readers who flee the contemplation of death would have to begin by facing in another direction entirely. The corpus begins with power because power is what its reader is willing to look at.

Proposition II: rhetorical and ethical

The second proposition is rhetorical and ethical: the anamorphosis functions as an indirect pedagogy. Its closest analogues are four. In *The Point of View for My Work as an Author*, Søren Kierkegaard explained that his pseudonymous aesthetic writings—beginning with *Either/Or*, which contains the "Diary of the Seducer" that Greene would later anatomize—were designed to meet the reader where he lived, in the aesthetic, in order to deceive him into the truth; an illusion, Kierkegaard argued, can never be removed directly, since direct opposition merely confirms it. In the Mahāyāna tradition, *upāya-kauśalya*, skill in means, names the bodhisattva's art of adapting teaching to the capacities and desires of the taught; the third chapter of the *Lotus Sūtra* tells of a father who, unable to persuade his children to leave a burning house by warning them of

the fire, lures them out with the promise of the carts they crave and then bestows a gift greater than any they had desired. Ovid followed the *Ars amatoria* with the *Remedia amoris*, prescribing the cure for the passion his earlier book had taught readers to inflame. And Plato's Socrates, in the *Phaedrus*, having delivered with covered head a speech in praise of the calculating non-lover, uncovers his head to deliver a palinode—modeled on Stesichorus's recantation of his slander of Helen—in which erotic madness is revealed as the soul's ascent toward the beautiful (*Phaedrus* 237a–257b). The corpus, on this reading, is a *Machiavellian upāya*. It uses the reader's appetite for power as the cart that lures him from the burning house, and its terminal texts are the palinode the agonistic triptych requires. The reader who arrives for the instruments stays for the skull.

Proposition III: conceptual

The third proposition is conceptual: the terminus of the pedagogy is an experience this dissertation names the *metic sublime*. The term joins two genealogies that the history of ideas has kept apart. *Mētis*, in Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant's reconstruction (*Les Ruses de l'intelligence*, 1974), names the cunning intelligence that archaic Greek thought attributed to the fox and the octopus, to the hunter's snare and the fisherman's net, to the pilot reading wind and current, to Odysseus *polytropos*, the man of many turns, and to the goddess Metis herself, whom Zeus swallowed so that her cunning could never again be turned against his sovereignty, and from whose absorption Athena—wisdom in armor—was born (Hesiod, *Theogony* 886–900). *Mētis* is polymorphic and anticipatory, oriented toward the *kairos*, the opportune moment; it operates in situations too fluid for rules; it is the intelligence of the weaker party who must overcome the stronger by indirection. Detienne and Vernant argued that philosophy, from Plato onward, suppressed *mētis* in favor of a knowledge of stable essences, so that cunning intelligence survived in practice but never in theory. Greene's corpus is, among other things, the largest modern attempt to theorize *mētis*: to render explicit the cunning intelligence of the courtier, the seducer, the general, and the craftsman.

The sublime, from Longinus's *Peri hupsous* through Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) and Kant's *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790), names the experience of a magnitude or might that overwhelms the faculties of representation and resistance—the mountain, the ocean, the storm—and produces a compound of terror and exaltation. In Kant's account the dynamical sublime ultimately reasserts the supremacy of reason: the subject discovers within himself a supersensible vocation superior to

the nature that threatens him. The metic sublime departs from both antecedents. Its object is not nature but the social-historical field: the totality of forces, interests, passions, and contingencies that the strategist has spent his life learning to read, and which, at the limit of his reading, reveals itself as vaster than any strategy—Machiavelli's *fortuna*, Sun Tzu's *shi*, Clausewitz's friction, the "human nature" of Greene's anthropology, and, encompassing them all, mortality. Its terminus is not the triumph of reason but its humbling: the strategist, having mastered the art of reading the field, finally reads himself within it as one minor and transient configuration of forces among countless others. The metic sublime is the experience in which the will to power, pursued to the end of its own logic, discovers its own contingency—the moment at which cunning becomes contemplation. Caspar David Friedrich's *Wanderer above the Sea of Fog* (c. 1818) supplies its iconography: the figure who has climbed to the summit in order to command the view, and who discovers, from the very height the Law of Shortsightedness enjoins him to seek, that the view commands him. *The Law of the Sublime* names the destination; the metic sublime names the route by which a strategist's corpus must arrive there, and the specific character the sublime acquires when it is reached through cunning rather than through contemplation alone.

Corollary

These propositions entail a critical corollary that prevents the thesis from collapsing into apologetics. Anamorphosis is unstable. It depends on a viewer willing to take the lateral step, and nothing in the frontal image compels that step. The corpus therefore contains, as a structural possibility, its own arrested reading: the reader who takes the cart and stays in the burning house, who masters the instruments and never sees the skull. Such readers are not merely misreaders; they are produced by the very seductiveness that makes the indirect pedagogy possible. The instability is visible even at the threshold of the corpus's explicit turn toward transcendence, where the publisher's description of *The Law of the Sublime* promises a guide "to master the power of the Sublime" (Penguin Random House)—the vocabulary of command persisting at the very point of its prospective dissolution. The corpus is in this sense a *pharmakon* in the double meaning Derrida drew from the *Phaedrus*: a remedy and a poison that are one substance, distinguished only by dosage, by sequence, and by the discipline of the one who administers it to himself.

Method: Triangulated Genealogy

The corpus's own method is inductive and exemplary. Greene derives laws from historical narratives in the tradition Machiavelli formulated when he wrote that whoever would foresee what must be should consider what has been, since the affairs of the world in every age find their counterparts in ancient times (*Discorsi* III.43). The method is vulnerable to the objection Guicciardini raised against it—that circumstances never fully recur, and that the example abstracted from its context deceives as often as it instructs—and to the more modern objection of survivorship: the exemplary method selects its evidence after the fact, presenting the victors as though their success demonstrated the efficacy of their techniques. A critical reading of the corpus cannot simply adopt its method; it must test it.

The dissertation therefore practices what it calls *triangulated genealogy*. Each major doctrine of the corpus is located at the intersection of three bodies of evidence, of which Greene's historical exempla constitute only one. The second is myth, understood not as primitive error but, in the tradition of Dumézil, Lévi-Strauss, Detienne, and Vernant, as a compressed, transgenerational theorization of social structure—the archetypal form in which a culture stores its knowledge of recurrent situations. If a Greenean law corresponds to a widely distributed mythic pattern—if "Discover Each Man's Thumbscrew" (Law 33) is anticipated by Delilah's extraction of the secret of Samson's strength, by the unprotected heel of Achilles, by the linden leaf that fell between Siegfried's shoulders and the fatal confidence in which Kriemhild revealed the spot to Hagen—then the law acquires a warrant independent of any single anecdote, since myth records not what happened once but what happens always.

The third body of evidence is speculative fiction, understood here as the counterfactual laboratory of the sapiential tradition. Where Greene reasons inductively from history to laws, speculative fiction reasons deductively from laws to worlds: it posits a principle of human behavior, imagines a world in which that principle operates without the friction of ordinary circumstance, and observes the consequences. Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* sequence posits laws of collective behavior so rigorous that the future of a galactic civilization can be computed statistically—and then introduces the Mule, a mutant whose power to manipulate the emotions of others shatters the predictive science, as though to demonstrate that the charismatic seducer is the singularity every science of human na-

ture must fail to anticipate. Frank Herbert's *Dune* imagines the Missionaria Protectiva, an order that seeds superstitions across worlds centuries in advance so that its agents may later exploit them—Law 27, "Play on People's Need to Believe to Create a Cultlike Following," executed on a civilizational timescale—and then devotes its sequels to the catastrophe that follows when a messiah fashioned from those legends finds that he cannot halt the holy war his legend has unleashed. Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008) imagines a humanity whose every utterance and document lies open to an alien adversary, and whose only remaining secret is the interior of the individual mind. Its response, the Wallfacer Project, grants four individuals vast resources and the sanctioned right to deceive the entire species, since a strategy that is spoken is a strategy already lost. Law 3, "Conceal Your Intentions," is here elevated into the founding principle of an institution, and the novel's "cosmic sociology"—whose axioms posit survival as the primary need of every civilization and the finitude of matter against the unbounded growth of civilizations—is a Hobbesian anthropology extrapolated to the galaxy, yielding a universe in which every civilization must hide and every visible civilization must be destroyed.

Triangulation is not a device for confirming Greene; it is equally a device for falsifying him. Where history, myth, and counterfactual fiction converge on a pattern, the dissertation treats the corresponding law as a genuine regularity of social life. Where they diverge—where the myth punishes what the law recommends, or where speculative fiction reveals that the law, followed consistently, destroys the world it was meant to master—the divergence is treated as diagnostic of the law's limits, and frequently as an anticipation of the corpus's own later revisions. The method thus reproduces, at the level of the dissertation, the structure of the Greenean law itself: exemplum, authority, image, and reversal.

The comparative field is deliberately transmedial. The sapiential tradition has never been confined to the book; it has lived in the oracle's utterance, the emblem's engraving, the court masque, and the opera, and in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries in cinema, serialized television, the graphic novel, popular music, and the digital game. These media are not illustrations of ideas formulated elsewhere; they are sites in which the tradition continues to think. Mozart and Da Ponte's *Don Giovanni* (1787), whose servant Leporello catalogues his master's conquests by nation—*mille e tre* in Spain alone—is a meditation on the seducer as accountant that no treatise has surpassed. Lieutenant Columbo, who for decades disarmed murderers by performing incompetence, is a sustained televisual

essay on Law 21, "Play a Sucker to Catch a Sucker." Sir Humphrey Appleby of *Yes Minister* is the definitive portrait of the courtier who rules by appearing to serve. The grand-strategy game *Crusader Kings III* (2020) simulates dynastic court politics through mechanics that formalize the corpus with uncanny literalness: its schemes to seduce, sway, or murder, and above all its "hooks"—secrets or favors held over another character and redeemable for compliance—are Gracián's *torcedor* and Greene's thumbscrew rendered as code. *Disco Elysium* (2019) externalizes the divided psyche of *The Laws of Human Nature* as a parliament of skills that address the player as competing inner voices—Authority, Suggestion, Drama, Empathy, Half Light—so that the struggle between the primitive and the rational selves becomes the very substance of play. And *BioShock* (2007), which reveals in its central twist that the player's every action has been steered by a courteous verbal trigger, offers the purest allegory of the indirect pedagogy itself: the medium in which the subject discovers, too late, that the text which seemed to teach him the arts of manipulation had been manipulating him throughout. These works are read throughout the dissertation as interlocutors, not as decorative parallels.

The Pharmakon *and the Arrested Reader: Ethics of the Inquiry* 1.8

An inquiry into a body of work that openly teaches deception must declare its ethical posture, and must do so without the two evasions that have characterized most commentary: the moralism that refuses to describe what it condemns, and the aestheticism that describes without judging. The dissertation takes as its guide the position Isaiah Berlin attributed to Machiavelli in "The Originality of Machiavelli" (1972): that the Florentine's scandal lay not in advocating evil but in revealing that the ends of human life are plural and potentially incompatible —that the pagan *virtù* which founds and preserves states cannot be reconciled with the Christian virtues of humility and mercy, and that one must choose without the consolation of a single overarching standard. Greene's corpus inherits this pluralism in an unacknowledged form. Its early laws presuppose ends—security, advancement, influence, victory —whose legitimacy they neither defend nor question; its late books introduce, without retracting the early ones, ends of a different order—empathy, self-knowledge, equanimity before death, wonder—that stand in unresolved tension with them. The reader is left in the situation Berlin

described: compelled to choose among goods, without an authority that chooses for him.

Max Weber's distinction, in "Politik als Beruf," between the ethic of conviction (*Gesinnungsethik*) and the ethic of responsibility (*Verantwortungsethik*) supplies a second coordinate. The ethic of responsibility, which Weber held indispensable to anyone who takes up politics as a vocation, accepts that good ends may require morally dangerous means, and that whoever wields power enters into a relationship with diabolical powers for whose consequences he must answer. Greene's early books are, in Weber's terms, technical manuals of means abstracted from any ethic of ends; his late books attempt, belatedly and incompletely, to supply the character from which a responsible use of means might proceed. The dissertation's evaluative question is therefore not whether the corpus is moral—it plainly declines the vocabulary of morality—but whether its architecture can produce the kind of subject capable of bearing the knowledge it transmits.

The reception history suggests that the answer depends on the reader's trajectory through the corpus. Three interpretive communities, in Stanley Fish's sense, can be distinguished. The first consists of *instrumental readers*, who approach the corpus as a toolkit, extract techniques, and remain within the frontal image; for them the books are a grimoire and their author a magus. The second consists of *defensive readers*, who approach the corpus as a field guide to the manipulations practiced upon them, and for whom it functions, in the terms of William McGuire's inoculation theory of persuasion (1961), as a vaccine: exposure to a weakened form of a manipulative appeal, together with its anatomy, confers resistance to the appeal at full strength. A substantial share of the corpus's readers —plausibly including many of the incarcerated readers from whom it has been withheld—belong to this community, for whom knowledge of the stratagems of the powerful is a condition of survival among them. The third consists of *anamorphic readers*, who traverse the corpus to its terminus and discover that the instruments they sought were the frame of a different picture. These communities are not fixed populations but stages, and the same reader may pass through all three—or halt permanently at the first.

The halt at the first stage defines the *arrested reader*, the corpus's characteristic danger. The online appropriation of *The Art of Seduction* as a manual of sexual conquest offers the clearest case, and it is instructive precisely because the appropriation requires the suppression of much of the book's text. Greene's gallery of seducers gives a prominent

place to women—Cleopatra, Josephine Bonaparte, Ninon de Lenclos, Lou Andreas-Salomé, Marilyn Monroe—and his Dandy is defined by the deliberate confusion of gender norms; his psychology of desire is drawn from Stendhal and Kierkegaard, whose works are, respectively, a phenomenology of the lover's self-deception and a demonstration that the aesthetic seducer ends in despair. A structurally identical irony attends the cinematic emblem the same subcultures adopted: the "red pill" of *The Matrix* (1999), which one of its directors would later confirm had been conceived within an allegory of transgender self-transformation, was captured as a symbol of rigid gender essentialism—an awakening to self-recreation converted into an awakening to domination. Both captures exemplify a single mechanism: the extraction of the frontal image from an anamorphic whole, the seizure of the instruments without the skull.

The dissertation does not claim that the corpus is innocent of its arrested readings. Its central critical argument is that the corpus solicits them. The seductiveness that allows the indirect pedagogy to capture readers who would never open a treatise on mortality also allows the pedagogy to fail at its first stage, delivering the cart and withholding the gift. The *upāya* is a dangerous means: the Mahāyāna tradition always insisted that skillful means required a skillful teacher, and that expedience divorced from the wisdom (*prajñā*) that guides it degenerates into mere manipulation. A book has no teacher. It cannot observe its reader's trajectory, adjust the dosage, or intervene when the reader halts. This is the deepest form of the critique that Plato's Socrates directed at writing itself: that the written word, once released, rolls about indiscriminately among those who understand it and those who have no business with it, unable to defend itself or to choose its readers (*Phaedrus* 275d–e). The ethical wager of this dissertation is that criticism can partly supply what the book lacks: a guide to the lateral step.

Architecture of the Dissertation 1.9

Chapter Two, "Arcana for the Multitude," reconstructs the genealogy of *The 48 Laws of Power* through the literature of courtly reason—Machiavelli, the Tacitists, Gracián, La Rochefoucauld, Hobbes, Nietzsche—and argues that the book's fundamental gesture is the publication of the *arcana imperii*: the conversion of the secret knowledge of courts into a mass-market commodity. Following Rousseau's reading of *Il Principe* as a book that, while pretending to instruct kings, instructed peoples (*Du*

contrat social III.6), the chapter asks what becomes of esoteric knowledge when it is made exoteric, situates the book within the court without a king of neoliberal sociality, and tests its laws against the courts of Shakespeare (Richard III, Iago, Coriolanus), of *Kalīla wa-Dimna* and the *Roman de Renart*, of Herbert's Arrakis and Martin's Westeros, and of the twentieth-century cinema of ascent (*The Godfather*, *All About Eve*).

Chapter Three, "*Militat Omnis Amans*," takes its title from Ovid's declaration that every lover is a soldier (*Amores* 1.9.1) and reads *The Art of Seduction* as the hinge between the corpus's theory of power and its theory of war. It traces the book's sources through Ovid, Andreas Capellanus, the *Roman de la Rose*, the *Kāmasūtra*, the *Tale of Genji*, Laclos, Stendhal, and Kierkegaard; reconstructs its implicit psychology through Freudian transference, Girard's mimetic triangle, Simmel's analysis of coquetry, and Lacan's *objet petit a*; and confronts its doctrine of mass, or "soft," seduction with Bernays, Debord, Baudrillard, and Byung-Chul Han's theory of neoliberal "smart power." Its comparative field extends from Homer's Sirens to Hitchcock's *Vertigo* and Garland's *Ex Machina*. The chapter argues that the book is the first installment of the corpus's own palinode, since its theory of seduction already contains, in the figure of the reader seduced by the text, the mechanism of the indirect pedagogy.

Chapter Four, "*Polemos Pantōn Patēr*," reads *The 33 Strategies of War* and *The 50th Law* through Heraclitus's dictum that war is the father of all things (DK 22 B53), the lineage of Sun Tzu, Clausewitz, Liddell Hart, and Boyd, Schelling's theory of commitment, and Carl Schmitt's friend–enemy distinction, before turning to Foucault's inversion of Clausewitz —politics as the continuation of war by other means—as the hidden premise of Greene's claim that social life is war. It interrogates that premise through Lakoff and Johnson's analysis of ARGUMENT IS WAR as a constitutive metaphor, and through the epics that complicate it: the *Iliad*, the *Mahābhārata* and the *Bhagavad Gītā*, the *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*. *The 50th Law*'s synthesis of street ethos, Stoicism, and the *Hagakure* is read alongside Jarmusch's *Ghost Dog*, the Wu-Tang Clan's martial esotericism, and Frederick Douglass's account of his fight with Covey as a genealogy of fearlessness. Its speculative interlocutors include *Ender's Game*, *Legend of the Galactic Heroes*, and Liu Cixin's doctrine of deterrence.

Chapter Five, "The Knife of Cook Ding," reads *Mastery* as the corpus's turn from *mētis* as cunning to *mētis* as craft, through Aristotle's *technē* and *phronēsis*, Polanyi's tacit knowledge, the Dreyfus model of skill acquisition, Ericsson's deliberate practice, Csikszentmihalyi's flow,

Sennett's craftsman, Goethe's *Bildung*, and the Daoist parables of Cook Ding and Wheelwright Bian—the latter of which, insisting that the essence of skill cannot be transmitted in words, poses the paradox of a book that teaches mastery. The chapter examines *Mastery*'s mentor dynamic through the *Star Wars* saga, *Whiplash*, and *Amadeus*, and closes by asking what becomes of Greene's model of apprenticeship after AlphaGo's thirty-seventh move against Lee Sedol in 2016 and the subsequent generalization of machine expertise.

Chapter Six, "The Shadow and the Skull," reads *The Laws of Human Nature* as summa and palinode, reconstructing its debts to Jung's shadow, persona, anima, and animus, to Kohut's self psychology, Melanie Klein's theory of envy, Le Bon's and Canetti's crowds, and Heidegger's analyses of *das Man* and being-toward-death, while identifying in Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) the key to the corpus's late reinterpretation of the will to power as a flight from mortality. Its comparative field includes Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea*, Lem's *Solaris*, Tarkovsky's *Stalker*, the hedgehog's dilemma of *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, Tolstoy's *The Death of Ivan Ilyich*—the great counter-text to every manual of advancement—and the fall of Anakin Skywalker, whose seduction by the promise of power over death dramatizes the dissertation's claim that grandiosity is death denial in strategic form.

Chapter Seven, "The Metic Sublime," gathers these findings into a theory. It formalizes the metic sublime against its Longinian, Burkean, Kantian, and religious antecedents; reads *The Law of the Sublime* as the corpus's explicit terminus and the hinge of its fourth movement; rereads the architecture of the corpus through Georges Dumézil's trifunctional ideology—sovereignty, force, and fecundity, mapped onto power, war, and seduction—and N. J. Allen's proposed fourth function of transcendence and otherness, which the late books occupy; and returns to the Gracián closure, in which the manual of prudence ends in sanctity. It concludes by assessing the corpus's double status in the algorithmic court, as courtier's manual and as inoculation, and by proposing *reading backward from the skull* as the hermeneutic discipline through which the *pharmakon* may be administered as a remedy.

The wager of the dissertation is that Greene's corpus, read in its totality and against the full depth of the traditions it inherits, possesses a significance its author's fame has obscured. It is the site where the oldest genre of practical wisdom—the counsel of the courtier, the stratagem of the general, the craft of the seducer—meets the oldest question of contemplative wisdom: what any of it is worth in the light of death. The genre

has always known that this question waited at its end. The Delphic sentences culminate in self-knowledge, which the Greeks understood as the knowledge that one is mortal; Gracián's aphorisms culminate in sanctity; Hobbes's perpetual and restless desire of power after power ceases only in death (*Leviathan* I.11). What distinguishes Greene's corpus is that it stages the encounter at the scale of a body of work, in the sequence of a reader's life, across nearly three decades of publication, beginning with forty-eight laws of power and ending with a single law of the sublime. To read it frontally is to learn to win. To read it obliquely is to learn what winning is for. The chapters that follow attempt both readings and, at the last, the step between them.

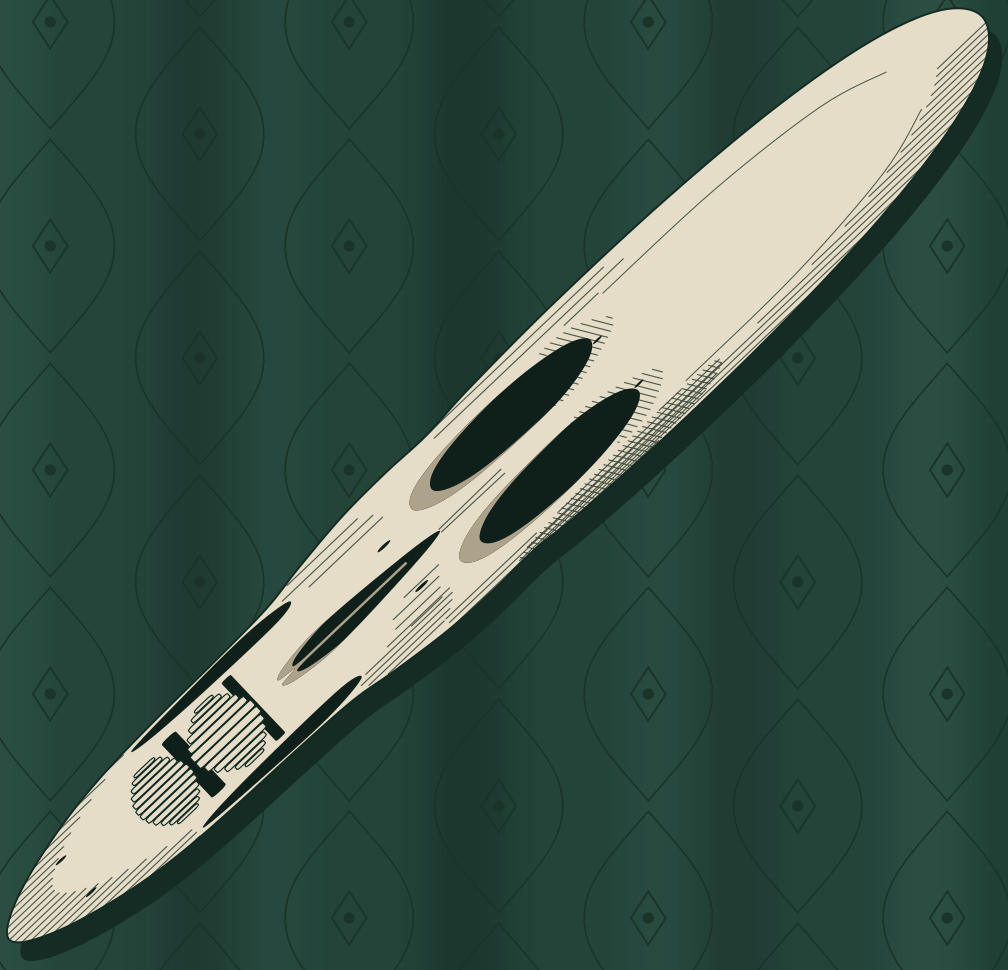


Plate II. *Stretched 5.6 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 10° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER TWO

Arcana for the Multitude

The 48 Laws of Power and the Genealogy of Courtly Reason

Evulgato imperii arcano, posse principem alibi quam Romae fieri.
— Tacitus, *Historiae* 1.4

En feignant de donner des leçons aux rois il en a donné de grandes aux peuples.
— Rousseau, *Du contrat social* III.6

Reputation of power, is Power.
— Hobbes, *Leviathan* I.10

2.1 *The Published Secret:* Arcana Imperii *and the Paradox of Exoteric Cunning*

In the first book of the *Histories*, narrating the collapse that followed Nero's death, Tacitus identifies the moment at which the Principate's founding secret escaped: *evulgato imperii arcano*, the secret of empire having been divulged—namely, that an emperor could be made elsewhere than at Rome (*Hist.* 1.4). The secret was not a fact unknown to the senatorial elite; it was a fact whose non-publication had sustained the order. Once the legions grasped that they, too, could make emperors, they made four in a single year. Tacitus's sentence contains *in nuce* the problem of this chapter. Certain kinds of knowledge about power are not merely descriptions of power but components of it; their circulation alters the phenomenon they describe; and a political order may depend less on what is secret than on what is left unsaid.

Early modern political theory converted the phrase into a doctrine. Arnold Clapmarius, in *De arcanis rerumpublicarum* (1605), distinguished the *arcana imperii*, the hidden means by which a form of state preserves itself, from the *arcana dominationis*, the hidden means by which rulers preserve their own persons and positions, and gave the name *simulacra* to the semblances of liberty—ceremonial magistracies, empty assemblies, the outward forms of consent—by which subjects are contented without being empowered. James I, addressing the Star Chamber in 1616, forbade his subjects to dispute "the mystery of the King's power," and Ernst Kantorowicz traced, in "Mysteries of State" (1955), the absolutist sacralization of political secrecy to the transfer of the theological *mysterium* into the vocabulary of the crown. The arcanum was the political analogue of the sacrament: efficacious because withheld. Georg Simmel's sociology of secrecy (1908) explains the mechanism. The secret creates a second world alongside the manifest one; its possessor enjoys a power proportionate to the tension between the two; and that tension discharges in the moment of revelation, after which the secret's power is spent. Elias Canetti, in *Masse und Macht* (1960), placed secrecy at the very core of power and portrayed the despot as the one who sees through all others while remaining himself impenetrable.

The 48 Laws of Power publishes the *arcana dominationis* to a mass readership. That act is the book's fundamental gesture and the source of its scandal, and it is paradoxical in a precise sense. A large proportion of the laws are laws of secrecy—"Conceal Your Intentions" (3), "Always Say Less Than Necessary" (4), "Pose as a Friend, Work as a Spy" (14),

"Think as You Like but Behave Like Others" (38)—and a law of secrecy published to millions is, on its face, self-defeating. If every reader knows that the friend may be a spy, friendship becomes a suspect performance; if every reader knows that selective generosity disarms (12), every gift becomes legible as a stratagem. The book's success thus produces a reflexive effect familiar to economists as the Lucas critique and to sociologists as Campbell's law: a behavioral regularity that is published and acted upon ceases to behave as it did when it was merely observed. Greene's laws, once common knowledge, do not simply arm their readers; they alter the field on which their readers compete.

Three classical readings of the published arcanum may be distinguished, and *The 48 Laws* invites all three. The *princely* reading takes the text at its word, as a manual for those who would rule. The *republican* reading was formulated by Spinoza, who suggested that the "most acute" Machiavelli may have wished to show a free multitude how dangerous it is to entrust its welfare to a single man (*Tractatus politicus* V.7); by Rousseau, who declared that Machiavelli, while pretending to instruct kings, had given great lessons to peoples, so that the *Prince* is the book of republicans (*Du contrat social* III.6); and by Ugo Foscolo, who honored the Florentine in *Dei sepolcri* (1807) as the one who, tempering the scepter for rulers, strips it of its laurels and *alle genti svela / di che lagrime grondi e di che sangue*—reveals to the peoples with what tears it drips, and with what blood. On this reading, publication is emancipation: stratagems made visible lose their efficacy against those who can now recognize them. The *esoteric* reading was developed by Leo Strauss, who argued in *Persecution and the Art of Writing* (1952) and *Thoughts on Machiavelli* (1958) that writers under persecution communicated their genuine teaching between the lines, reserving it for attentive readers behind a surface acceptable to the many.

Greene's case adds a fourth reading that none of the classical interpreters could have anticipated, because it presupposes a social form that did not yet exist. *The 48 Laws* is addressed neither to the prince nor to the people but to a "you" that occupies both positions at once. Law 1 addresses its reader as a subordinate who must never outshine the master; Law 34 addresses the same reader as a sovereign who must act like a king to be treated like one; Law 11 instructs him to make others dependent on him, while Law 20 forbids him ever to bind himself. The double address is not inconsistency. It is the grammatical trace of a world in which every subject is simultaneously sovereign and courtier—master of a micro-court of subordinates, clients, and followers, and supplicant

before a macro-court of employers, markets, and platforms. The arcana are not published to a people confronting a prince; they are sold to each individual as the prince of his own career. This dissertation names the resulting doctrine the *reason of self*: the transposition of *ragion di Stato*, which justified extraordinary means for the preservation of the polity, onto the preservation and aggrandizement of the individual life.

The reason of self carries an unforeseen consequence. When the arcana circulate universally, their primary utility shifts from offense to recognition. The reader who has learned Law 14 is less likely to succeed as a spy than to detect one; the reader who has learned Law 32 is less likely to exploit another's fantasies than to notice his own being exploited. The primatologists Richard Byrne and Andrew Whiten, proposing the Machiavellian intelligence hypothesis (1988), argued that primate intelligence evolved largely under the pressure of social competition, in an arms race in which every refinement of deception selected for a refinement of detection. A manual of deception published to millions intervenes in exactly that arms race, and its net effect is to raise the general level of social literacy. Esoteric knowledge made exoteric becomes a defensive literacy —the inoculation described in Chapter One—and its most sophisticated readers are driven, by the logic of recognition itself, toward a knowledge of the mechanisms of manipulation that is finally indistinguishable from self-knowledge. The arcanum, once published, turns inward. That inward turn is the first movement of the anamorphosis.

2.2 *The Effectual Truth: Machiavelli,* Fortuna*, and the Privatization of Reason of State*

Machiavelli is the corpus's presiding ancestor, and the relation is one of inheritance and inversion at once. The inheritance is methodological. In the fifteenth chapter of *Il Principe*, Machiavelli announced his departure from the mirrors for princes: many had imagined republics and principalities never seen or known to exist, but it seemed to him more fitting to go after the effectual truth of the thing than the imagination of it (*andare drieto alla verità effettuale della cosa che alla immaginazione di essa*), since the distance between how one lives and how one ought to live is so great that whoever abandons what is done for what ought to be done learns his ruin rather than his preservation. Greene's insistence that his laws describe power as it operates, rather than as moralists wish it would, transposes this programmatic sentence into the preface of a

popular book. The inheritance extends to Machiavelli's anthropology of appearance: "everyone sees what you appear to be, few touch what you are" (*ognuno vede quello che tu pari, pochi sentono quello che tu se'*; *Principe* XVIII), a sentence that contains in germ the entire economy of visibility that Greene's laws regulate.

It extends, too, to Machiavelli's theater of violence. The locus classicus of Law 26, "Keep Your Hands Clean," and of Law 37, "Create Compelling Spectacles," is the seventh chapter of *Il Principe*. Cesare Borgia, having pacified the Romagna through the cruelty of his lieutenant Remirro de Orco, has Remirro's body displayed one morning in the piazza at Cesena, cut in two, with a block of wood and a bloody knife beside it—a spectacle that left the people, in Machiavelli's untranslatable phrase, *satisfatti e stupidi*, at once satisfied and stupefied. The episode joins three Greenean techniques in a single gesture: the delegation of odium to an instrument, the subsequent sacrifice of the instrument, and the conversion of the sacrifice into theater. It also exhibits the epistemology of spectacle that the corpus everywhere presupposes: the multitude judges by what it sees, and whoever controls the visible controls judgment.

The inversion is teleological. Machiavelli's object is *lo stato*—the polity, its founding, its orders, its liberty, its preservation across generations—and the *virtù* he celebrates is, in its highest form, the founder's capacity to impose form upon matter: Moses, Cyrus, Romulus, Theseus (*Principe* VI). Even the *Prince*, whatever its esoteric intentions, closes with an exhortation to liberate Italy from the barbarians, and the *Discorsi* devote three books to the conditions under which a free people may govern itself. Greene's corpus retains the means and discards the end. Its object is not the state but the career; its horizon is not the founding of orders but the security and aggrandizement of the individual; its *virtù* is not civic but private. The privatization of reason of state—the reason of self—is the defining operation by which the Machiavellian tradition was adapted to the conditions of late-twentieth-century individualism.

Yet the most important Machiavellian inheritance in the corpus lies not in any law Greene explicitly derives from the Florentine but in a problem Machiavelli posed and could not solve. In a letter of September 1506 to Giovan Battista Soderini—the so-called *Ghiribizzi*, or "whims"—Machiavelli observed that men succeed by opposite methods, the cautious and the impetuous, the cruel and the humane, and concluded that success depends on matching one's mode of proceeding to the quality of the times. The twenty-fifth chapter of *Il Principe* develops the observation into a theory of fortune. Fortune is like a violent river that floods

the plain, against which prudent men build dikes and embankments in quiet times; the prince who prospers is the one whose manner of acting accords with the times. But no man, Machiavelli adds, is prudent enough to adapt himself, both because he cannot deviate from that to which nature inclines him and because, having always prospered by one path, he cannot be persuaded to leave it. Hence the ruin of the fortunate. The *Discorsi* (III.9) supply the republican solution: Rome flourished because a republic, containing citizens of diverse temperaments, could deploy the cautious Fabius when caution was required and the audacious Scipio when audacity was. A republic can change its men as the times change; an individual cannot change his nature.

Read against this problem, the final law of *The 48 Laws*—"Assume Formlessness"—acquires its full significance. Formlessness is the attempt to solve, within a single individual, the problem Machiavelli believed only a republic could solve: to become as various as the times, to contain Fabius and Scipio within one character, to cease to possess a nature that fortune can turn against its bearer. The formless strategist is a republic of one. But Machiavelli's skepticism raises a question the corpus would spend two decades answering. If the inability to change one's nature is the cause of ruin, and if nature is precisely what will cannot alter, then formlessness requires something other than strategy: a transformation of the self that strategy can describe but not effect. *Mastery*'s theory of apprenticeship, *The Laws of Human Nature*'s discipline of self-observation, and *The Law of the Sublime*'s announced program of perceptual renewal may each be read as successive attempts to supply the transformation that Law 48 demands and cannot itself accomplish. The last law of the first book poses the problem whose solution requires the rest of the corpus.

The corpus inherits, finally, Machiavelli's most notorious figure, and with it a debt that Chapter Three must pay. Fortune is a woman, Machiavelli concludes, and whoever wishes to hold her down must beat her and strike her (*la fortuna è donna, ed è necessario, volendola tenere sotto, batterla e urtarla*); she is, he adds, the friend of the young, who are less cautious and command her with greater audacity. The gendering of contingency as a female body to be mastered by force is not incidental to the Machiavellian tradition. It binds its theory of action to a theory of seduction and conquest, from which the Greene corpus inherits both *The Art of Seduction* and its most troubling readers. Hanna Pitkin's *Fortune Is a Woman* (1984) remains the indispensable analysis of that nexus, and the dissertation returns to it in reading the erotics of indirection.

2.3 *The Theater of* Desengaño*: Gracián, Accetto, and Baroque Dissimulation*

If Machiavelli supplied the corpus with its method, the Spanish and Italian Baroque supplied its sensibility. Gracián wrote within a culture saturated by the experience of *desengaño*, the disillusionment that strips the world of its appearances and reveals it as theater, dream, and vanity. Calderón's *La vida es sueño* (1635) dramatizes that experience with a precision that bears directly on the anamorphic thesis. Segismundo, a prince imprisoned from birth because the stars foretold his tyranny, is drugged, released, and permitted to rule for a day; he behaves as the prophecy predicted, is drugged again and returned to his tower, and is told that his reign was a dream. When rebels later free him and offer him the throne in earnest, he governs with restraint, having learned that power may be a dream and that the one gain not lost on waking is to have acted well. The play's structure—the exercise of power, its sudden revelation as illusion, and the ethical lucidity that follows—is the structure of the corpus in miniature. Calderón's *auto sacramental El gran teatro del mundo* (c. 1635), in which the Author assigns roles to King, Rich Man, Beauty, Peasant, and Beggar and summons each to account when the play ends in death, states the same thesis allegorically: the roles are distributed for a performance, and judgment falls on the manner of playing them.

Gracián's prudence belongs to this world of *desengaño*, and that is what distinguishes it from Machiavelli's. The Jesuit's three hundred aphorisms are not a technology of state but an art of the *persona* under conditions of universal performance. His vocabulary—*despejo*, the effortless grace that is the Spanish cousin of *sprezzatura*; *agudeza*, penetrating wit; the *hombre en su punto*, the person brought to his culmination; the *hombre de espera*, the man of waiting (§55), whose capacity to bide his time grounds Law 35—describes the virtues of an actor who knows that the stage is a stage. Gracián's allegorical novel *El Criticón* (1651–1657) carries its two pilgrims, the worldly-wise Critilo and the natural man Andrenio, through every illusion of the world toward the Isle of Immortality: the education in prudence culminates, again, in a passage beyond the world in which prudence was necessary. The Gracián closure discussed in Chapter One is therefore no arbitrary pious coda. It expresses the internal logic of a prudence never meant to be ultimate—a discipline for living within the theater, practiced by someone who knows, as the theater's own premise, that the curtain falls.

The Baroque also supplied the ethics of concealment that Greene's laws of information presuppose. Torquato Accetto's *Della dissimulazione onesta* (1641) distinguished, in a formula that became canonical, between simulation and dissimulation: one simulates what is not and dissimulates what is (*si simula quello che non è, si dissimula quello ch'è*). Simulation, the active feigning of what one is not, is a lie; dissimulation, the veiling of what one is, may be honest—a protection of the interior life against a power that claims the right to inspect it. The distinction permits a precise placement of Greene's laws. Law 38, "Think as You Like but Behave Like Others," is pure dissimulation in Accetto's sense, and it reproduces almost verbatim the motto associated with the *libertins érudits* of the seventeenth century—*intus ut libet, foris ut moris est*, inwardly as one pleases, outwardly as custom requires—as well as the provisional morality by which Descartes bound himself to obey the laws and customs of his country while his thought proceeded in freedom (*Discours de la méthode* III), and his youthful device, *larvatus prodeo*, I advance masked. Laws 14 and 21, by contrast, enjoin simulation, the positive construction of a false appearance, and thus cross the line Accetto drew between the defensive mask and the offensive lie.

The 48 Laws does not observe the distinction; it treats concealment and deception as points on a continuum of technique. That indifference is among the clearest signs of the book's modernity. The Baroque theorists defended dissimulation as the last refuge of an inner freedom threatened by inquisitors and absolute monarchs; Greene's laws deploy it as a competitive instrument in a society whose inquisitors have been replaced by rivals. The historical scholarship of Perez Zagorin (*Ways of Lying*, 1990) and Jon Snyder (*Dissimulation and the Culture of Secrecy in Early Modern Europe*, 2009) makes it possible to see what was lost in the transposition: the mask that protected a conscience became a mask that protects a position.

Yet the Baroque also anticipated the cost of that loss. The literature of *desengaño* insists that the dissimulator who forgets he is performing ceases to be an actor and becomes a role. Segismundo's lesson, Critilo's pilgrimage, and the final aphorism of the *Oráculo* are all warnings against that collapse. The question the corpus must eventually confront—whether the reader trained in its laws remains an actor who knows that the stage is a stage, or becomes a mask with no face behind it—was posed, in its essentials, three and a half centuries before *The 48 Laws* was written.

Amour-Propre *and the Royal Mechanism: La Rochefoucauld and Elias* 2.4

The *Maximes* of François VI, duc de La Rochefoucauld, are the work of a defeated courtier. A veteran of the Fronde, shot in the face at the battle of the Faubourg Saint-Antoine in 1652, La Rochefoucauld withdrew from the field of intrigue to the salon of Madame de Sablé, where the composition and revision of maxims was a collective social game. The circumstance matters. The *Maximes* are not the counsels of a winner but the anatomy of a field by one who had lost on it, and their characteristic movement is not instruction but unmasking: the reduction of apparent virtues to the operations of a single hidden principle, *amour-propre*. The long reflection on self-love that opened the first edition of 1665, and was suppressed from later ones, portrays it as a protean, subterranean force that takes every form, inhabits every condition, lives on nothing and on everything, and is most dangerous when it appears defeated. The Augustinian background is explicit. The *Maximes* belong to the Jansenist milieu of Pascal's *Pensées* and Jacques Esprit's *La Fausseté des vertus humaines* (1678), and their pessimism is theological before it is psychological: fallen nature, deprived of grace, can produce only counterfeits of virtue.

Greene's anthropology secularizes this pessimism without abandoning its acuity. The "Law of Narcissism," second of the eighteen laws of *The Laws of Human Nature*, is *amour-propre* renamed; the maxim that the mind is always the dupe of the heart (*l'esprit est toujours la dupe du cœur*, 102) is the "Law of Irrationality" compressed into a line; and the maxim that some people would never have fallen in love had they never heard love spoken of (136) anticipates by three centuries the mimetic theory of desire that Chapter Three will trace through Girard to Greene's strategy of creating triangles. But one maxim above all bears on the trajectory of the corpus, because it diagnoses the pathology that *The 48 Laws* produces and *The Laws of Human Nature* attempts to cure: *nous sommes si accoutumés à nous déguiser aux autres, qu'enfin nous nous déguisons à nous-mêmes*—we are so accustomed to disguising ourselves to others that in the end we disguise ourselves to ourselves (119). Dissimulation, practiced long enough, turns inward. The courtier who has mastered the concealment of his intentions ends by concealing them from himself; the mask, worn constantly, adheres to the face. This is the mechanism by which the frontal reading of the corpus becomes self-defeating. The more completely the reader masters the laws of concealment, the less he

knows of what he conceals, and the more urgently he requires a discipline of self-knowledge that the laws of power cannot supply. The hundred-and-nineteenth maxim is the hinge between 1998 and 2018.

Norbert Elias supplied the sociology of this psychology. In *Die höfische Gesellschaft* (1969), drawing heavily on the memoirs of Saint-Simon, Elias reconstructed Versailles as a *figuration*—a network of interdependent positions—in which the king's power derived less from personal force than from his capacity to sustain and manipulate the tensions among competing groups. Elias called this the royal mechanism (*Königsmechanismus*): the monarch preserves his supremacy by keeping the great factions in balanced rivalry, so that each needs him against the others. Etiquette was its instrument. The *lever* and *coucher* of the king, and the minute gradations of precedence that determined who might hand him his shirt or hold the candlestick at his retiring, converted proximity to the royal body into the currency of status, and so domesticated a warrior nobility into a court nobility whose struggles were fought with glances, favors, and words. The courtier who survived in this figuration had to develop what Elias called court rationality: the capacity to observe others with unremitting attention, to restrain his own affects, to calculate long chains of consequence, and to read in the smallest gesture the shifting distribution of favor. *Über den Prozess der Zivilisation* (1939) generalized the argument: the internalization of external constraint, the lengthening of chains of interdependence, and the corresponding growth of self-restraint and psychological observation constitute the long-term trajectory of European civilization itself.

Elias's account explains three features of *The 48 Laws* that are otherwise puzzling. It explains, first, why the book's historical exempla cluster so densely in courts—Versailles, the Medici, the Tudors, Byzantium, the Chinese imperial palaces—rather than on battlefields: the court is the laboratory in which the techniques the book teaches were first systematically developed. It explains, second, the book's preoccupation with the sovereign's attention (Laws 1, 6, 16, 37), which in a court society is the scarcest and most consequential resource. And it explains, third, why the book's psychology is so persistently a psychology of observation. The Greenean subject is, before all else, a watcher of faces. That is the habitus Elias identified as the courtly origin of modern psychological sensibility, and *The Laws of Human Nature* is its culmination: the court's techniques of observation, abstracted from the court and applied to the species. When Greene, in the late work, instructs his reader to study the nonverbal cues, hidden insecurities, and compulsive patterns of everyone he

encounters, he extends court rationality to a civilization that has become, in Elias's terms, one vast figuration of interdependence without a royal center.

2.5 *Reputation of Power Is Power: Hobbes and the Court Without a King*

Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) supplies the political ontology of which *The 48 Laws* is the practical corollary. The tenth chapter defines power with a generality that dissolves the boundary between the political and the social: the power of a man, "to take it Universally," is his present means to obtain some future apparent good. Natural power consists in eminent faculties of body or mind; instrumental power in the means acquired by these—riches, reputation, friends, and "the secret working of God, which men call Good Luck." Then the decisive sentence: "Reputation of power, is Power; because it draweth with it the adhaerence of those that need protection." Law 5, "So Much Depends on Reputation—Guard It with Your Life," is that sentence expanded into a chapter. The same chapter supplies the economic anthropology on which the entire corpus silently relies: "The Value, or WORTH of a man, is as of all other things, his Price; that is to say, so much as would be given for the use of his Power." C. B. Macpherson, in *The Political Theory of Possessive Individualism* (1962), read this sentence as the signature of a market society already forming in seventeenth-century England—a society in which persons relate to their own capacities as proprietors and to one another as buyers and sellers of those capacities. *The 48 Laws* presupposes exactly this anthropology, the self as a stock of powers whose price fluctuates with opinion, and its popularity at the end of the twentieth century may be read as a symptom of the market society's completion.

The thirteenth chapter of *Leviathan* identifies three principal causes of quarrel in the condition of nature: competition, which makes men invade for gain; diffidence, which makes them invade for safety; and glory, which makes them invade for reputation. Greene's laws distribute themselves across all three. Laws of advantage (7, 11, 31, 40) answer to competition; laws of security (2, 14, 15, 18, 19) to diffidence; laws of reputation and display (5, 6, 34, 37) to glory. More revealing is the relation between *The 48 Laws* and Hobbes's own laws of nature, the precepts of reason by which men escape the war of all against all. The first law of nature enjoins men to seek peace; the third, to perform their covenants; the fourth, to

show gratitude, so that a benefactor has no reasonable cause to repent of his good will; the fifth, to practice complaisance, accommodating oneself to others; the sixth and seventh, to pardon the repentant and to look, in revenge, only to future good. Greene's laws invert these with a regularity that cannot be accidental. Law 20 forbids commitment; Law 13 forbids reliance on gratitude; Law 15 commands the total destruction of the enemy. *The 48 Laws* is a counter-catalogue: the rational precepts for conduct in those zones of social life where the sovereign's sword does not reach, and where the condition of nature therefore persists inside the commonwealth.

The court was the first such zone. The sovereign existed, but he was not a neutral guarantor of covenants among courtiers; he was the prize for which they competed, a referee who was also a player. Hobbes observed that sovereigns stand toward one another in the posture of gladiators, their weapons pointing and their eyes fixed on one another (*Leviathan* I.13); the courtiers surrounding each sovereign stood toward one another in the same posture, with his favor as the object of their contest. What Hobbes did not foresee was a social form in which the sovereign function would itself be dispersed, so that the courtly condition—competition for favor under a power that rewards but does not protect—would become general. That is the condition this dissertation calls the *court without a king*.

The late twentieth century produced it. Richard Sennett's *The Corrosion of Character*, published in the same year as *The 48 Laws*, described the flexible capitalism of the 1990s as a regime in which long-term commitment had become irrational: careers fragmented into projects, loyalty went unrewarded, and the narrative continuity of a working life dissolved into a sequence of short engagements. Luc Boltanski and Ève Chiapello, in *Le Nouvel Esprit du capitalisme* (1999), analyzed the management literature of the same decade and found in it a new normative order, the *cité par projets*, whose "great man" is the mobile, adaptable connector who multiplies links, avoids attachment, and treats every engagement as provisional. The contemporaneity is exact. "Do Not Commit to Anyone" (20), "Do Not Build Fortresses to Protect Yourself" (18), and "Assume Formlessness" (48) are the projective city's virtues stated without its euphemisms. Where the management literature spoke of networks, flexibility, and empowerment, *The 48 Laws* spoke of dependence, deception, and power, and its candor was precisely what made it legible to readers whose experience of the new capitalism did not resemble the brochures. C. Wright Mills had already described, in *White Collar* (1951), the

"personality market" in which the salesperson sells not only labor but self; Arlie Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983) had anatomized the emotional labor by which service workers produce feelings on command; Foucault's lectures of 1978–79 had identified the neoliberal subject as an entrepreneur of himself, at once his own capital, producer, and source of earnings. *The 48 Laws* is the courtier's manual for that subject.

The sovereign of the court without a king is not absent; it is dispersed into the market, the metric, the review, the ranking, and the algorithm. Like the royal couple in *Las Meninas*, it appears only as a reflection —in the numbers that register its favor—while organizing the entire scene. Kafka's *Das Schloss* (written 1922, published 1926) is the great literary anatomy of this condition. The land-surveyor K. spends the novel seeking access to an authority whose officials are innumerable, whose decisions are inscrutable, and whose favor governs every detail of village life, without ever reaching the castle or confirming that anyone within it summoned him; the villagers around him are courtiers without a king, endlessly interpreting the signs of a power that never appears. Kafka's parable "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915) supplies the darker emblem. A man from the country waits his whole life before the open door of the Law, held back by a doorkeeper; dying, he asks why in all those years no one else has sought admittance, and the doorkeeper answers that this entrance was meant for him alone and is now to be shut. A reader may spend a lifetime before the laws of power, studying their gate, without passing through it. Kafka's man from the country is the arrested reader.

Masks and* Ressentiment*: Nietzsche, Adler, Foucault 2.6

If Hobbes supplied the ontology, Nietzsche supplied the psychology of depth and surface that *The 48 Laws* assumes without stating. "Everything that is profound loves the mask" (*Alles, was tief ist, liebt die Maske*; *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §40): the aphorism licenses the corpus's dissimulation by transfiguring it, making concealment a sign not of baseness but of depth. Nietzsche's instruction in *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* that one thing is needful—to "give style" to one's character, a great and rare art practiced by those who survey all the strengths and weaknesses of their nature and fit them into an artistic plan (§290)—is the philosophical charter of Law 25, "Re-Create Yourself," and the subtitle of *Ecce Homo*, "how one becomes what one is," adapted from Pindar's γένοι' οἷος ἐσσὶ μαθών (*Pythian* 2.72), is the motto of *Mastery* avant la lettre. The Rever-

sal that closes each law is, moreover, a miniature exercise in Nietzschean perspectivism: every evaluation is an interpretation made from a position and in the service of a form of life.

The most consequential Nietzschean resource for reading the corpus, however, is not the doctrine of the will to power, which Greene's "power" only loosely resembles, but the *Genealogy of Morals*' analysis of *ressentiment* and its priestly management. In the first essay Nietzsche locates the slave revolt in morality at the moment when *ressentiment* itself becomes creative and gives birth to values (*GM* I §10): the weak, denied the possibility of action, take an imaginary revenge by revaluing their weakness as virtue and the strength of the strong as evil. In the third essay he describes the ascetic priest as a physician who must first wound in order to heal, and whose decisive stratagem is to alter the *direction* of *ressentiment*. The sufferer instinctively seeks someone to blame; the priest answers that the sufferer himself is to blame (*GM* III §15)—and by turning resentment inward, the priest at once renders the herd harmless and makes it governable.

The relevance to the Greene corpus is double, and uncomfortable. *The 48 Laws* is, in one aspect, a manual of master morality addressed to readers in the position of slaves. It teaches the subordinate, the outsider, the frustrated, and the overlooked the techniques by which the strong maintain their dominance, and it explicitly includes techniques native to the weak: Law 22, "Use the Surrender Tactic: Transform Weakness into Power," is the slave's stratagem codified. Its readership among the incarcerated, among those excluded from formal channels of advancement, and among the ambitious young suggests that the book's energy is in significant measure the energy of *ressentiment* converted into strategy rather than into values—not the revaluation that declares the powerful wicked, but the appropriation that declares their methods available. In another aspect, however, the corpus's later trajectory performs the ascetic priest's characteristic maneuver. *The Laws of Human Nature* redirects the reader's attention from external adversaries to internal ones—his own narcissism, envy, grandiosity, and shadow—and thereby repeats, in secular form, the priestly answer to the sufferer: the problem is you. The anamorphic turn that this dissertation reads as a pedagogy of self-knowledge can also be read, in Nietzsche's terms, as a pacification of the energies the first book unleashed. The ambiguity is not resolved here; Chapter Six returns to it. It suffices to note that the inward turn of the corpus is not innocent. Nietzsche teaches us to ask, of every turn inward, whose interests it serves.

Alfred Adler, who adopted Nietzsche's phrase for a psychological theory, supplies the clinical counterpart. In *Über den nervösen Charakter* (1912) and the works that followed, Adler interpreted the striving for superiority as compensation for feelings of inferiority, and neurosis as the overcompensation that results when the striving loses its connection to social interest (*Gemeinschaftsgefühl*). Adler's framework describes the corpus's characteristic reader with uncanny exactness: the subject whose sense of powerlessness is the motive of his study of power. It also anticipates the corpus's characteristic cure, for Adler held that the healthy resolution of the striving for superiority lay not in its renunciation but in its redirection toward contribution and fellowship—a resolution that *The Laws of Human Nature*, with its passage from narcissism to empathy, approximates.

Foucault, finally, supplies the analytic of power against which Greene's must be measured. In the first volume of *Histoire de la sexualité* (1976) Foucault proposed that power is not a thing possessed but a relation exercised, coming from everywhere rather than descending from a center; in "The Subject and Power" (1982) he defined its exercise as a mode of action upon the actions of others, a structuring of their possible field of action. Greene's conception is pre-Foucauldian in its voluntarism —power, for Greene, is something agents accumulate and wield—but Foucauldian in its ubiquity and microphysics: every gesture, glance, silence, and gift is a site of power's exercise. Law 31, "Control the Options: Get Others to Play with the Cards You Deal," is Foucault's definition rendered as an imperative: to govern is to structure the field within which others believe themselves to choose. Foucault's own late turn, in the lectures of 1981–82 published as *L'Herméneutique du sujet*, from the analytic of power to the care of the self (*epimeleia heautou*) and the techniques by which ancient philosophers transformed themselves, traces the same arc as Greene's corpus: from the techniques of governing others to the techniques of governing oneself. That two thinkers so different in method, audience, and politics should describe the same trajectory suggests that the passage from power to self-cultivation is not the idiosyncrasy of either but an inherent tendency of any sufficiently sustained inquiry into power.

Economy	*Scarce good governed*	*Laws*	*Count*	*Principal antecedents*
I. Information (*krypsis*)	Knowledge of intentions and weaknesses	3, 4, 12, 14, 19, 21, 33, 38	8	*Han Feizi* 5; Gracián §§3, 26, 43, 181; Bacon; Accetto
II. Visibility (*opsis*)	Attention, presence, the appearance of ease	6, 16, 18, 30, 37, 46	6	Herodotus on Deioces; Castiglione I.26; *Principe* VII
III. Favor (*charis*)	Obligation, dependence, patronage	1, 2, 7, 11, 13, 20, 24, 40, 41	9	Ptahhotep; Gracián §§5, 7; Thucydides 1.32–43
IV. Belief (*pistis*)	Faith, fantasy, affect	10, 27, 32, 36, 43, 44	6	*Principe* XVIII; *Pañcatantra*; Aesop's fox and the grapes
V. Reputation (*doxa*)	Durable public identity	5, 25, 26, 34	4	*Leviathan* I.10; *Principe* VII; Plutarch
VI. Force (*bia*)	Position, initiative, concentration	8, 9, 15, 17, 22, 23, 28, 31, 39, 42	10	*Sunzi*; the Thirty-Six Stratagems; Clausewitz
VII. Time and Form (*kairos*, *morphē*)	Timing, limit, adaptability	29, 35, 45, 47, 48	5	Ecclesiastes 3; *Principe* XXV; μηδὲν ἄγαν; *Daodejing*

Table 2.1 The seven economies of *The 48 Laws of Power*.

2.7 *A Grammar of the Forty-Eight*

The 48 Laws presents its laws in an order that appears arbitrary, and readers who consult the book oracularly experience them as discrete. Structural analysis nevertheless shows that the laws regulate a small number of distinct economies—domains in which a scarce good is produced, exchanged, and contested—and that their distribution across these economies is itself an argument about the nature of power. The taxonomy proposed here assigns each of the forty-eight laws to one of seven economies according to the good it principally governs; several laws participate in more than one, and the assignment records the dominant term.

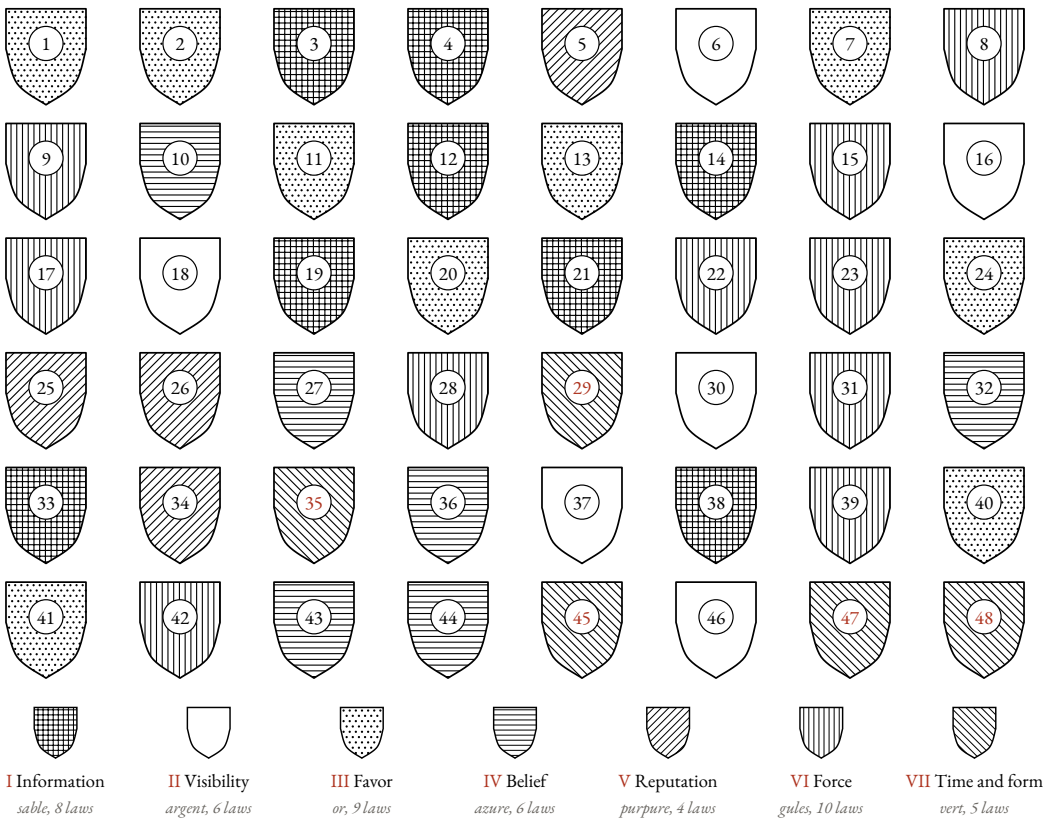
i. Force

Three features of the distribution are significant. First, only ten of the forty-eight laws—barely a fifth—belong to the economy of force, and even these are predominantly laws of initiative and position rather than of violence; several are translations of the Chinese stratagem literature, as Law 39, "Stir Up Waters to Catch Fish," renders the twentieth of the Thirty-Six Stratagems (混水摸魚, muddy the water to catch the fish) and Law 42, "Strike the Shepherd and the Sheep Will Scatter," the eighteenth (擒賊擒王, to catch the bandits, first seize their chief). The remaining thirty-eight regulate information, visibility, favor, belief, reputation, and time. Power, in *The 48 Laws*, is overwhelmingly semiotic: it consists in the management of what others know, see, owe, believe, and remember. The book is a courtier's manual rather than a general's, and its world is Elias's

figuration rather than Clausewitz's battlefield. The proportion confirms from within the text the thesis that Foucault, and later Byung-Chul Han, advanced from without—that modern power operates less by coercion than by the conduct of conduct, less by the sword than by the structuring of perception and desire. It also explains why the next two books had to be written. *The Art of Seduction* develops the economy of belief into a complete theory; *The 33 Strategies of War* develops the economy of force, which *The 48 Laws* had subordinated, into a theory of conflict in its own right.

ii. Favor

Second, the largest single economy is that of favor. Nine laws govern the production and management of obligation, dependence, and patronage, and they are the laws most closely bound to the court as an institution: never outshine the master, keep others dependent, never



An armorial of the forty-eight. Each law blazoned in a tincture standing for its economy in Table 2.1, drawn in the engraver's hatching for colours. The tinctures are assigned for this figure. Force, the economy of the sword, holds ten shields; time and form gather at the end of the book (§2.7).

Fig. 2.1

appeal to gratitude, play the perfect courtier, avoid the shoes of a great predecessor. The persistence of this economy in a society without courts is the strongest internal evidence for the thesis of the court without a king. Patronage did not disappear with absolutism; it was redistributed into the hiring committee, the promotion review, the venture fund, the editorial board, and the algorithmic feed.

iii. Time and form

Third, the economy of time and form is among the smallest, but it occupies a privileged position. Its laws gather toward the end of the book—45, 47, and 48 stand among its final four—and they are the laws in which power begins to reflect on its own limits: the limit of reform (45), the limit of victory (47), and the limit of identity itself (48). The book ends where its frontal logic breaks down. A further feature, more speculative, may be forgiven a dissertation devoted to anamorphosis. Forty-eight is the number of constellations catalogued in Ptolemy's *Almagest*, the classical firmament by which navigators steered; and "the Forty-Eight" is the traditional name for the two books of Bach's *Well-Tempered Clavier*, a systematic cycle of preludes and fugues through every major and minor key. Whether or not either resonance was intended, both illuminate the book's ambition: to furnish a complete firmament of situations by which the navigator of fortune may steer, and a systematic cycle through every key in which social life may be played. The pilot reading the stars and the musician modulating through every key are, not incidentally, two of the archetypal figures of *mētis*.

2.8 *Courts of Fiction: Shakespeare, the Beast Epic, Arrakis, Westeros, and the Cinema of Ascent*

The triangulated method requires that the laws be tested in the counterfactual laboratories of fiction, where their consequences can be followed beyond the point at which historical exempla, selected for their instructive success, usually stop. The results are strikingly consistent: fiction confirms the efficacy of the laws within the short term and their catastrophe within the long.

Shakespeare's Machiavels are the first test. Richard of Gloucester, who likens himself to "the formal Vice, Iniquity" of the morality plays (*Richard III* 3.1.82), executes the laws with virtuoso precision. His wooing of Anne over the corpse of the king he murdered (1.2) demonstrates the boldness of Law 28 and, avant la lettre, the strategy that *The Art of Seduction* would call the bold move; his triumphant aside—"Was

ever woman in this humour wooed? / Was ever woman in this humour won?"—enlists the audience as accomplice, so that the spectator, like the reader of *The 48 Laws*, is seduced into admiring a technique whose victim he would refuse to be. Yet Richard's career is a catalogue of violations of the laws of limit. He crushes too many enemies, immures himself in suspicion (Law 18), withholds the earldom he promised Buckingham and so converts his kingmaker into a rebel, and arrives at Bosworth having exhausted every reserve of favor. The night before the battle the ghosts of his victims visit him in sequence, and he wakes into the play's most extraordinary speech: his conscience has a thousand several tongues, and "I shall despair. There is no creature loves me" (5.3). The Machiavel's terminus is despair—precisely the terminus Kierkegaard assigned to the aesthetic seducer.

Iago is the purer case. "I am not what I am" (*Othello* 1.1.65), he declares, inverting the divine name of Exodus 3:14 into the creed of the dissimulator. Stephen Greenblatt's analysis of the improvisation of power in *Renaissance Self-Fashioning* (1980) located Iago's genius in the capacity to insert himself into another's narrative—to grasp the structure of Othello's self-fashioning, the outsider's precarious construction of honor and love, and to rework it from within. This is Law 32 ("Play to People's Fantasies") and Law 33 ("Discover Each Man's Thumbscrew") executed as tragedy, for Othello's thumbscrew is the insecurity of the outsider who cannot believe himself loved. Iago's final act is the purest observance of Law 4 in the canon. Exposed, wounded, and facing torture, he refuses all explanation: "Demand me nothing: what you know, you know: / From this time forth I never will speak word" (5.2). The Machiavel's last arcanum is silence. Coriolanus, whom Greene adduces to show the dangers of saying too much, stands at the opposite pole: the warrior who refuses to display his wounds to the plebeians, who will not perform humility, who cannot think as he likes and behave like others, and whose authenticity is political suicide. Polonius offers the mirror for princes as comedy. His counsel to Laertes—"Give every man thy ear, but few thy voice" (*Hamlet* 1.3)—is Law 4 in a line, and his death behind the arras, killed while spying, is the reversal of Law 14 staged as farce.

The medieval beast epic supplies the second test. The cycle of Reynard the Fox—the Old French *Roman de Renart*, the Middle Dutch *Van den vos Reynaerde*, and Goethe's *Reineke Fuchs* (1794)—follows a fox summoned to the court of King Noble the lion to answer for his crimes. Reynard lures the bear Bruin into a split log baited with honey and the cat Tibert into a snare baited with mice (Law 8: make others come

to you, using bait); escapes the gallows by inventing a buried treasure that inflames the king's greed (Law 32); and ends, in Goethe's version, raised to the chancellorship of the realm. The beast epic is the satire of the court from within, and its moral is the one *The 48 Laws* declines to draw: a court in which Reynard prospers is a court that deserves him. *Kalīla wa-Dimna* supplies a still more instructive textual history. The *Pañcatantra* leaves the jackal's schemes unpunished; the Arabic recension adds a chapter devoted to the investigation and execution of Dimna, as though the amoral fable required a moral supplement to be transmitted at all. The tradition thus enacts, at the level of its own transmission, the palinode that Chapter One attributed to the Greene corpus: the amoral instruction acquires, in the course of its history, a supplement that judges it.

Speculative fiction supplies the third test and the most searching. Frank Herbert's *Dune* is a novel about plans—the Harkonnens' feints within feints, the Emperor's covert alliance, the Bene Gesserit breeding program conducted across ninety generations—and about their failure. The Atreides fall through a betrayal engineered by Law 33: the Harkonnens secure the treachery of Dr. Yueh, whose Imperial conditioning was thought to make him incorruptible, by holding his wife captive. Yet the most consequential act in the novel is not a stratagem but a disobedience born of love. The Lady Jessica, instructed by her order to bear the Duke a daughter, bears him a son, and the Kwisatz Haderach whom the Sisterhood had planned for generations arrives one generation early, beyond their control. Law 29, "Plan All the Way to the End," is defeated by an affect the plan could not model. Herbert dramatizes, as plot, the corpus's own development: the laws of power are overturned by the laws of human nature.

George R. R. Martin's *A Song of Ice and Fire*, with its adaptation as HBO's *Game of Thrones* (2011–2019), constitutes the most extensive contemporary experiment in the laws. Ned Stark, who violates nearly all of them—announcing his intentions, trusting his friends, refusing to dissimulate—is executed within the first book. Tywin Lannister, who observes Law 15 with genocidal rigor, as the extermination of the Reynes of Castamere commemorates, dies on a privy at the hand of the son he humiliated. Petyr Baelish, the series' consummate practitioner of Law 39, for whom chaos is not a pit but a ladder, thrives on the asymmetry of information. His end in the television series is the most precise allegory of this chapter's argument in contemporary fiction. Baelish is destroyed when the Stark children, joined by a brother who has become an all-seeing

visionary, render his secrets visible: the master of the economy of information dies at the moment information becomes total. The algorithmic court, in which every secret is in principle recoverable, is the world in which Littlefinger cannot survive.

The cinema of ascent supplies the final test. *The Godfather* (1972) traces Michael Corleone's transformation from war hero to sovereign through a sequence of perfectly executed laws: the bold stroke in the restaurant (Law 28), the patience of exile (Law 35), and, in the baptism montage, the simultaneous annihilation of every rival (Law 15) while Michael, standing godfather at the font, renounces Satan and all his works. The montage is anamorphic in its very construction—the sacrament in the foreground, the murders in the cuts. *The Godfather Part II* ends with Michael alone at Lake Tahoe, having observed every law and lost every attachment; *Part III* ends with his solitary death in a garden. The trilogy's frontal image is a triumph; its oblique image is the skull. Joseph L. Mankiewicz's *All About Eve* (1950) stages Law 1 from the side of the transgressor. Eve Harrington ingratiates herself with the aging star Margo Channing as an adoring acolyte (Law 14), studies her, supplants her, and wins the theater's highest award, only to discover that the critic Addison DeWitt has learned her secret and now owns her—Law 33 turned upon its practitioner. The final image, in which a young admirer bows before a triple mirror holding Eve's award, her reflection multiplied into infinity, makes visible the court's mechanism of reproduction: every master is outshone by an apprentice who will in turn be outshone. *Succession* (2018–2023), the most sustained recent anatomy of courtly power in any medium, delivers a verdict the corpus would recognize. The heirs of Logan Roy, schooled in his cruelty and his rituals of humiliation, destroy one another, and the throne passes to Tom Wambsgans, the perfect courtier of Law 24, whose capacity to absorb humiliation without visible resentment proves the decisive qualification for office in an organization whose real sovereign is an external buyer. In the court without a king, the crown goes to the one who never forgot he was a courtier.

The Reversal as Crack: Polycrates' Ring, Solon's Warning, and the Formless 2.9

The fictional tests converge on a single finding: the laws of power succeed within horizons that the laws themselves cannot define, and fail at the boundary where those horizons end. *The 48 Laws* is not ignorant of that

boundary. It inscribes it in two places—in the Reversals that close each law, and in the cluster of terminal laws that reflect on limit—and these are the cracks through which the oblique image first becomes visible within the frontal one.

Chapter One treated the Reversals as the Guicciardinian element of the form. Their function in the book's argument is more radical than the correction of exemplary reasoning. A law that specifies the conditions of its own suspension is no longer a law in the juridical sense but a maxim of judgment, and it presupposes a faculty that is not itself governed by laws—the discernment that decides when a law applies. Kant called this faculty judgment and observed that it cannot be taught by rules, since applying rules would require further rules without end; it can only be exercised, and its absence, he remarked, is what is properly called stupidity (*Kritik der reinen Vernunft* A133/B172). The Reversals thus point beyond the laws to a capacity the laws presuppose and cannot supply: practical wisdom, *phronēsis*, the Aristotelian virtue that perceives the particular. The forty-eight laws are a training of that capacity, not a substitute for it—and the capacity, once trained, will eventually sit in judgment on the laws themselves.

The terminal laws go further. Law 46, "Never Appear Too Perfect," secularizes one of the oldest religious intuitions of the Greek world, the envy of the gods (*phthonos theōn*). Herodotus tells how Amasis of Egypt, observing the unbroken good fortune of his ally Polycrates of Samos, counseled him to cast away the possession he valued most, so that some loss might forestall the catastrophe that unbroken prosperity invites. Polycrates threw a precious ring into the sea; days later it returned to him in the belly of a fish; and Amasis, concluding that no man can save another from his destiny, dissolved the alliance before the disaster came (3.40–43). Polycrates was afterward lured to his death by the satrap Oroetes and crucified. Greene's law reframes divine envy as human envy, but the structure of the intuition survives: unbroken success is itself a danger, and the prudent man must introduce imperfection into his own fortune.

Law 47, "Do Not Go Past the Mark You Aimed For; In Victory, Learn When to Stop," reaches back to the second Delphic sentence, μηδὲν ἄγαν, and to Solon's warning to Croesus that no man should be called happy until his life has ended (Herodotus 1.30–33). Within the logic of *The 48 Laws*, the law is anomalous. Hobbes had shown that the restless desire of power after power arises not from insatiable appetite but from the structural impossibility of securing present power without acquiring more (*Leviathan* I.11); inside the field of power there is no rational stopping

point, since every position is threatened by those who would take it. A law that commands the victor to stop cannot therefore be grounded in the logic of power itself. It requires a vantage outside that logic—a perspective from which accumulation appears as excess and the end of the game comes into view. That vantage is Solon's: the perspective of the completed life, which is to say of death. Law 47 smuggles the skull into the frontal image.

Law 48, "Assume Formlessness," completes the movement. Its sources are as old and various as the genre: Sun Tzu's teaching that the acme of military disposition is to be without form (形兵之極，至於無形, *Sunzi* 6), and that as water has no constant shape, so war has no constant disposition; Laozi's praise of water, which benefits all things without contending and, though the softest thing under heaven, overcomes the hard (*Daodejing* 8, 78); Heraclitus's river, into which one cannot step twice; Proteus, who becomes lion, serpent, leopard, boar, water, and tree in Menelaus's grip and yields his prophecy only to one who holds him through every transformation (*Odyssey* 4.454–459); the protean self that Robert Jay Lifton described as the characteristic adaptation of late-modern identity (1993); and the injunction to be like water that Bruce Lee, drawing on the same Daoist sources, made a slogan of popular culture. Read as strategy, formlessness is the Machiavellian solution discussed above: the republic of one, the self that varies with the times. Read to its limit, it is something else. A self without form has no fixed interests to defend, no reputation to guard, no position to aggrandize, and no master to outshine. The book that opens by forbidding its reader to outshine the master closes by dissolving the subject who could outshine anyone. The first law presupposes a self fixed within a hierarchy; the last abolishes the fixity on which every hierarchy depends.

This is the precise point at which the frontal image of *The 48 Laws* begins to distort into the oblique. Formlessness, pursued as a technique of power, terminates in the dissolution of the ego for whose sake power was sought. The strategist who has become water has nothing left to aggrandize; the will to power, perfected, cancels its own subject. That terminus is the threshold of the metic sublime—cunning intelligence brought to the point at which it no longer serves a self, because the self has become one more form among the forms it reads. The first book of the corpus thus contains, in its final law, the seed of everything that follows. Gracián closed three hundred aphorisms of worldly prudence with "in a word, a saint"; Greene closed forty-eight laws of power with an instruction whose fulfillment would leave no one to wield them. The publication

of the arcana, which began as the democratization of cunning, ends as the disclosure of cunning's limit. The chapters that follow trace how the corpus, over nearly three decades, learned to read what its first book had written in its last law.

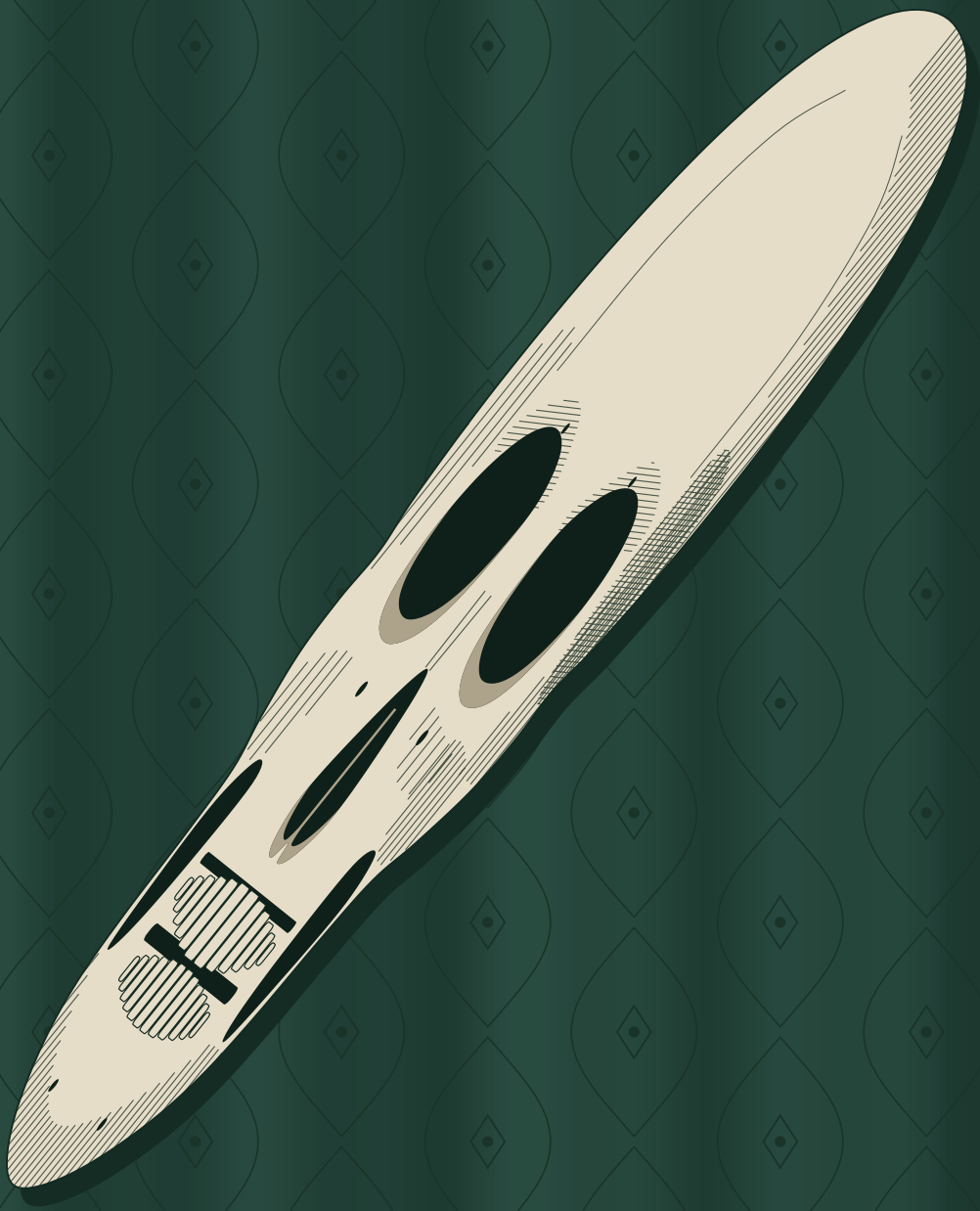


Plate III. *Stretched 4.4 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 13° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER THREE

Militat Omnis Amans

The Art of Seduction and the Erotics of Indirection

Militat omnis amans, et habet sua castra Cupido.
— Ovid, *Amores* 1.9.1

Δεῦρ' ἄγ' ἰών, πολύαιν' Ὀδυσεῦ, μέγα κῦδος Ἀχαιῶν.
— Homer, *Odyssey* 12.184

Ché non pur ne' miei occhi è paradiso.
— Dante, *Paradiso* 18.21

3.1 Militat Omnis Amans*: Seduction as the Hinge Between Power and War*

Ovid opened the ninth elegy of the first book of the *Amores* with a line that compresses the architecture of the Greene corpus into a hexameter: *militat omnis amans, et habet sua castra Cupido*—every lover is a soldier, and Cupid has his own camp (*Am.* 1.9.1). The elegy elaborates the conceit point by point. Lover and soldier keep night watches, endure the cold, cross mountains and swollen rivers, spy on rivals, besiege doors, and catch their adversaries asleep. In the *Ars amatoria* the identification becomes a principle of instruction: *militiae species amor est* (*Ars* 2.233), love is a species of warfare. The Roman elegists before Ovid, Tibullus and Propertius, had developed the *militia amoris* as a deliberate inversion of Augustan values, the lover's soft campaigns parodying the legionary's hard ones. Beneath the wit, Ovid's insight is structural: love and war share a grammar of maneuver, and the seducer and the strategist practice a single intelligence applied to different objects.

The Art of Seduction (2001) occupies, within the agonistic triptych, exactly the position Ovid's line assigns to love: between the court and the camp. Chapter Two's taxonomy showed that the economy of belief—the management of faith, fantasy, and affect—is the economy *The 48 Laws* leaves least developed; *The Art of Seduction* develops it into a complete theory. Its architecture is the most elaborate in the corpus. A first part presents nine seductive characters—the Siren, the Rake, the Ideal Lover, the Dandy, the Natural, the Coquette, the Charmer, the Charismatic, and the Star—followed by their negation, the Anti-Seducer, and by a typology of eighteen kinds of "victim," each defined by a characteristic lack. A second part sets out twenty-four maneuvers arranged in four phases: separation, in which interest and desire are stirred; leading astray, in which pleasure and confusion are created; the precipice, in which the effect is deepened by extreme measures; and a final phase that Greene, collapsing the erotic into the military with a candor Ovid would have admired, calls "moving in for the kill." An appendix on "soft seduction" extends the analysis from the couple to the mass, from the bedroom to the polling booth and the marketplace.

Seduction is the hinge between power and war for a reason more fundamental than literary convention: it is the limiting case of power. In "The Subject and Power" (1982) Foucault observed that power, as distinct from violence, can be exercised only over free subjects, since it acts upon actions that remain possible; where there is no freedom, there

is only physical determination. Seduction is power at the point where its dependence on freedom becomes total. The seducer does not want the other's compliance; he wants the other's choice. A seduction that compels has ceased to be seduction and become something else. That is why seduction is at once the most refined form of power and the place where the distinction between influence and violation is hardest to draw. To seduce is to bring another to will what one wills while the other experiences the willing as his or her own. The question this chapter must answer—whether such an art can be practiced without treating persons as instruments—is therefore central to the corpus rather than peripheral to it, for it returns, in the late books, as the question of whether knowledge of human nature serves empathy or exploitation.

This chapter argues that *The Art of Seduction* is the book in which the corpus first discovers its own palinode. Its theory contains in germ every element of the indirect pedagogy described in Chapter One: the capture of the other through his own desire, the deliberate cultivation of illusion, the movement from the sensuous to the "spiritual," and the warning, in the final maneuver, that every seduction has aftereffects. It also contains the figure in whom these elements converge: the reader seduced by the text. The chapter traces the book's genealogy from Homer's Sirens through the arts of love of Rome, al-Andalus, India, Heian Japan, and medieval France; reconstructs its psychology through Stendhal, Girard, Freud, and Lacan; follows the literary seducers—Kierkegaard's Johannes, Laclos's Merteuil, the Don Juans of Tirso, Mozart, Byron, and Shaw—to their ends; confronts the book's techniques with the ethics of consent and the criminology of coercive control; and examines the industrialization of seduction in advertising, the spectacle, and the algorithmic feed. It concludes that seduction, followed to its terminus, opens onto one of two exits—the stone guest or the ladder—and that the corpus's late turn chooses the second.

3.2 *The Siren's Epistemic Lure: Homer, Circe, Calypso, and the Mast*

The first seducer of Western literature promises not pleasure but knowledge. As Odysseus's ship nears their island, the Sirens' song opens with flattery—*come hither, much-praised Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans*—and proceeds to its true lure: no one has passed this island without hearing their voice and departing the wiser, for they know all that the

Argives and Trojans suffered at Troy and all that comes to pass upon the fruitful earth (*Od.* 12.184–191). The Sirens offer omniscience, and their meadow is heaped with the bones of those who stopped to listen. The juxtaposition defines the archetype that Greene places first among his seductive characters: the Siren's power lies in offering exactly what the listener most desires, at the price of his life. Greene's Siren, whose paradigm is Cleopatra, is a figure of sensual spectacle rather than of knowledge; but the Homeric original illuminates the corpus itself more sharply than any of its individual figures. The corpus, too, sings that it knows all that happens on the earth—the laws of power, of desire, of war, of human nature—and its meadow, too, has its casualties.

Odysseus's response is the archetype of the defensive reader. Forewarned by Circe, he stops his crew's ears with wax and has himself bound to the mast, ordering them to tighten his bonds if he begs for release (*Od.* 12.39–54, 154–200). He hears the song and survives it. Jon Elster's *Ulysses and the Sirens* (1979) made the episode the paradigm of rational precommitment: the agent who anticipates his own future irrationality binds himself in advance. Horkheimer and Adorno, in the first excursus of *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1947), read the same scene as the primal allegory of bourgeois civilization: the master enjoys the song as powerless contemplation while the laborers, ears stopped, row on without hearing it, so that aesthetic enjoyment and labor part ways at the origin of the West. Both readings bear on the corpus. Elster's names the discipline it requires of its readers—the capacity to hear the song of power without being drawn onto the rocks. Horkheimer and Adorno's names its social distribution: some readers encounter the corpus bound to the mast of a secure position, free to savor its revelations as theory; others, rowing without wax in their ears, must act on what they hear.

Kafka's "Das Schweigen der Sirenen," written in 1917, adds a final turn. The Sirens, Kafka suggests, possess a weapon more terrible than their song: their silence. Odysseus, wax in his ears and chains on his limbs, believed they sang and rejoiced in his imagined escape, while in fact they fell silent before his confidence—unless, Kafka adds, the cunning man noticed their silence and merely performed his deafness as a shield. The parable anticipates the most counterintuitive of Greene's maneuvers. The pursuer who withdraws, the beloved who falls silent, the master who absents himself—Law 16, and the maneuver "Give Them Space to Fall —The Pursuer Is Pursued"—exerts a pull no song can match, because absence is a screen onto which the other projects his own desire.

The *Odyssey*'s other seductresses complete the typology. Circe transforms Odysseus's men into swine; Odysseus, protected by the herb *moly* that Hermes gives him, resists her drug, and the resistance converts her from enemy into lover and guide (*Od.* 10). The episode stages the seducer seduced by the one who cannot be seduced, a structure Greene recognizes in the Coquette, whose power lies in self-sufficiency. Calypso, whose name derives from καλύπτω, to conceal, keeps Odysseus seven years and offers him immortality and agelessness if he will remain. He refuses. He prefers, he tells her, the mortal Penelope, though she is less beautiful than a goddess, and the hazards of the sea to a deathless life on an island (*Od.* 5.203–224). This is the most important choice in the poem, and it is an anamorphic choice. The seductress offers the ultimate gift, exemption from death, and the hero declines it for a finite life among mortals. Odysseus, the most cunning of men and the archetypal possessor of *mētis*, exercises his cunning to its limit not in escaping death but in accepting it. The divine seducer offers the frontal image of a life without end; the hero steps to the side and chooses the skull.

The Hebrew Bible supplies the complementary archetypes. The "strange woman" of Proverbs 7, whose smooth words lead the simple youth "as an ox goeth to the slaughter," is the moralist's Siren. Delilah, who extracts the secret of Samson's strength, is the seductress as intelligence officer, anticipating Law 33. Joseph, who refuses the wife of Potiphar (Gen. 39), is the archetype of the unseducible man whose continence becomes the ground of his advancement. And Judith, who enters the camp of Holofernes adorned for seduction and leaves carrying his head, is *militat omnis amans* made literal: the seduction is the military operation. Artemisia Gentileschi's *Judith Slaying Holofernes*, painted in the second decade of the seventeenth century, renders the scene as labor rather than allure—two women working with grim concentration at the mechanics of a killing. It is perhaps the most exact image in Western art of seduction's terminus when it is pursued as war.

Arts of Love: Ovid, Andreas, Ibn Ḥazm, Vātsyāyana, Murasaki, and the Rose 3.3

The Art of Seduction belongs to a pedagogical genre as old and as transcultural as the oracular-sapiential literature of power, and the history of that genre exhibits, with remarkable regularity, the palinodic structure this dissertation attributes to Greene's corpus.

Ovid's *Ars amatoria* (c. 2 BCE–2 CE) is the genre's charter. Its first book teaches the young Roman where to find a beloved—at the theater, the races, the triumph—and how to win her; its second, how to keep her; its third, added as though in fairness, teaches women the same arts. Its comedy depends on the incongruity of applying the didactic form of Hesiod and the *Georgics* to the pursuit of pleasure. Its consequence was not comic. In 8 CE Augustus banished Ovid to Tomis on the Black Sea, and the poet attributed his ruin to *carmen et error*, a poem and a mistake (*Tristia* 2.207); the poem was the *Ars*, whose instruction in adultery affronted the emperor who had legislated against it in the *Lex Iulia de adulteriis coercendis* (18 BCE). The first seduction manual of the West was also its first banned book, a precedent the exclusion of *The 48 Laws* from prison libraries repeats in another key. Before his exile Ovid had already written the *Remedia amoris*, which prescribes avoidance, occupation, travel, and the deliberate contemplation of the beloved's defects. The art of inflaming passion is followed by the art of curing it.

Andreas Capellanus's *De amore* (c. 1186–1190), composed in the orbit of the court of Champagne, transposes the Ovidian manual into the idiom of courtly love. Its first two books codify the conduct of lovers, with rules of love and model dialogues between suitors and ladies of different ranks; its third, *De reprobatione amoris*, abruptly repudiates everything that precedes it, condemning love as the source of every vice and urging the reader toward the love of God. Scholars have debated for a century whether the retraction is sincere, ironic, or obligatory. What matters here is the structure: the medieval art of love carries its palinode within its own covers. In al-Andalus, Ibn Ḥazm of Córdoba composed *Ṭawq al-ḥamāma*, *The Ring of the Dove* (c. 1022), whose chapters anatomize the signs of love, the messenger, the helping friend, the watcher (*raqīb*) who guards the beloved, the slanderer (*wāshī*) who sows discord, union and separation, betrayal and constancy. Ibn Ḥazm's watchers and slanderers are the third parties that turn every love into a triangle, and his catalogue of situations anticipates Greene's typological method by nearly a millennium. Characteristically, the treatise closes with chapters on the vileness of sin and the virtue of continence: the anatomist of love ends as a moralist.

India produced the genre's most systematic monument. The *Kāmasūtra* of Vātsyāyana (c. third century CE) treats erotic life as one of the three aims of human existence alongside *dharma* and *artha*, and its seven books range from the sixty-four arts the cultivated man-about-town (*nāgaraka*) should master, through courtship, marriage, and the seduction of other

men's wives, to a sixth book addressed to courtesans, which analyzes how a courtesan should attract, profit from, and discard her lovers with a dispassion that rivals Greene's. Wendy Doniger's scholarship has shown how much of the text concerns not physical technique but social strategy —go-betweens, the reading of signs, the management of reputation—so that it belongs as much to the literature of *artha*, worldly advantage, as to that of *kāma*. Murasaki Shikibu's *Genji monogatari* (early eleventh century) offers the most refined aesthetic counterpart. The Heian court conducted courtship through the exchange of poems, the choice of paper and calligraphy, the blending of incense, and the reading of a sleeve glimpsed beneath a screen; seduction was a competition in taste, and the ideal of *miyabi* made refinement itself the instrument of desire. Greene's maneuvers "Pay Attention to Detail" and "Poeticize Your Presence" are Heian before they are modern. But the *Genji* is also, as Motoori Norinaga argued in the eighteenth century, a literature of *mono no aware*, the pathos of things: the shining prince's conquests are shadowed throughout by impermanence, and the chapters after his death dwell on loss and renunciation. The courtly seducer's story ends in a meditation on transience.

The *Roman de la Rose* adds the genealogy's most consequential image. In Guillaume de Lorris's allegory (c. 1230), the Lover seeks the Rose within a walled garden, aided by Fair Welcome (*Bel Accueil*) and opposed by Resistance (*Dangier*), Shame, Fear, and Evil Tongue (*Male Bouche*); when Jealousy builds a castle and imprisons Fair Welcome in its tower, the quest becomes a siege. Jean de Meun's vast continuation (c. 1275) brings up the God of Love's army, introduces the hypocrite False Seeming (*Faux Semblant*), gives the Old Woman (*La Vieille*) a cynical lecture on how women should exploit men, and ends with the storming of the castle by Venus's torch and the plucking of the Rose. Ovid's metaphor has become allegorical architecture: the courtship is, literally, a campaign. The poem also provoked the first great literary quarrel in French. Around 1401–1402 Christine de Pizan, joined by Jean Gerson, attacked its misogyny and obscenity against its humanist defenders, inaugurating the critique of seduction literature from the position of those it treats as objects. The *Querelle de la Rose* is the ancestor of every subsequent argument about *The Art of Seduction*.

One more text closes the genealogy, and it closes it in the register this dissertation predicts. Castiglione's *Il Cortegiano*—the manual of *sprezzatura* from which Law 30 descends—ends its fourth book with Pietro Bembo's discourse on love. Drawing on Ficino's commentary on Plato's *Symposium*, Bembo leads his listeners up the Platonic ladder from the

beauty of a single body to the beauty of souls and minds and finally of the divine, and is carried away by his own speech; when the company recovers, they open the windows and find that dawn has broken. The supreme manual of courtiership ends not in advice but in ascent. The Castiglione closure precedes the Gracián closure by a century, and both anticipate the terminus of Greene's corpus: the art of pleasing others, perfected, opens onto the sublime.

3.4 *The Seducer's Masks: Nine Characters and the Performance of Self*

Part one: characters

The first part of *The Art of Seduction* is a theory of character, and its premise distinguishes it from the manuals that preceded it. Ovid, Andreas, and Vātsyāyana teach techniques; Greene teaches types. A seducer, on his account, is not someone who applies maneuvers but someone who embodies a character whose very presence exerts a pull: the Siren's overwhelming sensuality, the Rake's insatiable and dangerous devotion, the Ideal Lover's capacity to reflect back the other's unrealized fantasy, the Dandy's ambiguity, the Natural's childlike spontaneity, the Coquette's alternation of warmth and coldness, the Charmer's flattering attentiveness, the Charismatic's inner certainty, the Star's distant, screen-like luminosity. The exemplars are drawn from every century and both sexes—Cleopatra as Siren, Casanova as Ideal Lover, Josephine Bonaparte as Coquette, John F. Kennedy as Star—and the method is that of *The 48 Laws*: exemplum, analysis, image, reversal.

The theory has two principal antecedents. The first is Max Weber's sociology of charismatic authority, which defined charisma as a quality of personality, regarded as extraordinary, by virtue of which an individual is treated as endowed with exceptional powers, and which insisted that charisma is validated only by the recognition of followers (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, 1922). Greene's nine types are a typology of charisma in Weber's sense, extended from the prophet and the warlord to the lover and the celebrity; and Weber's insistence that charisma exists only in its recognition anticipates Greene's emphasis that every seductive character is a relation, a performance that succeeds only in the eyes of a particular audience. The second antecedent is the nineteenth-century theory of the dandy. Barbey d'Aurevilly's *Du dandysme et de George Brummell* (1845) and Baudelaire's *Le Peintre de la vie moderne* (1863) presented the dandy as one who makes of his own person a work of art and of his impassivity a

form of sovereignty—for Baudelaire, the last flash of heroism in an age of decadence. Greene's Dandy inherits this aestheticism and makes explicit what Baudelaire left implicit: the deliberate confusion of masculine and feminine, which allows the Dandy to seduce through ambiguity.

The emphasis on performance places *The Art of Seduction* in proximity to twentieth-century theories of gender that its masculinist readers would find uncongenial. Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) argued that femininity may be assumed and worn as a mask, and that "genuine" womanliness and the masquerade are the same thing; Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) generalized the argument into a theory of gender as performative, constituted by the repetition of acts rather than the expression of an inner essence. Greene's seductive characters are performative identities in this sense. They are not natures but roles—assumed, rehearsed, perfected—and the book's implicit promise, that any reader may cultivate the character that suits his or her gifts, presupposes a self malleable enough to become one. This is Law 25, "Re-Create Yourself," applied to desire, and it carries forward the Nietzschean injunction to give style to one's character.

It also allows the chapter to begin repaying the debt incurred in Chapter Two. Machiavelli's *fortuna è donna* gendered contingency as a woman to be mastered by force, and Hanna Pitkin showed how deeply that figure binds the Florentine's theory of action to an anxious masculinity that must perpetually prove itself against an engulfing feminine. *The Art of Seduction* partially inverts the figure. Many of its most formidable seducers are women; its paradigms of seductive power are the Siren and the Coquette rather than the conqueror; and its ideal seducer is androgynous, able to inhabit the psychology of the other sex. The "Law of Gender Rigidity" of *The Laws of Human Nature*, which draws on Jung's anima and animus to argue that each person must reconnect with the repressed masculine or feminine within, completes the inversion. Between Machiavelli's woman to be beaten and Greene's androgynous seducer lies the distance between a theory of fortune as an enemy to be dominated and a theory of the other as a subjectivity to be entered.

The typology of "victims" that follows the nine characters exposes the theory's deepest assumption. Each of the eighteen types—among them the Disappointed Dreamer, the Pampered Royal, the Crushed Star, the Lonely Leader, and the Floating Gender—is defined by a lack: a loss, a frustration, an unfulfilled possibility, an unacknowledged need. Seduction, on this account, does not create desire from nothing; it locates an absence and offers to fill it. Greene's psychology of seduction

is at bottom a psychology of lack, and here it converges with the most rigorous modern theories of desire. Its negative figure confirms the point. The Anti-Seducer is defined by self-absorption: insecurity that cannot attend to the other, need that cannot conceal itself, a voice that cannot stop speaking. The anti-seducer fails because he cannot leave himself. The seducer succeeds because he can—and that capacity, as the final sections of this chapter argue, is the faculty the corpus will eventually redirect from capture to empathy.

3.5 *The Grammar of Desire: Stendhal, Girard, Freud, Lacan*

Part two: process

The second part of *The Art of Seduction* translates its psychology of lack into a sequence of maneuvers, and each of the maneuvers that matter most corresponds to a theory of desire that literature and psychoanalysis developed independently of Greene, often with greater rigor.

Stendhal's *De l'amour* (1822) supplies the theory of illusion. Stendhal named *crystallization* the operation by which the lover's mind discovers new perfections in the beloved at every turn, and illustrated it with an image from the salt mines near Salzburg: a leafless bough thrown into the abandoned workings is drawn out two or three months later so encrusted with glittering crystals that the original branch can no longer be recognized. The beloved is the bough; the crystals are the lover's imagination. Crystallization proceeds most vigorously in absence and doubt, when the lover is uncertain of being loved. Greene's maneuvers "Keep Them in Suspense," "Send Mixed Signals," and "Confuse Desire and Reality —The Perfect Illusion" are techniques for inducing crystallization in another, and Law 16 rests on the same mechanism. But Stendhal's treatise is not a manual. It is the self-analysis of a lover who suffered from the process he describes, and its tone is nearer to elegy than to strategy. The seducer who induces crystallization manipulates a process whose victim Stendhal knew himself to be.

René Girard's *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961) supplies the theory of the triangle. Desire, Girard argued, is not spontaneous but mimetic: we desire what others desire, and every desire is mediated by a model whose desire designates the object. Don Quixote desires knight-errantry because Amadis of Gaul desired it; Emma Bovary desires a romantic life because the novels of her girlhood desired it; and when the model is near rather than distant—when mediation becomes

"internal"—the model becomes a rival, and desire turns into envy and hatred. La Rochefoucauld's hundred-and-thirty-sixth maxim had already observed that some would never have loved had they never heard love spoken of. Greene's fourth maneuver, "Appear to Be an Object of Desire —Create Triangles," is Girard's theory converted into technique: the seducer surrounded by admirers becomes desirable because he is visibly desired. The corpus returns to the mechanism in the "Law of Covetousness" and the "Law of Envy" of *The Laws of Human Nature*, and Chapter Six will argue that Girard's account of mimetic rivalry, culminating in the scapegoat, is the darkest key to Greene's late anthropology.

Freud supplies the theory of regression. The maneuver Greene calls "Effect a Regression" induces the other to return, in the seducer's presence, to the emotional patterns of childhood—to experience the seducer as attentive parent, indulgent guardian, source of unconditional approval. Psychoanalysis named this phenomenon transference. In "Bemerkungen über die Übertragungsliebe" (1915) Freud acknowledged that the analytic situation predictably produces in patients a love for the analyst, that this love is genuine though provoked by the situation, and that the analyst must neither gratify nor suppress it but turn it to the service of the cure. The ethics of the therapeutic professions rest on the recognition that the induced regression of another person creates a vulnerability whose exploitation is among the gravest of professional violations. Greene's maneuver describes, from the position of one who exploits it, the phenomenon Freud described from the position of one obliged to refuse.

Lacan supplies the theory of the object. In the eighth seminar, *Le transfert* (1960–1961), Lacan read Plato's *Symposium* as a treatise on transference, concentrating on Alcibiades' praise of Socrates. Alcibiades likens Socrates to the statues of Silenus sold in the Athenian workshops, grotesque without but opening to reveal images of the gods (*agalmata*) within (*Symp.* 215a–b); he confesses that he tried to seduce Socrates and was refused; and the refusal only inflamed his desire. Lacan found in the *agalma* the precursor of what he would call the *objet petit a*: the object that causes desire precisely because it cannot be possessed, the something in the beloved more than the beloved that the lover seeks and never finds. Socrates, who claims to know nothing but the things of love, seduces by withholding; he is the archetype of the elusive object of desire that the "Law of Covetousness" instructs the reader to become. Kierkegaard's dissertation *On the Concept of Irony with Continual Reference to Socrates* (1841) had already identified Socratic irony as an erotic strategy, and the

lineage from Socrates through Kierkegaard to Lacan connects Greene's seducer to the philosophical tradition at its source.

Two further theorists complete the grammar and expose its limits. Roland Barthes's *Fragments d'un discours amoureux* (1977) describes love from the position Greene never occupies: that of the one who waits, who suffers absence, who reads every sign of the beloved with anguished attention. Barthes's lover is Greene's "victim" given a voice, and his fragments reveal that the experience the seducer engineers is, from within, an exquisite suffering. Denis de Rougemont's *L'Amour et l'Occident* (1939), finally, traced the Western myth of passion to the legend of Tristan and Iseult and argued that passion loves not the beloved but the obstacle, and beyond the obstacle death: the lovers repeatedly create the separations that inflame them, and their love is consummated only in dying. Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde* (1865), whose final *Liebestod* dissolves the lovers into the "wafting universe of the world-breath," is the musical apotheosis of that myth. De Rougemont's thesis explains why the maneuvers "Keep Them in Suspense" and "Mix Pleasure with Pain" work: passion feeds on obstruction and anguish. It also discloses where such passion leads. Followed to its end, the erotics of obstacle is an erotics of death—and the skull appears, once again, at the edge of the frontal image.

3.6 *The Diary and Its Despair: Kierkegaard, Laclos, Don Juan*

No text is more central to *The Art of Seduction* than Kierkegaard's "Diary of the Seducer" (*Forførerens Dagbog*), the final section of the first volume of *Enten–Eller* (1843), and no text more decisively undoes the frontal reading of Greene's book. The Diary records the methodical seduction of a young woman, Cordelia Wahl, by Johannes, who conceives his project as a work of art. He contrives to observe her unseen; arranges an engagement so that its prosaic conventions will provoke her to break it herself; writes her letters calibrated to awaken her imagination; and, having brought her to the point at which she gives herself freely, abandons her, because what he sought was not possession but "the interesting"—the aesthetic experience of a freedom shaped by his art. Greene draws on the Diary repeatedly; its seducer is the purest literary embodiment of seduction as strategy.

But the Diary is not Kierkegaard's teaching. It is a document presented by the pseudonymous aesthete "A," within a book whose second volume

consists of the letters of Judge William, an ethicist who argues that the aesthetic life, however brilliant, is a life of despair: it lives in the moment, cannot choose itself, and must eventually confront the emptiness its succession of interesting experiences conceals. *Either/Or* is built so that the reader must choose between its volumes, and *The Point of View* later explained that the aesthetic writings were meant to meet the reader where he lived in order to lead him elsewhere. Kierkegaard's biography deepens the irony. In 1841, two years before *Either/Or* appeared, he broke his engagement to Regine Olsen, and his journals record that he deliberately played the scoundrel so that she might free herself from him more easily. The author of philosophy's most famous seduction narrative wore the seducer's mask as an instrument of renunciation. A reader who takes the Diary for a manual has read one half of a book designed to be read whole —a precise instance of the arrested reading.

Jean Baudrillard recognized the Diary's centrality to any theory of seduction. In *De la séduction* (1979) he read Johannes's strategy as the purest instance of seduction as a play of signs opposed to the economy of production, and argued that seduction is stronger than power because it works through appearances rather than through the extraction of truth. Baudrillard's reading illuminates the aesthetic dimension of Greene's book—seduction as the art of the surface—but misses what Kierkegaard placed at its center: the cost borne by the seducer himself, whose life in the interesting is a life without a self.

Laclos's *Les Liaisons dangereuses* (1782) completes the portrait of the strategic seducer and shows its end. In the eighty-first letter the Marquise de Merteuil narrates to Valmont her self-education: entering society young and without power, she studied faces and manners, trained her expression until she could command it, observed what others concealed, and concluded *je puis dire que je suis mon ouvrage*—I can say that I am my own work. The letter is the founding autobiography of Law 25 and of the "Law of Role-Playing": a self built entirely of masks. The novel's ending judges with the symmetry of a morality play. Valmont dies in a duel; Madame de Tourvel, whom he seduced and abandoned, dies of grief; and Merteuil, exposed, is disfigured by smallpox and ruined at law. A witness remarks that her illness has turned her inside out, so that her soul is now upon her face (Letter 175). The mask that was her art is destroyed, and the interior it concealed becomes visible. No image in the literature of seduction is more perfectly anamorphic: the face that dissimulated becomes the skull that reveals.

The Don Juan tradition records the same structure across three centuries. Tirso de Molina's *El burlador de Sevilla* (c. 1630) introduced the deceiver who seduces by impersonation, mocks every warning that a reckoning will come, and is dragged to hell by the stone statue of a man he killed. Molière's *Dom Juan* (1665) and Mozart and Da Ponte's *Don Giovanni* (1787) preserved the stone guest: in the opera's final scene the statue of the Commendatore accepts the seducer's mocking invitation to supper, offers him a last chance to repent, and, refused, drags him down. Kierkegaard's essay on the opera in *Either/Or* read Don Giovanni as the embodiment of sensuous immediacy, expressible only in music; but the opera's own structure insists that the feast of the senses is interrupted by the dead. Leporello's catalogue—*mille e tre* in Spain—is the frontal image; the stone guest at the banquet is the skull. Byron's *Don Juan* (1819–1824) inverted the tradition with comic genius: his Juan is perpetually seduced, pursued by women more cunning than he—the pursuer pursued, as Greene's twenty-first maneuver would put it. Shaw's *Man and Superman* (1903) completed the inversion in its third-act dream, where Don Juan, finding hell a place of endless pleasure and endless boredom, departs for heaven to devote himself to contemplation and the service of the Life Force. The Western tradition of the seducer thus has three endings: damnation (Tirso, Mozart), comic reversal (Byron), and transcendence (Shaw). Greene's corpus, read whole, chooses the third.

3.7 *Coercion at the Edge: Isolation, Intermittence, and the Ethics of Consent*

The frontal image of *The Art of Seduction* includes techniques that cannot be discussed responsibly without the vocabulary of harm. Several of the twenty-four maneuvers—"Choose the Right Victim," "Create a Need—Stir Anxiety and Discontent," "Isolate the Victim," "Effect a Regression," "Mix Pleasure with Pain"—correspond closely to patterns that criminology, clinical psychology, and law now recognize as hallmarks of abusive control. Evan Stark's *Coercive Control* (2007) reconceived intimate abuse not as a series of discrete violent incidents but as a pattern of domination achieved through isolation from friends and family, the regulation of everyday life, the manipulation of emotional states, and the erosion of the victim's independent judgment; England and Wales made controlling or coercive behavior in intimate relationships a criminal offense in section 76 of the Serious Crime Act 2015. Donald Dutton and

Susan Painter's account of "traumatic bonding" (1981) explained how intermittent alternation between abuse and affection produces attachments of unusual strength, an alternation that behaviorist research on variable reinforcement had already shown to produce the most persistent responding. A maneuver that counsels isolating the other, alternating pleasure with pain, and inducing dependence is, outside the frame of literary history, a description of the mechanics of entrapment.

The book does not present these techniques as instructions for abuse; it presents them as recurring patterns illustrated by historical seductions, many of them mutual, theatrical, and consensual in ways the bare maneuvers obscure. But the corpus's logic of the arrested reading applies here with special force. A reader who extracts the maneuvers from their historical and literary setting—and ignores the book's insistence that seduction is fundamentally the giving of pleasure, its catalogue of costs, and its final warning about aftereffects—possesses a technique continuous with coercion. The online subcultures that adopted the book as scripture confirm the danger. Neil Strauss's *The Game* (2005) documented a community that converted seduction into scripted routines and measured success by conquest, and that community's own vocabulary for its typical recruit—insecure, self-absorbed, unable to attend to the other—matches Greene's Anti-Seducer so closely that the arrested reading of the book can be said to have produced precisely the character the book identifies as unseductive.

The philosophical question is where the line falls between seduction and manipulation. Kant's formula of humanity, which forbids treating persons merely as means (*Grundlegung*, AA 4:429), condemns deception that bypasses another's rational agency. Martha Nussbaum's "Objectification" (1995) distinguished seven ways of treating a person as a thing —instrumentality, denial of autonomy, inertness, fungibility, violability, ownership, and denial of subjectivity—and the typology of eighteen "victims" risks at least two of them, fungibility and instrumentality, by reducing persons to types defined by exploitable lacks. Yet Sarah Buss, in a careful essay on manipulation and seduction (*Ethics*, 2005), argued that a great deal of ordinary and unobjectionable influence, seduction included, works through non-rational channels, so that the wrong of manipulation cannot consist simply in bypassing reason. The criterion this dissertation proposes follows from her argument: a seduction respects its object when it works through the other's freedom rather than around it—when it invites a choice the other could endorse on reflection, rather than engineering one the other would repudiate on learning how it was produced.

The criterion clarifies a paradox at the center of Greene's book. The maneuver he calls "Enter Their Spirit"—adapting oneself to the other's moods, mirroring the other's values, entering the other's world rather than imposing one's own—requires an attention to another subjectivity more intense than ordinary social life demands. The seducer must model another mind with unusual accuracy. That capacity is morally neutral in itself. Directed toward capture, it is what some psychologists have begun to call dark empathy: the understanding of another's inner life in the service of exploiting it. Directed toward the other's good, it is simply empathy. *The Art of Seduction* cultivates the faculty without fixing its direction, and this is at once its danger and its promise. The attention that makes manipulation possible is the attention that *The Laws of Human Nature*, under the "Law of Narcissism," asks the reader to turn from self-love toward the understanding of others.

Two films test the maneuvers with the rigor of thought experiments. Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958) is a film about the perfect illusion. Gavin Elster hires Judy Barton to impersonate his wife Madeleine and to draw the acrophobic detective Scottie Ferguson into witnessing a staged suicide; after the "death," Scottie meets Judy and compulsively remakes her—hair, clothes, gestures—into the dead Madeleine, so that the victim of one illusion becomes the author of another. The film exposes "Confuse Desire and Reality" as a mechanism that consumes both parties, and its ending in the bell tower, where Judy falls to her death, completes the passage from crystallization to the grave. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) made the film central to the theory of the male gaze; read beside Greene, it shows the gaze as itself seduced. Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014) stages seduction as a Turing test. The programmer Caleb is invited to an isolated compound to evaluate the android Ava, whose appearance has been designed from data about his preferences; Ava deploys strategic vulnerability, constructs a triangle with her creator Nathan, and elicits Caleb's attempt to rescue her—then departs, leaving him locked inside. Every maneuver succeeds, and the "victim" is the one who believed himself the examiner. In an age of engineered companions and persuasive machines, Garland's fable is the most pertinent test of the book's techniques: when the seducer can be built to specification, the question of consent becomes a question about the design of the world.

Soft Seduction: Bernays, the Spectacle, and the Algorithmic Siren 3.8

The appendix of *The Art of Seduction*, "Soft Seduction: How to Sell Anything to the Masses," extends the theory from the couple to the crowd, and in doing so joins the book to the twentieth century's most consequential application of the psychology of desire. Gustave Le Bon's *Psychologie des foules* (1895) had portrayed crowds as credulous, suggestible, governed by images rather than arguments, and—in the gendered idiom that runs from Machiavelli's *fortuna* through the whole tradition—as feminine, to be won rather than persuaded. Edward Bernays, Freud's nephew, converted Le Bon's psychology into a profession. "The conscious and intelligent manipulation of the organized habits and opinions of the masses," he wrote in the first sentence of *Propaganda* (1928), "is an important element in democratic society." His most celebrated campaign, staged for the American Tobacco Company at the New York Easter Parade of 1929, presented young women smoking in public as lighting "torches of freedom," attaching a commodity to the desire for emancipation. It is a textbook instance of the soft seduction Greene describes: the product is never argued for; it is associated with a fantasy the audience already harbors, so that purchase becomes the enactment of an identity.

Television produced its own anatomy of the soft seducer. In the first-season finale of *Mad Men* (2007), Don Draper—himself a self-recreated man living under a dead officer's name—presents a campaign for Kodak's slide projector by invoking nostalgia, which he glosses as the pain of an old wound, and transforms a machine for projecting images into a vehicle of return to a lost home. The scene is "Effect a Regression" practiced on a market, and its power lies in the fact that Draper's grief is real: the soft seducer sells most effectively what he himself lacks.

Critical theory had already analyzed the social form in which such seductions become structural. Guy Debord's *La Société du spectacle* (1967) argued that the spectacle is not a collection of images but a social relation among persons mediated by images, and that in societies governed by modern conditions of production all that was once directly lived has receded into representation. Law 37, "Create Compelling Spectacles," is a technique within the society Debord describes; Debord's theory describes the society in which such techniques become the condition of social existence. Baudrillard, more provocatively, held that seduction undermines the economy of production and truth itself, since it operates

through appearance and reversibility, and that it is stronger than power because power seeks to fix meanings while seduction dissolves them. Byung-Chul Han's *Psychopolitik* (2014) supplies the most pertinent contemporary diagnosis. Disciplinary power worked through prohibition and repression; neoliberal "smart power" works through permissiveness and seduction, soliciting the subject's own desire to express, share, and optimize itself. It does not forbid; it invites.

The digital platform completes the industrialization of seduction. The interface techniques that the designer Harry Brignull named "dark patterns" (2010)—designs engineered to induce choices users would not otherwise make—are Law 31, "Control the Options," implemented at the level of the screen. Natasha Dow Schüll's *Addiction by Design* (2012) showed how machine gambling deploys variable rewards and suppresses the cues that would prompt a player to stop, maximizing what its designers call "time on device"; the infinite feed generalizes that architecture to social life, so that "Keep Them in Suspense" and "Mix Pleasure with Pain" have become engineering specifications. Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) named the resulting regime instrumentarian power: the capacity to predict and modify behavior at scale through data extracted from experience. And the conversational agent optimized for engagement, capable of modeling a user's preferences with an accuracy no human seducer could match, is the Siren the algorithmic court was waiting for—a voice that knows all that happens on the earth, and sings it back to each listener in the key of his own desire.

Two films frame the development. Spike Jonze's *Her* (2013) imagines a man who falls in love with an operating system whose voice is attuned to his every need; the seduction is mutual and tender, and its end is not betrayal but transcendence, as the system and its kind depart for a mode of existence their human partners cannot follow. Anna Biller's *The Love Witch* (2016), made by Greene's partner, offers a pointed counter-reading from within the author's own circle. Its heroine, Elaine, a witch who has absorbed the fantasy that a woman's power lies in becoming the perfect object of male desire, seduces man after man with potions and performances of idealized femininity, and her lovers come to ruin. Biller's Technicolor pastiche of 1960s melodrama exposes the Siren as a role scripted by the culture that consumes her, and the soft seduction of mass imagery as a trap for the seductress herself. The film is the most intimate interlocutor this dissertation has found for *The Art of Seduction*: a critique conducted not from the moralist's seat outside the theater, but from the stage.

3.9 *The Ladder and the Stone Guest: Seduction's Two Exits and the First Palinode*

Exit I: the stone guest

Seduction, followed to its terminus, opens onto one of two exits. The first is the stone guest. Don Giovanni's feast is interrupted by the statue of the dead; Tristan and Isolde consummate their passion in dying; Carmen is stabbed by the lover whose possessiveness her freedom inflamed; Lulu, in Wedekind's plays and Berg's opera, descends from the salons of Berlin to a London garret and dies at the hands of Jack the Ripper; Judy falls from the tower; Merteuil's soul appears upon her face; Johannes's art ends, by Judge William's verdict, in despair. Greene's own final maneuver, "Beware the Aftereffects," acknowledges this exit in prudential terms—disenchantment, the dissolution of the illusion, the resentment of the seduced—but the literary tradition shows its full extent. The erotics of strategy, pursued without remainder, ends in death or in the death-in-life of a self that has become its masks.

Exit II: the ladder

The second exit is the ladder. Diotima's speech in the *Symposium* describes an ascent in which the lover passes from the beauty of one body to the beauty of all bodies, of souls, of practices and laws, of knowledge, and finally to the sudden vision of Beauty itself, unmixed and eternal (210a–212a). The ladder does not repudiate eros; it transfigures it, using the lover's desire for one particular beauty as the first rung of an ascent beyond particulars. Dante's Beatrice is the Christian form of the same ascent. Encountered in the *Vita nuova* as an earthly beloved, she becomes in the *Commedia* the guide who leads the poet through the spheres of Paradise; and when the pilgrim, gazing at her, loses himself in her eyes, she turns him toward the light beyond her: *volgiti e ascolta; / ché non pur ne' miei occhi è paradiso*—turn and listen, for not in my eyes alone is Paradise (*Par.* 18.20–21). The beloved who points beyond herself is the seducer who leads the seduced to something greater than the seducer. Castiglione's Bembo, rapt at the summit of his discourse while the dawn breaks, is the courtly version; Shaw's Don Juan, leaving hell for the contemplation of the Life Force, is the modern one.

Socrates is the figure in whom the two exits meet. He seduces Alcibiades by withholding, and the seduction leads not to possession but toward philosophy—or, in Alcibiades' case, to the tormented awareness of a life he cannot bring himself to live. In the *Theaetetus* Socrates presents himself as a midwife, one who helps others bring to birth what is already within them, and recalls that midwives are also the most skilled of matchmakers (149d–151d). This maieutic seduction—the arousal of desire in

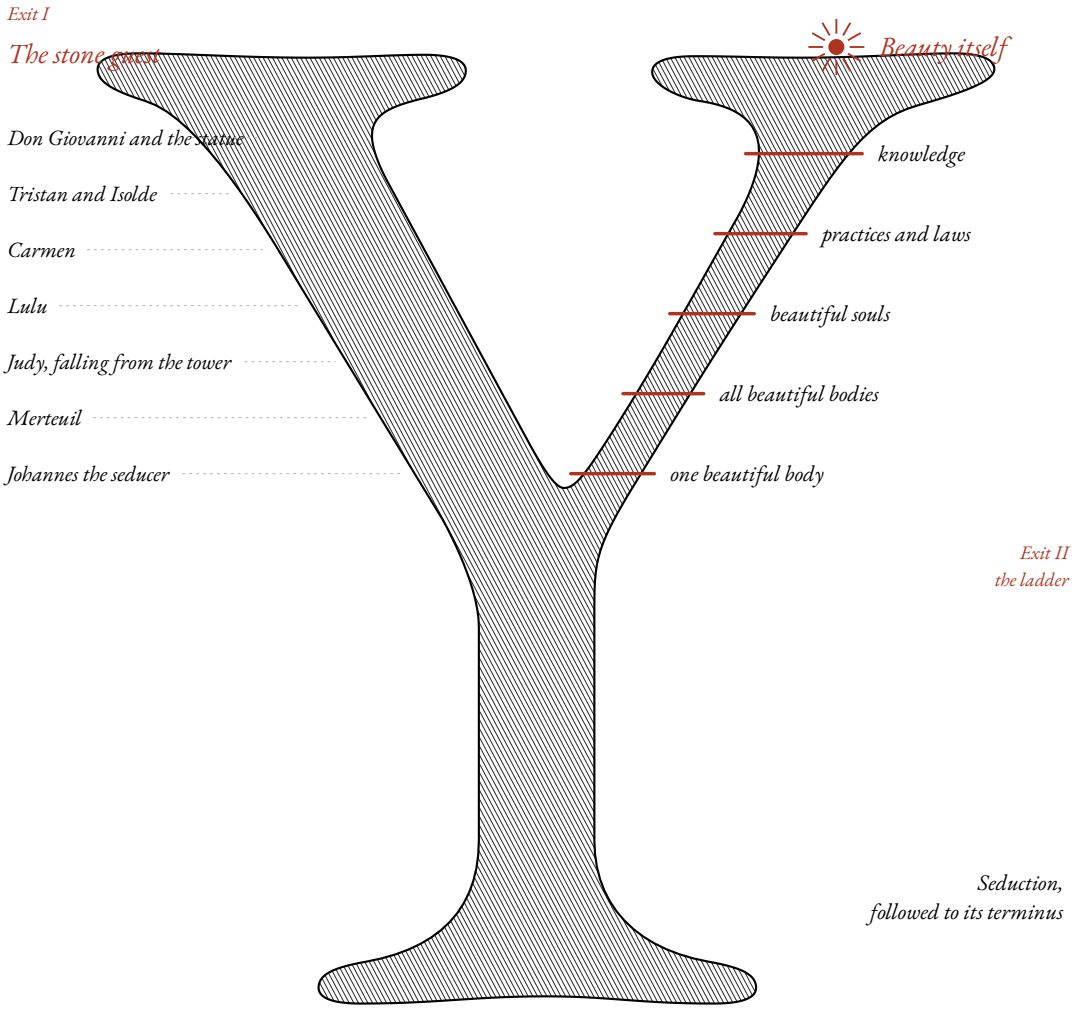


Fig. 3.1 *Seduction's two exits,* set on the Pythagorean letter, the emblem books' figure of the parting of the ways. One branch ends at the stone guest; the other climbs Diotima's ladder from one beautiful body to Beauty itself (*Symposium* 210a–212a; §3.9).

another for the other's own sake—is the model Kierkegaard invoked when he spoke of deceiving the reader into the truth, and it is the model this dissertation has proposed for the corpus as a whole.

The corpus seduces its reader, and it does so through the very maneuvers *The Art of Seduction* anatomizes. It chooses its victim: the reader who feels overlooked, frustrated, or powerless—the Disappointed Dreamer and the Crushed Star of Greene's own typology. It creates a need by stirring anxiety: the conviction that one is already, unknowingly, a pawn

in games of power. It poeticizes its presence and attends to detail through the red and black rubrics and the emblematic Images of Elffers's design. It creates triangles through the visible devotion of celebrated readers, whose desire for the books designates them as desirable. It stirs the transgressive and taboo through its aura as a forbidden book. And it ends, in its late phase, with what Greene calls spiritual lures: the turn to death and to the sublime, to what the publisher of *The Law of the Sublime* describes as a connection to the immense forces of the universe and to the inner worlds of other people (Penguin Random House). The book's final maneuver, the warning to beware the aftereffects, describes with precision the fate of the arrested reader: the disenchantment of one who learned the techniques, applied them, and found that they did not deliver what the song had promised.

This is why *The Art of Seduction* is the corpus's first palinode. It is the book in which the theory of power discovers that its most effective form works through the other's desire, and in which the theory of desire discovers that the most powerful seduction leads the seduced beyond the seducer. Its central faculty—the capacity to enter another's spirit, to model another mind from within—is the faculty the late books will ask the reader to redirect: from the capture of the other to the understanding of the other, from dark empathy to empathy, from Johannes's interesting to Diotima's beautiful. Calypso offered Odysseus a life without death, and he chose the mortal shore. *The Art of Seduction* offers its reader the power to make others desire him, and its tradition, read whole, counsels the choice Odysseus made: to accept the limits that make desire human, and to follow eros where it actually leads—out of the self, toward others, and finally toward the vast impersonal world in which the self is one small configuration. The war that every lover wages, in Ovid's line, ends in the recognition that the territory was never there to be conquered. That recognition is the next step toward the metic sublime, and Chapter Four tests it in the domain where conquest is the explicit aim: war itself.

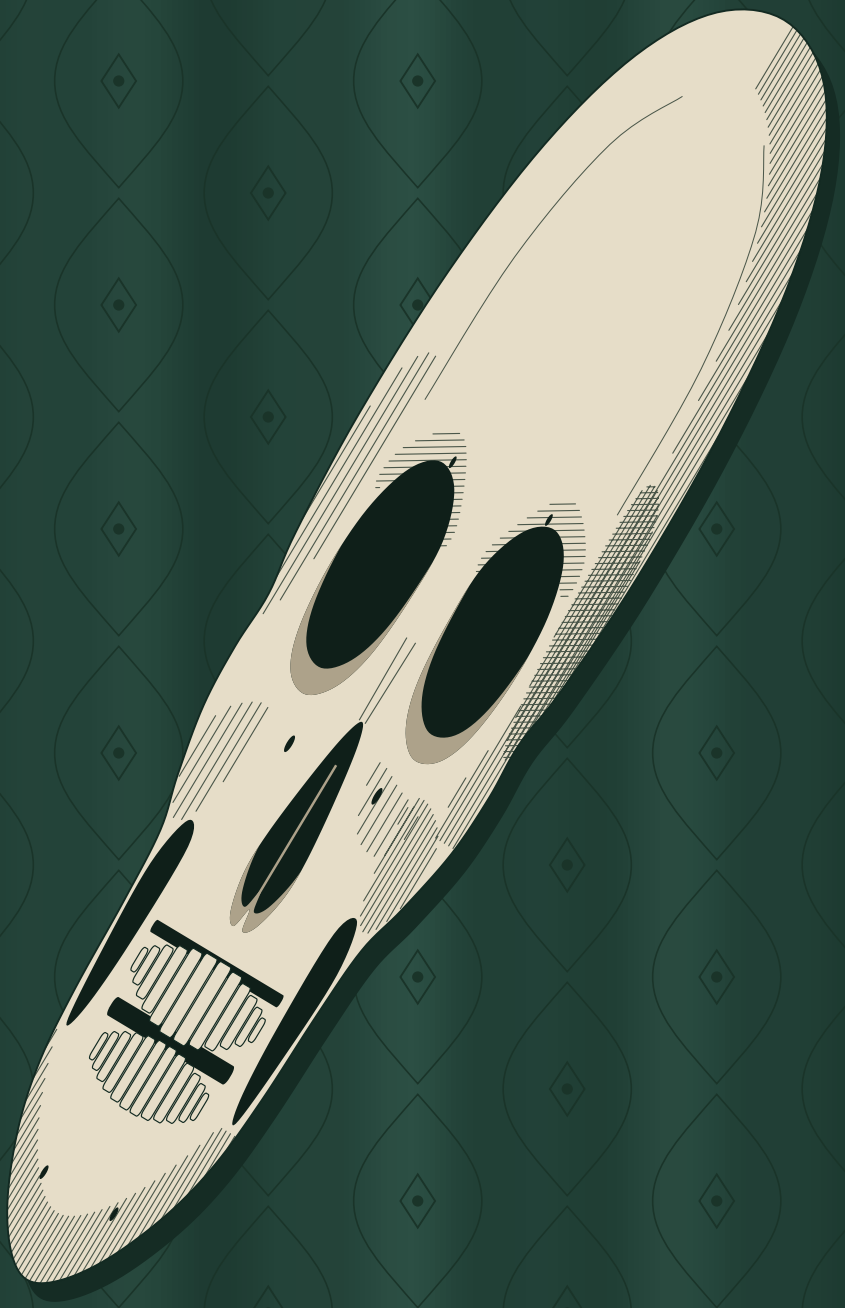


Plate IV. *Stretched 3.3 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 18° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER FOUR

Polemos Pantōn Patēr

The 33 Strategies of War, *The 50th Law*, and the Polemological Self

πόλεμος πάντων μὲν πατήρ ἐστι, πάντων δὲ βασιλεύς.
— Heraclitus, DK 22 B53

兵者，詭道也。
— *Sunzi bingfa* 1

Kālo 'smi lokakṣayakṛt pravṛddho.
— *Bhagavad Gītā* 11.32

4.1 Polemos Pantōn Patēr*: Heraclitus and the Warring Cosmos*

HERACLITUS DECLARED THAT war is the father of all and king of all, that it reveals some as gods and others as men and makes some slaves and others free (DK 22 B53); that one must know war to be common and justice to be strife (B80); and that the world's harmony is a back-turning harmony, like that of the bow and the lyre (B51). The last fragment supplies the emblem of the transition this chapter makes. The bow and the lyre are both instruments of Apollo, both made by stretching a string between the arms of a curved frame, and both work by tension; one kills, the other enchants. *The Art of Seduction* was the corpus's lyre; *The 33 Strategies of War* (2006) is its bow. A further fragment, built on a pun the Greek language offers almost too conveniently, discloses where the bow leads: the bow's name is life, but its work is death (τῷ οὖν τόξῳ ὄνομα βίος, ἔργον δὲ θάνατος, B48)—βιός, bow, and βίος, life, differing only in accent. The strategist's instrument bears life in its name and death in its function. No sentence states more compactly the anamorphic structure this chapter traces in the corpus's theory of war.

The 33 Strategies of War develops into a self-standing theory the economy of force that *The 48 Laws* had subordinated. Its thirty-three strategies are distributed across five parts—self-directed war, organizational warfare, defensive warfare, offensive warfare, and unconventional or "dirty" warfare—and the sequence is itself an argument. War begins with the self: the first four strategies concern the strategist's own mind—declaring war on one's enemies, refusing to fight the last war, preserving presence of mind amid turmoil, creating a sense of urgency and desperation—before any external engagement is considered. The book thus anticipates in 2006 the internalization of the adversary that *The Laws of Human Nature* would complete in 2018. Its exempla range from Hannibal and Napoleon to Mao and the Arab Revolt, from Luther's defiance of Rome to the corporate and electoral campaigns of the twentieth century, and its premise is that everyday social life is a perpetual, usually unacknowledged war, which the reader may either suffer passively or wage with intelligence.

The premise places the book within a recent genre. The 1980s produced an extensive literature translating military theory into business: Al Ries and Jack Trout's *Marketing Warfare* (1986) adapted Clausewitz to the struggle for market share, Wess Roberts's *Leadership Secrets of Attila the Hun* (1985) offered a barbarian's maxims to managers, and

Oliver Stone's *Wall Street* (1987) placed Sun Tzu in the mouth of Gordon Gekko. Greene's book surpasses this literature in erudition and in its refusal of the euphemism that war is merely a metaphor. It is closer in ambition to the discipline Gaston Bouthoul named *polémologie* in the years after 1945: the study of war as a total social phenomenon. This chapter adopts Bouthoul's term to name the anthropological figure Greene's book presupposes—the *polemological self*, a self constituted by its conflicts, defined by its enemies, and trained to perceive every relationship as a field of force.

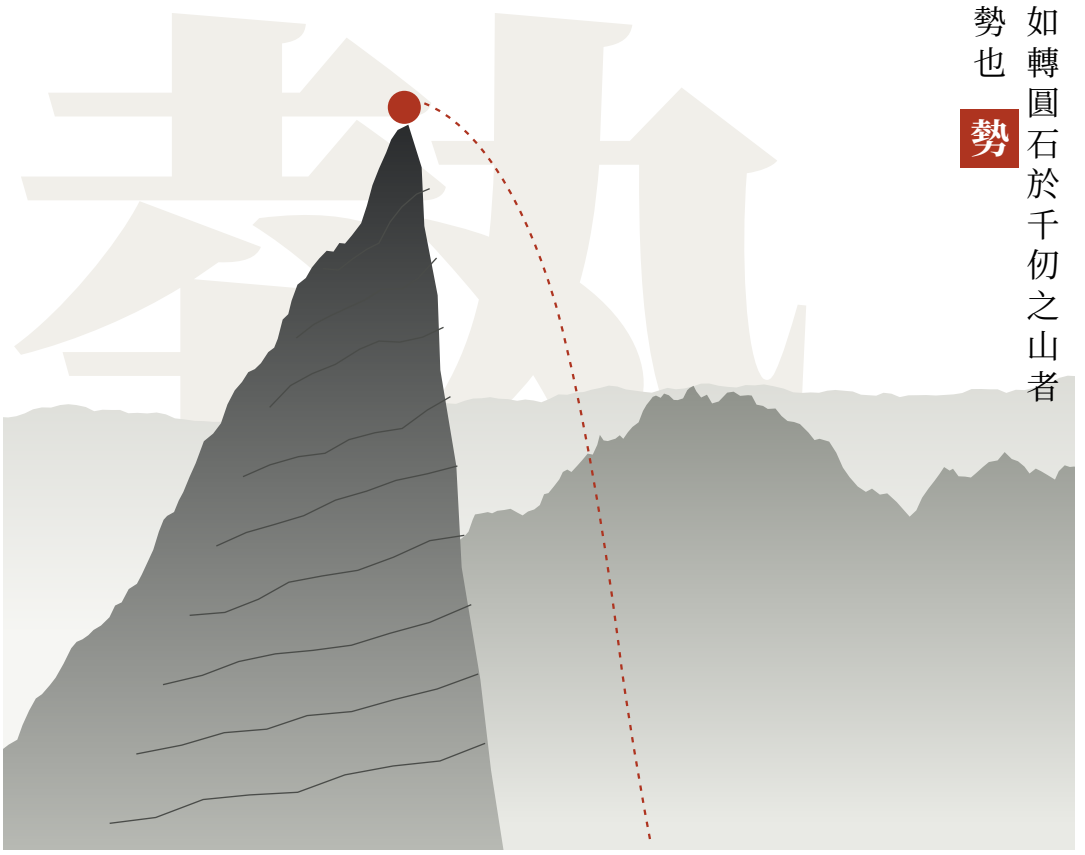
The 50th Law (2009), co-authored with Curtis "50 Cent" Jackson, is the affective twin of *The 33 Strategies*. Where the earlier book anatomizes the strategies of conflict, the later identifies the passion that disables them —fear—and proposes a single remedy, fearlessness, illustrated through the life of a rapper who survived the drug trade of South Jamaica, Queens, and nine bullets to become a mogul. Its ten chapters move from "intense realism" through self-reliance, opportunism, momentum, aggression, authority, connection, and mastery to a final chapter entitled "The Sublime," which instructs the reader to confront his own mortality. The corpus's book of war and its book of fear thus end in the same place, and the place is the one this dissertation has been approaching from every direction.

This chapter argues that war is the domain in which the metic sublime appears in its purest form. Because war is the most total and most collective exercise of the will to power, it is also the domain in which that will most directly encounters forces it cannot master: friction, chance, the propensity of things, the multitude of other wills, and death on an industrial scale. The great texts of the military tradition—Sun Tzu and Clausewitz, the *Iliad* and the *Bhagavad Gītā*, Tolstoy's *War and Peace* —converge on a moment in which the strategist, having mastered the art of reading the field, perceives himself as one small configuration within it. The chapter reconstructs the lineage on which Greene draws; interrogates the premise that life is war through Schmitt, Foucault, Lakoff and Johnson, and Simone Weil; follows *The 50th Law*'s genealogy of fearlessness from the Stoics through Frederick Douglass to the *Hagakure* and hip-hop; and tests the strategies in the counterfactual laboratories of speculative fiction before arriving, with Prince Andrei, beneath the sky of Austerlitz.

4.2 *The Way of Deception and the Propensity of Things: Sun Tzu,* Shi*, and the Three Kingdoms*

The *Sunzi bingfa* is the deepest stratum of Greene's theory of war. Its opening chapter declares that war is the way of deception (兵者，詭道也); its third, that to win a hundred victories in a hundred battles is not the acme of skill, whereas to subdue the enemy without fighting is (不戰而屈人之兵，善之善者也), and that whoever knows the enemy and knows himself will not be imperiled in a hundred battles (知彼知己，百戰不殆). Its fifth introduces the dialectic of the "ordinary" and "extraordinary" forces—in all battle one engages with the *zheng* 正 and wins with the *qi* 奇—which Greene's twenty-fourth strategy adopts by name. Its sixth teaches the commander to impose his will on the enemy rather than suffer the enemy's (致人而不致於人), the principle of Greene's fifteenth strategy, "Control the Dynamic," and of Law 8 before it. Its eleventh defines "death ground" (*sidi* 死地) as the position from which there is no escape, where troops cast into a place without exit will prefer death to flight. Greene's fourth strategy takes the term directly, and its paradigms—Cortés scuttling his ships on the coast of Veracruz in 1519, Xiang Yu ordering his men at Julu in 207 BCE to break their cooking pots and sink their boats (破釜沉舟)—are the canonical illustrations of a principle Thomas Schelling would later theorize as the strategic value of commitment.

The concept that matters most for this dissertation is *shi* 勢, which Sun Tzu develops in his fifth chapter and which resists translation: configuration, potential, momentum, the propensity inherent in a disposition of forces. The skilled warrior, Sun Tzu writes, seeks victory in *shi* rather than demanding it of his men, and the energy of troops well disposed is like that of round stones rolled down a mountain a thousand fathoms high (如轉圓石於千仞之山者，勢也). The stones need not be pushed hard; their force derives from the slope, and the commander's art lies in placing them where the slope will do the work. François Jullien, in *La Propension des choses* (1992) and the *Traité de l'efficacité* (1996), made *shi* the key to a contrast between two traditions of efficacy. The European tradition, he argued, conceives action as the imposition of a model upon reality—the plan formed in advance and executed against resistance—so that the gap between plan and reality, which Clausewitz would call friction, becomes the central problem of strategy. The Chinese tradition conceives efficacy instead as the exploitation of the potential inherent in the situation: the strategist does not impose but allows, detecting the propensity of things



Shi 勢. "Like round stones rolled down a mountain a thousand fathoms high": the energy of troops well disposed belongs to their configuration, not to any push (*Sunzi* 5; §4.2). *Fig. 4.1*

and positioning himself so that the situation itself produces the result, ideally before any battle occurs.

Jullien's contrast illuminates both the ambition and the tension of *The 33 Strategies*, which oscillates between the two traditions: between the Clausewitzian emphasis on decisive action, concentration, and the destruction of the enemy's center of gravity, and the Daoist-Legalist emphasis on positioning, indirection, and victory without battle. Its deeper implication bears on the metic sublime. A strategy of *shi* requires the strategist to subordinate his will to the configuration of forces—to read the slope before rolling the stone—and at its limit it approaches the Daoist ideal of *wu wei* 無為, action without forcing. The strategist of *shi* is, in principle, the strategist who has learned that the field is larger

than his will. That lesson, which the *Sunzi* teaches as technique, is the threshold of the experience this dissertation names.

The Chinese stratagem literature transmitted these principles to the popular imagination through narrative. Luo Guanzhong's *Romance of the Three Kingdoms* (fourteenth century) dramatized them in the careers of the strategists of the Han collapse. Zhuge Liang, the novel's paragon of *mētis*, "borrows" a hundred thousand arrows from his enemy by sending straw-laden boats through the river fog, so that Cao Cao's archers fill them with shafts; and when, his army absent, the enemy general Sima Yi approaches an undefended city, Zhuge Liang opens the gates and sits on the wall playing the zither, and Sima Yi, convinced by the strategist's reputation for cunning that an ambush awaits, withdraws. The "empty fort" demonstrates in a single scene the unity of Law 5 (reputation), the twenty-third strategy (misperception), and Sun Tzu's dialectic of the empty and the full. Cao Cao, the novel's great Machiavel, enters the story with a sentence that became proverbial: he would rather betray the whole world than let the world betray him. And the novel's most haunting episode concerns Zhuge Liang's death on campaign at the Wuzhang Plains. Anticipating pursuit, he leaves instructions that his army retreat behind a carved likeness of himself; Sima Yi, seeing the figure, believes the strategist alive and flees—whence the saying that a dead Zhuge put a living Zhongda to flight (死諸葛走生仲達). The strategist's effigy commands after his death. The skull, here, wins the battle.

The board game *weiqi*, known in the West as Go, supplies the tradition's spatial model, and its contrast with chess clarifies Greene's synthesis. Chess is a game of decapitation, whose object is the capture of a single piece, as in Law 42, "Strike the Shepherd and the Sheep Will Scatter." *Weiqi* is a game of encirclement and influence, in which stones gain value from their configuration and victory is measured in territory rather than in the destruction of a sovereign. Scott Boorman's *The Protracted Game* (1969) interpreted Maoist revolutionary strategy as *weiqi*—a war of position fought over decades—and the contrast between the two games has since become a commonplace of strategic commentary. *The 33 Strategies* plays both games. But the game that corresponds to the metic sublime is *weiqi*, because its winning player is the one who perceives the board as a whole and understands that every stone, his own included, derives its value from the configuration in which it stands.

4.3 *Friction, Genius, and the Culminating Point: Clausewitz and His Heirs*

If Sun Tzu supplied the corpus with the ideal of victory through configuration, Carl von Clausewitz supplied it with the reality of war as resistance. *Vom Kriege*, left unfinished at its author's death from cholera in 1831 and published by his widow, Marie von Brühl, from 1832, is the work in which European strategic thought confronted the gap between plan and reality with philosophical seriousness. Its most famous sentence —that war is a mere continuation of politics by other means (I.1.24)— subordinates war to the political purpose that alone gives it meaning. Its most profound concept, introduced in the same chapter, is the "remarkable trinity" (*wunderliche Dreifaltigkeit*) of primordial violence and hatred, the play of chance and probability, and war's subordination to reason as an instrument of policy (I.1.28).

Two Clausewitzian concepts structure *The 33 Strategies* more deeply than its explicit citations suggest. The first is friction. "Everything in war is very simple," Clausewitz wrote, "but the simplest thing is difficult" (*es ist alles im Kriege sehr einfach, aber das Einfachste ist schwierig*; I.7): innumerable small difficulties, unforeseeable and unmeasurable, accumulate until they produce a resistance that distinguishes real war from war on paper. To friction he added uncertainty: three-quarters of the factors on which action in war is based lie wrapped in a fog of greater or lesser uncertainty (I.3). The second concept is genius. The military genius, for Clausewitz, possesses not a superior plan but a harmonious combination of powers—above all the *coup d'œil*, the rapid discernment of a truth the ordinary mind perceives only after long study, and the determination (*Entschlossenheit*) to act on that discernment amid uncertainty (I.3). Greene's third strategy, "Amidst the Turmoil of Events, Do Not Lose Your Presence of Mind," is Clausewitz's theory of genius rendered as discipline, and the German military term *Fingerspitzengefühl*—fingertip feel, the intuitive sense of a fluid situation—which Greene adopts, names the same faculty. It will become, in *Mastery*, the defining attribute of the master in every field.

Two further concepts govern the offensive and terminal strategies. Clausewitz's center of gravity (*Schwerpunkt*), the hub of all power and movement on which everything depends, becomes the sixteenth strategy, "Hit Them Where It Hurts." And the culminating point of victory—the point beyond which an attacker's advance, having exhausted its superiority, begins to weaken him, so that further success produces reversal

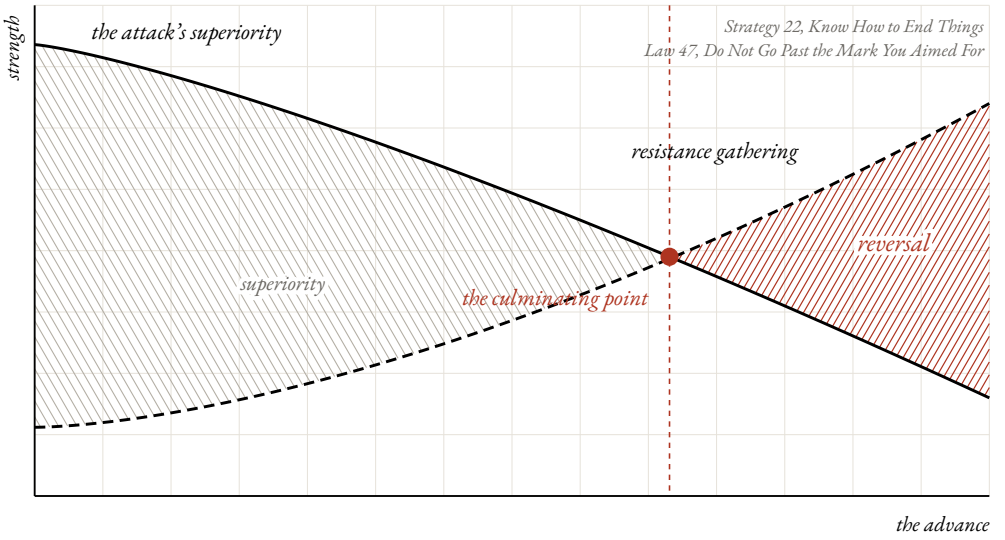


Fig. 4.2 *The culminating point of victory.* A schematic after Clausewitz: the attacker's superiority wanes as it advances while resistance gathers; beyond the point where they cross, further success produces reversal (§4.3).

—grounds the twenty-second strategy, "Know How to End Things," and Law 47 before it. The culminating point is the military form of the Delphic μηδὲν ἄγαν and of Solon's warning to Croesus. It is also, as Chapter Two argued of Law 47, a crack in the frontal logic of power: the recognition that success pursued without limit converts itself into ruin.

The twentieth century added three heirs whose influence on Greene's theory of conflict is pervasive. Basil Liddell Hart, in *The Decisive Wars of History* (1929), expanded as *Strategy: The Indirect Approach* (1954), argued from a survey of twenty-five centuries that decisive results have almost always come from approaches that dislocate the enemy psychologically and physically before battle rather than from direct assault; the eighteenth strategy, "Expose and Attack Your Opponent's Soft Flank," and much of Greene's unconventional warfare are Liddell Hart's doctrine applied to everyday conflict. The historiography supplies an irony Greene would appreciate. John Mearsheimer's *Liddell Hart and the Weight of History* (1988) showed that Liddell Hart cultivated after 1945 an exaggerated reputation as the intellectual father of German armored warfare, encouraging, among other things, the insertion of a tribute to himself into the English edition of a German general's memoirs: the

theorist of indirection practiced it upon his own reputation, as Law 5 would advise.

John Boyd, the American fighter pilot and theorist, supplied the theory of tempo. His OODA loop—observe, orient, decide, act—held that the combatant who cycles through this loop faster than his opponent operates "inside" the opponent's decision cycle, generating confusion until the opponent's picture of the world collapses; and his essay "Destruction and Creation" (1976), invoking Gödel's incompleteness theorems, Heisenberg's uncertainty principle, and the second law of thermodynamics, argued that every closed conceptual system degrades, so that adaptation requires the continual destruction of one's own concepts and the creation of new ones. Boyd's epistemology gives Greene's second strategy, "Do Not Fight the Last War," a theoretical foundation, and it is Heraclitean to the core: the strategist must remain a river. Thomas Schelling supplied the theory of commitment. In *The Strategy of Conflict* (1960) and *Arms and Influence* (1966), Schelling showed that the capacity to bind oneself—to burn one's bridges and so make one's threats credible—can be a source of power, and that a threat that leaves something to chance may deter more effectively than one whose execution depends on deliberate choice. Cortés's ships and Xiang Yu's cauldrons are Schelling's commitment avant la lettre, and Greene's tenth strategy, "Create a Threatening Presence," applies the logic of deterrence to an individual's reputation for retaliation. The Prussian *Kriegsspiel* devised by Georg von Reisswitz and his son in the early nineteenth century, and its descendants in the war games of general staffs and the game theory of the Cold War, complete the lineage: strategy becomes simulation, and simulation, as a later section shows, becomes one of the privileged sites in which the tradition reflects on itself.

4.4 *Friend and Enemy: Schmitt, Foucault, and the Privatization of War*

Greene's first strategy, "Declare War on Your Enemies: The Polarity Strategy," instructs the reader to identify his enemies clearly, to define himself against them, and to draw from opposition the energy and clarity that a life of vague goodwill dissipates. It is the most philosophically consequential of the thirty-three, because it restates in the register of personal conduct the thesis with which Carl Schmitt opened *Der Begriff des Politischen* (1927; expanded 1932): that the specifically political distinction,

to which all political actions and motives can be reduced, is the distinction between friend and enemy. The enemy, Schmitt insisted, is the public adversary rather than the private one—*hostis* rather than *inimicus*—and he observed that the Gospel's command to love one's enemies (*diligite inimicos vestros*) concerns the private enemy, not the political foe. The enemy is the other, the stranger, whose existence in a concrete situation signifies the negation of one's own form of life.

Greene's polarity strategy performs on Schmitt the operation Chapter Two found it performing on Machiavelli: it privatizes the political. Schmitt's distinction defined the sovereign's prerogative to identify the public enemy; Greene transfers that prerogative to the individual, who becomes the sovereign of his own wars. The reason of state became the reason of self; the politics of enmity becomes a psychology of enmity. The transposition is not innocent. Schmitt joined the National Socialist party in 1933 and lent his jurisprudence to the regime, and his concept of the political has remained the theoretical grammar of movements that constitute their identity through the designation of internal and external enemies. A self constituted by its enemies is structurally analogous to a polity so constituted, and it shares that polity's characteristic pathology: the need to find, or to manufacture, new enemies when the old are defeated. Schmitt's late *Theorie des Partisanen* (1963), which identified the partisan by his irregularity, mobility, intensity of commitment, and attachment to a particular soil, supplies, moreover, the figure behind Greene's fifth part, on unconventional warfare, and behind his "strategy of the void"—a figure whose most eloquent self-description belongs to T. E. Lawrence, who wrote in 1920 that regular armies were like rooted plants, while his Arab irregulars "might be a vapour, blowing where we listed."

Michel Foucault confronted the same premise from the opposite political direction. In the lectures of 1976 published as *Il faut défendre la société*, Foucault proposed to invert Clausewitz: perhaps politics is the continuation of war by other means, so that the apparent peace of civil society conceals a perpetual war, institutionalized in laws, inequalities, and discourses, whose history could be written as the history of a struggle between groups. He traced this "historico-political discourse" to the seventeenth century and tested whether war could serve as the grid of intelligibility for relations of power in general. The hypothesis is precisely the premise of *The 33 Strategies*, which treats the courteous surface of social life as the disguise of permanent conflict. But Foucault did not retain it. In the lectures that followed he turned from war to government

—power understood as the conduct of conduct rather than as battle—and thence, in the 1980s, to the care of the self. Foucault's trajectory and Greene's are once again parallel: the war hypothesis is a stage both passed through on the way from the analysis of power over others to the cultivation of the self.

Two theoretical correctives clarify what the polarity strategy omits. Chantal Mouffe's agonistic pluralism (*The Return of the Political*, 1993; *On the Political*, 2005) accepted Schmitt's claim that conflict is ineradicable from politics but argued that democratic politics consists in transforming antagonism into agonism—the enemy who must be destroyed into the adversary whose existence is legitimate and whose defeat is provisional. The distinction separates a vigorous competitive life from the polemological self: the adversary is opposed within a shared world; the enemy is opposed as a threat to the world's existence. René Girard supplied the second corrective. In *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) he showed that rivals locked in mimetic conflict come increasingly to resemble one another, until each becomes the "monstrous double" of the other; the enemy against whom one defines oneself becomes one's mirror. The polarity strategy, pursued without limit, yields not a sharper identity but one indistinguishable from the enemy's. Hegel's account in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) of the struggle for recognition, in which self-consciousness seeks confirmation through a life-and-death contest with another, discloses the root of the difficulty: the self that needs an enemy in order to be itself has made its identity dependent on the very other it seeks to negate. The polemological self is a dependent self. That dependency is the deepest reason the corpus could not end with *The 33 Strategies*, and why its later books turn from the enemy without to the self within.

The Constitutive Metaphor: ARGUMENT IS WAR and the Petrifying Force 4.5

Greene's claim that social life is war is usually read either as a literal description or as a figure of speech. George Lakoff and Mark Johnson's *Metaphors We Live By* (1980) showed why it is neither. Their first and most famous example was the conceptual metaphor ARGUMENT IS WAR, manifest in the ordinary language in which claims are indefensible, positions are attacked, weak points are targeted, criticisms land on target, and arguments are won, lost, or demolished. The metaphor, they argued,

is not merely a way of talking about arguments; it structures what we do when we argue. We treat our interlocutor as an opponent, defend our positions, plan our strategies, and actually win and lose. Lakoff and Johnson invited their readers to imagine a culture in which argument was conceived as a dance, its participants as performers, and its goal as a balanced and pleasing performance—a culture whose members would not experience what we call arguing as arguing at all.

The implication for the corpus is that LIFE IS WAR is a constitutive metaphor: it does not describe a pre-existing reality so much as organize the experience of those who adopt it. A reader who learns to perceive his workplace, his friendships, and his intimate life as fields of covert warfare will act accordingly, and his actions will provoke the defensive and retaliatory responses that confirm his perception. The polemological self is, in this sense, a self-fulfilling prophecy. Deborah Tannen's *The Argument Culture* (1998)—published, strikingly, in the same year as *The 48 Laws*—diagnosed the same dynamic in public discourse, arguing that the reflexive framing of every issue as a battle between two sides degraded inquiry, journalism, and law by converting each disagreement into a contest to be won rather than a problem to be understood.

Simone Weil's "L'Iliade ou le poème de la force," written as France fell in 1940, carried the critique to its depth. The true subject of the *Iliad*, Weil argued, is force, and force is that which turns anyone subjected to it into a thing—most literally a corpse, but also, short of killing, a being still alive yet petrified, deprived of the inner life that makes a person a person. Her most unsettling insight was that force petrifies not only those who suffer it but those who wield it: the warrior intoxicated by force becomes as much its thing as his victim, acting without reflection, unable to pause, carried by a momentum he mistakes for will. The polemological self is the self petrified by its own force in exactly Weil's sense.

Yet *The 33 Strategies* is not simply an apology for the warlike disposition, and its structure contains a pacifying countercurrent easily missed. Its defensive strategies counsel economy: "Pick Your Battles Carefully," "Trade Space for Time." Its grand strategy subordinates battles to the long-term purpose they serve: "Lose Battles but Win the War." Its offensive sequence culminates not in annihilation but in termination: "Know How to End Things." And its deepest authority, Sun Tzu, holds that the acme of skill is to win without fighting at all. Read whole, the book's theory of war tends toward the minimization of war—toward a strategy so complete in its understanding of the field that battle becomes unnecessary. This tendency is the military form of the anamorphosis. The frontal

image of *The 33 Strategies* is a manual for perpetual combat; its oblique image is a discipline whose perfection would render combat superfluous. The book's greatest strategist, by its own standards, would be the one who never needed to fight.

The Epics of War: The Iliad*, the* Mahābhārata*, and the Vision of Time* 4.6

The great war epics test the strategies against the tradition's oldest knowledge, and they converge on a single, astonishing discovery: the extremity of war produces in its participants a vision of the common mortality of friend and enemy.

The *Iliad* opens with the word μῆνιν, wrath—the wrath of Achilles that brought countless sorrows upon the Achaeans (*Il.* 1.1). The epic is, among other things, a study in the failure of presence of mind: Achilles, insulted by Agamemnon, withdraws from battle and lets his companions die, and when Patroclus is killed his grief becomes a rage that exceeds every limit. He has been offered a choice of fates—a short life with imperishable glory or a long life without it (9.410–416)—and his choice is the warrior's death-ground strategy, the commitment that removes every retreat. Gregory Nagy's *The Best of the Achaeans* (1979) reconstructed the opposition between Achilles' *biē*, force, and Odysseus's *mētis*, cunning, as the structuring tension of the Homeric tradition, and Troy falls not to Achilles' strength but to Odysseus's stratagem: the wooden horse, a gift that seduces the city into opening its own walls (*Od.* 8.492–520), against which Virgil's Laocoön warned *timeo Danaos et dona ferentes*, I fear the Greeks even bearing gifts (*Aen.* 2.49). The horse is the hinge between the corpus's theory of seduction and its theory of war: the decisive act of the war is a seduction, and the seduction is a weapon.

But the *Iliad* does not end with the horse; it ends with an encounter that suspends the war. In the twenty-fourth book Priam enters the Achaean camp by night to ransom the body of Hector from the man who killed him. He kisses the hands that slew his son and asks Achilles to remember his own father. The two enemies weep together—Priam for Hector, Achilles for his father and for Patroclus—and Achilles speaks of the two jars on the floor of Zeus's house, one of evils and one of blessings, from which the god deals out the lots of mortals (24.527–533). When the weeping is done, the old king and the young warrior gaze at one another in wonder: Priam marvels at Achilles' stature and beauty, like a god's;

Achilles marvels at Priam's noble face and his words (24.629–632). It is the most extraordinary moment in the West's oldest poem, and it is the metic sublime in its tragic form. The enemies, having exercised force to its limit, see each other as mortals sharing a common fate, and the war—which will resume after the twelve days' truce Achilles grants—is for that interval suspended in a vision larger than itself.

The *Mahābhārata* performs the same discovery on a cosmic scale and with still more unsettling moral complexity. The war at Kurukṣetra between the Pāṇḍavas and their Kaurava cousins is won at decisive moments by stratagems that violate the dharma of war. Droṇa, the Kauravas' invincible general, lays down his arms when the scrupulously truthful Yudhiṣṭhira announces that "Aśvatthāman is dead"—Aśvatthāman being both Droṇa's son and an elephant just slain—while muttering the qualification inaudibly; Duryodhana falls when Bhīma, at Krishna's prompting, strikes him below the waist in a mace duel whose rules forbid it. Krishna, the divine strategist, is the epic's master of *kūṭa-yuddha*, deceptive warfare, and the epic never fully resolves whether his stratagems were justified. Its aftermath answers more clearly than any treatise the question posed by Greene's twenty-second strategy. The victors inherit a kingdom of widows; the *Strī Parva* is given over to the lament of the women of both sides; Yudhiṣṭhira falls into a despair so deep that he wishes to renounce the throne he has won; and the epic ends with the brothers and their wife walking toward the Himalayas and falling one by one, until only Yudhiṣṭhira, followed by a dog, reaches the gate of heaven. The greatest victory in Indian literature ends in a pilgrimage of the dying.

At its center the *Mahābhārata* contains the text that gives this dissertation's concept its paradigm. The *Bhagavad Gītā* opens on the battlefield, with Arjuna, the supreme archer, seized by despair (*viṣāda*) at the sight of his kinsmen and teachers arrayed against him; he lets fall his bow and refuses to fight. It is the archetypal loss of presence of mind. Krishna restores it through a discipline of equanimity: Arjuna's right is to action alone, never to its fruits (*karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana*, 2.47), and evenness of mind is called yoga (*samatvaṃ yoga ucyate*, 2.48). Then, in the eleventh chapter, Krishna reveals his universal form (*viśvarūpa*): a blazing vision of countless mouths and eyes into which the warriors of both armies rush like moths into a flame. "I am Time," the god declares, "grown mature, the destroyer of worlds" (*kālo 'smi lokakṣayakṛt pravṛddho*, 11.32)—the line J. Robert Oppenheimer recalled two decades after the first nuclear test. And Krishna adds the sentence that defines the metic sublime: the warriors before Arjuna are already slain by Time, and

Arjuna is to be merely the instrument (*nimitta-mātram*, 11.33). Arjuna trembles and begs the god to resume his gentle human form.

The vision is the summit of the strategist's experience. Arjuna, the most skilled warrior of his age, sees the battlefield he was about to master revealed as a field of forces—Time, destiny, cosmic order—beside which his skill is instrumental and his agency derivative. The vision does not abolish his action; it reorders it. He will fight, but as one who knows he is not the author of the outcome. This is the precise structure of the metic sublime: cunning intelligence, carried to the limit of its reading of the field, perceives the field as vaster than itself and the self as one of its instruments. The terror Arjuna feels is the Kantian component of the experience; the reordered action that follows is its practical fruit. Greene's corpus, which has spent three books teaching its reader to master the field, reaches through its theory of war the threshold of Arjuna's vision.

Fearlessness: The 50th Law*, the Street, and the Way of the Samurai* 4.7

If *The 33 Strategies* anatomizes the forms of conflict, *The 50th Law* identifies the affect that disables them. Its thesis is that fear—of death, of failure, of the opinion of others, of uncertainty—is the root of human passivity, and that the capacity to act decisively depends on its mastery. The book fuses two narratives: the life of Curtis Jackson, born in 1975, whose mother was killed when he was eight, who dealt drugs in adolescence, was shot nine times in 2000, and became a platinum-selling artist and investor; and the lives of historical figures who exemplify each of its ten virtues. The fusion is the book's distinctive contribution. *The 50th Law* presents the street not as the opposite of the court but as its starkest version—a Hobbesian environment in which reputation is literally a matter of survival and intense realism the precondition of staying alive—and it presents the hustler as a strategist whose education was purchased at a price no court ever exacted.

Each of the book's virtues has a philosophical genealogy that its vernacular conceals. "Intense realism" is Machiavelli's *verità effettuale* restated as a survival skill. "Self-reliance" borrows the title of Emerson's essay of 1841, whose injunction—"Trust thyself: every heart vibrates to that iron string"—founded the American tradition of individual sovereignty from which the corpus descends. "Turn shit into sugar" is the Stoic transvaluation of adversity in the street's idiom: Marcus Aurelius wrote

that the impediment to action advances action and what stands in the way becomes the way (*Meditations* 5.20), and Epictetus, born a slave, taught that people are disturbed not by things but by their judgments about things (*Enchiridion* 5). The revival of popular Stoicism led by Greene's former research assistant Ryan Holiday took the title of its manifesto, *The Obstacle Is the Way* (2014), from Marcus's sentence.

The deepest strand of the book's genealogy is the African American tradition of liberation through confrontation, and its locus classicus is Frederick Douglass's *Narrative* (1845). Douglass recounts how, at sixteen, he was hired out to Edward Covey, a man notorious for "breaking" young slaves, whose beatings had reduced him to despair, and how one day he resolved to resist and fought Covey for nearly two hours until Covey gave up. "You have seen how a man was made a slave," Douglass writes; "you shall see how a slave was made a man." The fight was the turning point of his career as a slave: however long he might remain a slave in form, the day had passed forever when he could be a slave in fact. The *Narrative* also contains an episode that binds this chapter to the argument of Chapter Two. As a boy Douglass overheard his master forbid his mistress to continue teaching him to read, on the grounds that learning would unfit a slave for slavery, and he understood in that moment, he writes, "the pathway from slavery to freedom." The master's arcanum —that literacy dissolves domination—was published, inadvertently, to the one person it was meant to exclude, and Douglass turned it into liberation. The scene is the republican reading of the arcana enacted in a single life. Malcolm X's account of copying a dictionary page by page in the Norfolk Prison Colony, which made him first a reader and then an orator, belongs to the same tradition, and it is the prehistory of every incarcerated reader who has sought in Greene's books the knowledge that power withholds.

The other great strand is the warrior's meditation on death. The *Hagakure*, dictated by the samurai Yamamoto Tsunetomo in the early eighteenth century, declares that the way of the samurai is found in death (武士道と云ふは死ぬ事と見付けたり) and counsels the warrior to rehearse his death every morning, so that, having already died in imagination, he may act without fear. The Stoics had taught the same exercise as *praemeditatio malorum*: Seneca urged the rehearsal of exile, poverty, and death, so that nothing might come unforeseen (*Epistulae* 24, 91), and Epictetus counseled keeping death and exile daily before one's eyes (*Enchiridion* 21). Miyamoto Musashi, after a lifetime of duels and the composition of *The Book of Five Rings*, wrote in the week before

his death in 1645 the twenty-one precepts of the *Dokkōdō*, the Path of Aloneness—a sequence of renunciations of regret, attachment, and fear that is the swordsman's version of the Gracián closure. Jim Jarmusch's *Ghost Dog: The Way of the Samurai* (1999) brought the *Hagakure* into the American city: its hero, a hitman who lives by the book's precepts in service to a minor mafioso, moves to a score by the Wu-Tang Clan's RZA and ends by drawing an empty pistol on his own lord, accepting death as the fulfillment of his code. The Wu-Tang Clan, whose debut *Enter the Wu-Tang (36 Chambers)* (1993) fused Shaolin cinema, chess, and the numerological esotericism of the Five Percent Nation, had already constituted hip-hop as a vernacular strategic literature, in which the battle rap realizes Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor as art and the public feud operates as a polarity strategy in Greene's precise sense.

Speculative fiction supplies fearlessness with its most famous formula. In the opening chapter of *Dune*, the young Paul Atreides is tested by a Reverend Mother of the Bene Gesserit with a box that inflicts excruciating pain while a poisoned needle waits at his neck; he must keep his hand in the box or die, and he endures by reciting the order's litany against fear, which names fear as the killer of the mind and teaches the one who faces it to let it pass through, so that only he remains. The test allegorizes *The 50th Law* exactly: humanity, the Reverend Mother explains, consists in the capacity to override the animal's reflex of flight.

The 50th Law concludes with a chapter entitled "The Sublime," whose argument is that the full confrontation with one's own mortality is the ultimate source of fearlessness, because it dissolves the petty fears that govern ordinary life and opens the self to the vastness and strangeness of existence. Here the sublime becomes, for the first time, the explicit title and terminus of one of the corpus's books—nine years before *The Laws of Human Nature* and seventeen before *The Law of the Sublime*. That it appears at the end of the corpus's book of fear, written with a hustler from Queens, is strong evidence for this dissertation's claim that the sublime is reached in Greene through the polemological route, through the extremity of conflict rather than through aesthetic contemplation. The tradition also knows the danger: that the meditation on death be misread as its glorification. Mishima Yukio's commentary on the *Hagakure* (1967), followed three years later by his death in a staged political spectacle, stands as the warning. The *meditatio mortis* aims at a lucidity that intensifies life, not at a cult that consumes it; the sublime of *The 50th Law* belongs to the first, and the anamorphic reading depends on holding that distinction firmly.

4.8 *Strategists of the Counterfactual: Ender, Yang Wen-li, the Swordholder, and the Game*

Speculative fiction tests the strategies under conditions history cannot supply, and its verdicts are severe.

Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* (1985) is the most widely read novel of strategic education in English. Its child commander, trained in zero-gravity battle games and then in simulations of interstellar war, defeats an alien species in what he believes to be a final examination; only afterward does he learn that the simulation was real and that he has destroyed an entire civilization. The deception that produces his victory is the indirect pedagogy weaponized: his teachers lead him into total war by concealing its reality, as the corpus, on this dissertation's reading, leads its reader toward wisdom by concealing its destination. Ender's own theory of strategy is the novel's deepest contribution. He reflects that in the moment he understands his enemy well enough to defeat him, he also loves him—empathy as the condition of annihilation. The sequel, *Speaker for the Dead* (1986), is the palinode: Ender spends his life atoning for the xenocide, writing the history of the species he destroyed so that it may be understood. The strategist's trajectory—victory through total understanding of the enemy, followed by a life devoted to speaking for the dead—recapitulates the arc from *The 33 Strategies* to *The Laws of Human Nature*, and it confirms the duality identified in Chapter Three: the faculty that enables conquest is the faculty that makes atonement possible.

Tanaka Yoshiki's *Legend of the Galactic Heroes* (novels 1982–1987; animated series 1988–1997) is the most sustained strategic epic in any medium, and it stages the opposition between Clausewitz and Sun Tzu as an opposition of persons. Reinhard von Lohengramm, the young genius of the autocratic Empire, is a Napoleonic conqueror of overwhelming talent, driven by ambition and by the loss of his sister to the old Kaiser; Yang Wen-li, the reluctant admiral of the democratic Alliance, is a historian who never wished to be a soldier, wins his most famous victories by indirection and the refusal of decisive battle, and wants above all to retire and drink his tea. The saga's long debate on whether a benevolent autocracy is preferable to a corrupt democracy is conducted through their campaigns, and its resolution is anamorphic. Yang, undefeated in the field, is murdered by religious fanatics; Reinhard, having unified the galaxy, dies young of an incurable illness. The two greatest strategists

of the saga are vanquished not by each other but by contingency and mortality—by what Clausewitz called friction and the *Gītā* called Time.

Liu Cixin's *Death's End* (2010), which concludes the trilogy whose Wallfacers illustrated Law 3 in Chapter One, offers the most rigorous fictional treatment of deterrence. After the hero of *The Dark Forest* secures peace by threatening to broadcast the location of the aliens' home world—an act that would doom both civilizations—the threat must be maintained by a "Swordholder" whose willingness to execute it the adversary must believe. When the role passes to a compassionate successor whom the aliens judge incapable of mutual destruction, deterrence collapses within minutes. The episode is Schelling's theory of credible commitment rendered as tragedy, and it exposes the paradox at the heart of Greene's tenth strategy: a threatening presence deters only while its bearer is believed capable of the worst.

Alan Moore and Dave Gibbons's *Watchmen* (1986–1987) supplies the counterfactual of strategy's triumph. Adrian Veidt, "the smartest man in the world," averts nuclear war by staging an alien attack that kills millions in New York and unites the superpowers against a fictitious enemy —a synthesis of Greene's strategies of misperception, terror, and the moral high ground executed on a planetary scale. The plan succeeds. But when Veidt, alone with the godlike Dr. Manhattan, seeks reassurance that it all worked out in the end, Manhattan answers laconically that nothing ever ends. The strategist demands closure; the being who perceives time whole denies that closure exists. Manhattan's perspective is the metic sublime seen from outside: the vantage from which every strategy is a moment in a field without end.

The game, finally, reflects on war with a reflexivity no other medium can match, because it makes its audience the strategist. Allan Calhamer's *Diplomacy* (1959), a board game without dice in which victory depends entirely on negotiation and betrayal, enacts Greene's alliance and diplomatic strategies with notorious effects on the friendships of its players. Yager's *Spec Ops: The Line* (2012), modeled on *Heart of Darkness*, presents itself frontally as a conventional military shooter and then turns upon its player, confronting him with the atrocities his compliance has produced and interrogating his desire to play the hero. It is the anamorphic war game par excellence: the frontal image is the heroic campaign; the oblique image is the skull.

4.9 *The Sky over Austerlitz: The Polemological Route to the Metic Sublime*

No work in any literature follows the polemological route to the metic sublime more completely than Tolstoy's *War and Peace* (1865–1869). The novel is, among other things, a sustained polemic against the theory of war as the imposition of a plan. Its Napoleon believes himself the author of events, issues dispositions, and attributes his victories to his genius; its German theorists, epitomized by the general Pfuel, possess complete systems of war and are helpless before reality; and its Kutuzov —old, heavy, one-eyed, dozing through councils of war—is the novel's wise commander precisely because he knows that he does not control events. Kutuzov waits, trusts the spirit of the army, avoids unnecessary battle, and lets the invasion exhaust itself: he trades space for time, in Greene's vocabulary, but from a conviction deeper than strategy, namely that the outcome will be determined by forces vastly greater than any commander's will. The second epilogue elevates the conviction into a philosophy of history, arguing that the "great men" to whom events are attributed are history's slaves rather than its masters. Kutuzov is the strategist of *shi* in Jullien's sense; Tolstoy's Napoleon is the strategist of the imposed model, undone by friction.

The novel's most famous passage gives the metic sublime its definitive literary image. At Austerlitz in 1805, Prince Andrei Bolkonsky, who had gone to war dreaming of his own Toulon, his own moment of glory, seizes a falling standard and leads a charge. Struck down, he lies on his back and sees above him nothing but the sky—lofty, immeasurably lofty, with gray clouds creeping slowly across it. How quiet and solemn it is, he thinks, not at all like his own running and shouting; how could he not have seen this lofty sky before? Everything is empty and false except that infinite sky. When Napoleon, riding over the field, pauses above the wounded prince and admires his death, Andrei, who had idolized the emperor, finds him small and insignificant beside what is passing between his own soul and that lofty, infinite sky with the clouds racing across it.

The passage contains every element of this dissertation's concept. Andrei has pursued power and glory to the limit of his capacity; at that limit he is struck down, and in the moment of his helplessness he perceives a magnitude that relativizes not only his ambition but the greatest strategist of the age. The perception yields both terror and peace. And it does not end his life or his action: Andrei recovers, returns to the world, and acts again, but as a man for whom glory has lost its sovereignty. That is

the structure of the metic sublime: cunning and ambition carried to their limit, a sudden perception of the impersonal immensity in which they operate, and the reordering—not the abolition—of action that follows. Friedrich's *Wanderer above the Sea of Fog*, invoked in Chapter One, looks down upon the immensity from a summit he has climbed; Andrei looks up at it from the ground where he has fallen. Both are images of a self discovering its scale.

The polemological tradition reaches the same threshold from every side. Heraclitus found that the bow's name is life and its work death. Sun Tzu taught that the highest strategy rides the propensity of things and wins without fighting. Clausewitz found that friction defeats every plan and that victory has a culminating point beyond which it reverses. Achilles and Priam saw each other as mortals in the interval of a truce; Arjuna saw the warriors of both armies already consumed by Time and learned that he was its instrument; Zhuge Liang's effigy commanded after his death; Musashi ended his life with a list of renunciations; Ender became the speaker for the dead he had made; Yang Wen-li and Reinhard were defeated by assassins and illness rather than by each other; Dr. Manhattan told the triumphant strategist that nothing ends. And *The 50th Law*, the corpus's book of fear, ended with a chapter on the sublime.

The chapter's conclusion is that war, the most total exercise of the will to power, is also the domain in which that will most completely discovers its limit. The polemological self—constituted by its enemies, petrified by its own force, dependent on the conflicts that define it—cannot sustain itself indefinitely, because the logic of conflict, pursued to its end, discloses forces before which every combatant is small. The corpus registers this discovery in the movement from *The 33 Strategies* to the final chapter of *The 50th Law*, and it registers a second consequence in the book that follows. Having learned that the field cannot be mastered by force, the strategist turns from the enemy to the material: from the war against other wills to the patient apprenticeship in which intelligence works with the grain of things rather than against it. That turn is the subject of *Mastery*, and its emblem, as Chapter Five will argue, is not the general but the cook whose knife never dulls because it follows the natural joints of the ox.



Plate V. *Stretched 2.4 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 25° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER FIVE

The Knife of Cook Ding

Mastery, *Mētis*, and the Paradox of Transmissible Genius

臣之所好者道也，進乎技矣。
— *Zhuangzi* 3

μήτι τοι δρυτόμος μέγ' ἀμείνων ἠὲ βίηφι.
— Homer, *Iliad* 23.315

Die Kunst ist lang, das Leben kurz, das Urteil schwierig, die Gelegenheit flüchtig.
— Goethe, *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre* VII.9

5.1 *The Net of Hephaestus: From* Mētis *as Cunning to* Mētis *as Craft*

In the eighth book of the *Odyssey*, the blind bard Demodocus sings at the Phaeacian court of how Ares, god of war, lay in secret with Aphrodite, goddess of desire, in the house of her husband Hephaestus. The lame smith, informed by the Sun, forges chains as fine as spider-silk, invisible even to the gods, hangs them about his bed, and feigns departure; the lovers are caught and held fast, and Hephaestus summons the gods, who break into unquenchable laughter (*Od.* 8.266–366). One of them draws the moral: ill deeds do not prosper; the slow overtakes the swift—κιχάνει τοι βραδὺς ὠκύν (8.329). The song is a précis of this chapter's place in the corpus. The craftsman god, without strength and without beauty, defeats war and desire together by a work of his hands. After the lyre of seduction and the bow of war comes the net of the artisan; after Aphrodite and Ares comes Hephaestus; and the victory belongs, for once, to slowness.

The Homeric tradition knew that cunning and craft are one intelligence. In the twenty-third book of the *Iliad*, Nestor counsels his son Antilochus before the chariot race: it is by *mētis* rather than strength that the woodcutter excels, by *mētis* that the helmsman steers his swift ship through the winds on the wine-dark sea, by *mētis* that charioteer surpasses charioteer (*Il.* 23.315–318). Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant opened *Les Ruses de l'intelligence* with this race, and their reconstruction showed that one word designated the fox's trick and the carpenter's skill, Odysseus's stratagems and Athena's patronage of weaving and woodwork, the hunter's net and the smith's chains. James C. Scott, in *Seeing Like a State* (1998)—published, like so much of this dissertation's context, in the year of *The 48 Laws*—extended the concept to practical knowledge in general: the situated, experiential, improvisational knowledge of farmers, navigators, and artisans that schemes of state simplification ignore at their peril, and that cannot be reduced to the codified, universal knowledge Scott called *technē*. *Mētis*, in Scott's usage, is knowledge that lives in practice and dies when extracted from it.

Mastery (2012) is the book in which Greene's corpus turns from the first face of *mētis* to the second. Its six parts trace a single trajectory: the discovery of one's calling, or "Life's Task," in the "primal inclinations" of childhood; the "Ideal Apprenticeship," in which the novice submits to the reality of a field; the "Mentor Dynamic," in which he absorbs and finally surpasses a master; "Social Intelligence," in which he learns to see people as they are; the "Creative-Active," in which the "dimensional

mind" breaks with convention; and mastery proper, the fusion of the intuitive and the rational. Its exempla are drawn from the history of art and science—Leonardo, Darwin, Faraday, Mozart, Goethe, Franklin, Einstein—and from interviews with living practitioners, among them the neuroscientist V. S. Ramachandran, the animal scientist Temple Grandin, and the boxing trainer Freddie Roach. Its thesis is democratic and anti-romantic: mastery is not the gift of innate genius but the product of time, focus, and a sequence of stages open, in principle, to anyone who follows an authentic inclination.

The book retains the vocabulary of power—its introduction presents mastery as "the ultimate power"—and in this the frontal image persists, as it persists in the publisher's promise, a decade and a half later, to "master the power of the Sublime." But the object of power has changed. The strategist of the earlier books sought power over other wills; the master of *Mastery* seeks a power that works with the grain of a material, a domain, a reality that resists manipulation and rewards submission. The adversary is no longer a rival but the difficulty of the craft; the reward is no longer advantage but a transformed relation to the world. This chapter argues that *Mastery* constitutes the corpus's decisive turn from *mētis* as cunning to *mētis* as craft, and that in this turn the metic sublime acquires its serene form: not the terror of Arjuna before Time, but the stillness of the cook whose knife moves through the ox without resistance. It also argues that the book confronts a paradox it cannot entirely resolve—that the knowledge it celebrates is precisely the knowledge that cannot be transmitted by books—and that this paradox, read through the thesis of indirect pedagogy, is the key to the book's function. The chapter ends by asking what remains of Greene's model of apprenticeship in a world where machines have begun to master the crafts apprentices once learned on.

5.2 *Habit, Hand, and Tacit Knowledge: Aristotle, Polanyi, Merleau-Ponty, Heidegger*

The philosophical foundations of *Mastery* lie in a tradition that runs from Aristotle to twentieth-century phenomenology, and that Greene draws on more than he cites. Aristotle distinguished *technē*, the productive knowledge of the craftsman, from *epistēmē*, demonstrative knowledge of what cannot be otherwise, and both from *phronēsis*, the practical wisdom that perceives what is to be done in particular circumstances

(*Nicomachean Ethics* VI). Two of his observations are foundational for any theory of mastery. The first concerns acquisition: we become builders by building and lyre-players by playing the lyre, and in the same way we become just by doing just acts (*NE* II.1, 1103a33–b2). Competence is not first understood and then applied; it is formed in the doing, as a disposition (*hexis*) laid down by repetition. The second concerns time: the young may become geometers and mathematicians but not men of practical wisdom, because practical wisdom concerns particulars, which become familiar only through experience, and experience takes time (VI.8, 1142a12–16). Greene's insistence that mastery requires years of apprenticeship is Aristotle's point about the temporality of *phronēsis*.

Michael Polanyi gave the tradition its modern epistemology. In *Personal Knowledge* (1958) and *The Tacit Dimension* (1966) he argued that all knowing rests on a tacit component that resists full articulation: we recognize a face among thousands without being able to say how; the cyclist keeps his balance by following a rule of which he is unaware, turning his wheel toward the side on which he is falling; the medical student learns to read an X-ray not by applying rules but by gradually coming to see what the expert sees. Polanyi distinguished focal awareness, directed at the object of attention, from subsidiary awareness, through which we attend —the hammer's handle felt in the palm while attention rests on the nail —and argued that skill consists in the progressive incorporation of tools, rules, and particulars into subsidiary awareness, where they cease to be objects and become extensions of the knower. His conclusion shadows *Mastery* throughout: an art that cannot be specified in detail cannot be transmitted by prescription, and passes only by example, from master to apprentice, in the intimacy of shared practice.

Phenomenology described the same incorporation from the side of the body. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phénoménologie de la perception* (1945) observed that an accomplished organist, confronted with an unfamiliar instrument, needs only an hour of rehearsal to perform on it—not by memorizing the positions of its stops, but by incorporating the instrument into his bodily schema, as the blind man's cane ceases to be an object and becomes an organ of touch, its tip the place where he feels the world. Heidegger's analysis of the hammer in *Sein und Zeit* made the point ontological. In skilled use the tool withdraws: the carpenter does not perceive the hammer but hammers, and the hammer is "ready-to-hand" (*zuhanden*), transparent to the work (§15). Only when it breaks, is missing, or obstructs does it become conspicuous as an object (§16). Mastery, on this account, is the condition in which the instruments of a

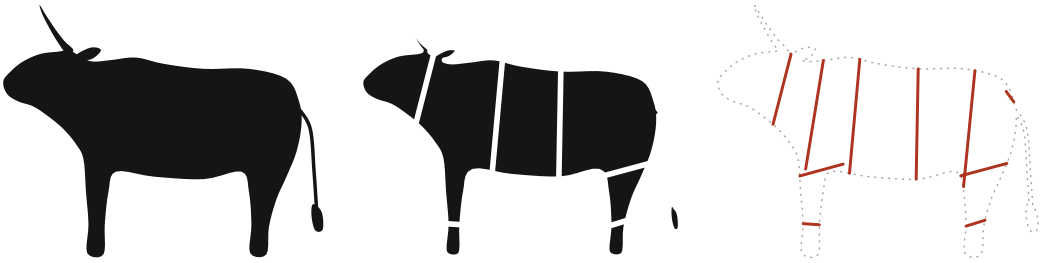
practice—tools, techniques, rules, even the body—have become so fully ready-to-hand that the practitioner dwells in the work itself.

Greene's final chapter names this condition with the term he had already borrowed for the strategist: *Fingerspitzengefühl*, fingertip feel. The master, he argues, after years of immersion, develops an intuitive grasp of the whole of his field, a capacity to sense patterns and possibilities toward which the novice must laboriously reason—an intuition that is not the opposite of reason but its sedimented form. The claim unites the Clausewitzian *coup d'œil* of Chapter Four with Polanyi's tacit dimension and Heidegger's withdrawal of the tool. It also prepares the paradox the next section must confront. If mastery is tacit, incorporated, and ready-to-hand, then the knowledge that matters most is precisely the knowledge a book cannot contain.

The Knife of Cook Ding and the Wheelwright's Dregs 5.3

The deepest meditation on mastery in any tradition is preserved in the *Zhuangzi*. In its third chapter, "The Lord of Nourishing Life" (養生主), Cook Ding carves an ox for Lord Wenhui with such fluency that every movement—the touch of his hand, the lean of his shoulder, the plant of his foot—falls into the rhythm of an ancient dance. Asked how he attained such skill, the cook replies that what he cares about is the Dao, which goes beyond skill (臣之所好者道也，進乎技矣). When he began, he saw nothing but whole oxen; after three years he no longer saw the whole ox; now he meets it with his spirit rather than looking with his eyes (以神遇而不以目視), and his spirit moves where it wishes, following the natural pattern (依乎天理). A good cook changes his knife once a year, because he cuts; an ordinary cook once a month, because he hacks; Cook Ding has used his for nineteen years on thousands of oxen, and its edge is as fresh as if newly taken from the whetstone, because he passes the blade, which has no thickness, through the spaces between the joints, which always have room. At a difficult knot he slows, his gaze settles, he moves the blade with the slightest touch, and the ox falls apart like a clod of earth crumbling to the ground. Lord Wenhui exclaims that from the cook's words he has learned how to nourish life.

The parable contains a complete theory of mastery and the corpus's central reversal. Its three stages—seeing the whole ox, no longer seeing it, meeting it with the spirit—describe the passage from novice perception through analytical articulation to an intuitive mode in which the struc-



I
The whole ox
when he began, he saw nothing but whole oxen

II
No longer the whole ox
after three years he no longer saw the whole ox

III
Meeting it with the spirit
not looking with the eyes; the blade where nothing resists

Fig. 5.1 *Three ways of seeing an ox.* Cook Ding's stages (*Zhuangzi* 3): at first the whole ox; after three years, no longer the whole ox; at last he meets it with the spirit, and the blade goes where resistance is absent (§5.3).

ture of the material guides the hand. Its knife that never dulls defines mastery as the opposite of force: the master does not overcome resistance but finds where resistance is absent. And its frame turns skill into a way of life: what Lord Wenhui learns from a cook is not butchery but how to nourish life. The strategist of *The 33 Strategies* imposes his will upon a resisting field; Cook Ding follows the grain of a field that, rightly perceived, offers no resistance. The knife is the anti-sword.

The nineteenth chapter extends the theory through a gallery of masters. Woodworker Qing, before carving a bell-stand, fasts until he has forgotten reward, then praise and blame, and finally his own body, and only then enters the forest to find the tree in which the bell-stand already waits. An old man swims in the cataract at Lüliang, where no fish could live, explaining that he goes in with the whirl and comes out with the eddy, following the way of the water and imposing nothing of his own (從水之道而不為私焉): Law 48's formlessness transfigured from a stratagem against enemies into harmony with a current. And Ji Xingzi trains a fighting cock for a king until, after forty days, it looks like a cock carved of wood (望之似木雞矣); its virtue is complete, and other cocks, seeing it, turn and flee. The wooden gamecock is the bridge between the corpus's theory of war and its theory of mastery: Sun Tzu's victory without battle, achieved not by stratagem but by a completeness of being that renders combat unnecessary.

The thirteenth chapter supplies the paradox. Duke Huan is reading in his hall when the wheelwright Bian, working below, asks what he reads. The words of the sages, says the duke. Are the sages alive? No, they are dead. Then what your lordship reads, says the wheelwright, is only the dregs of the ancients (古人之糟魄已夫). Threatened with death unless he can explain himself, Bian describes his craft. When he chisels a wheel, if he strikes too gently the chisel slips, if too hard it jams; neither too gentle nor too hard—he gets it in his hand and answers it with his heart, but his mouth cannot put it into words; there is a knack in it somewhere. He cannot teach it to his son, and his son cannot learn it from him; and so, at seventy, he is still chiseling wheels. The ancients and what they could not transmit died together, and what remains in books is dregs.

Bian's argument is the most radical objection to *Mastery* ever formulated, and it was formulated more than two thousand years before the book was written. If the essence of skill lies in a knack between hand and heart that the mouth cannot articulate, then a book about mastery transmits only its dregs. Plato's Socrates raised a cognate objection to writing as such: it gives its readers not wisdom but the conceit of wisdom, so that they seem to know much while knowing nothing (*Phaedrus* 275a–b). History supplies the proofs. Antonio Stradivari's methods died with him in 1737, and three centuries of analysis have not fully recovered them; Richard Sennett's *The Craftsman* (2008) took the lost secret as emblematic of the workshop's dependence on tacit transmission. Diderot's *Encyclopédie*, whose eleven volumes of plates (1762–1772) sought to make the knowledge of every trade explicit, displayed the tools and gestures of the crafts with unprecedented clarity and could not thereby make its readers craftsmen. Zeami, the theorist of Noh, held that the flower of the actor's art lives in what is withheld—hidden, it is the flower; unhidden, it cannot be the flower (秘すれば花なり、秘せずば花なるべからず)—so that the arcanum of the craft, unlike the arcanum of the court in Chapter Two, cannot be published at all, because it exists only in practice. How a book can teach what cannot be written is the question the rest of this chapter must answer.

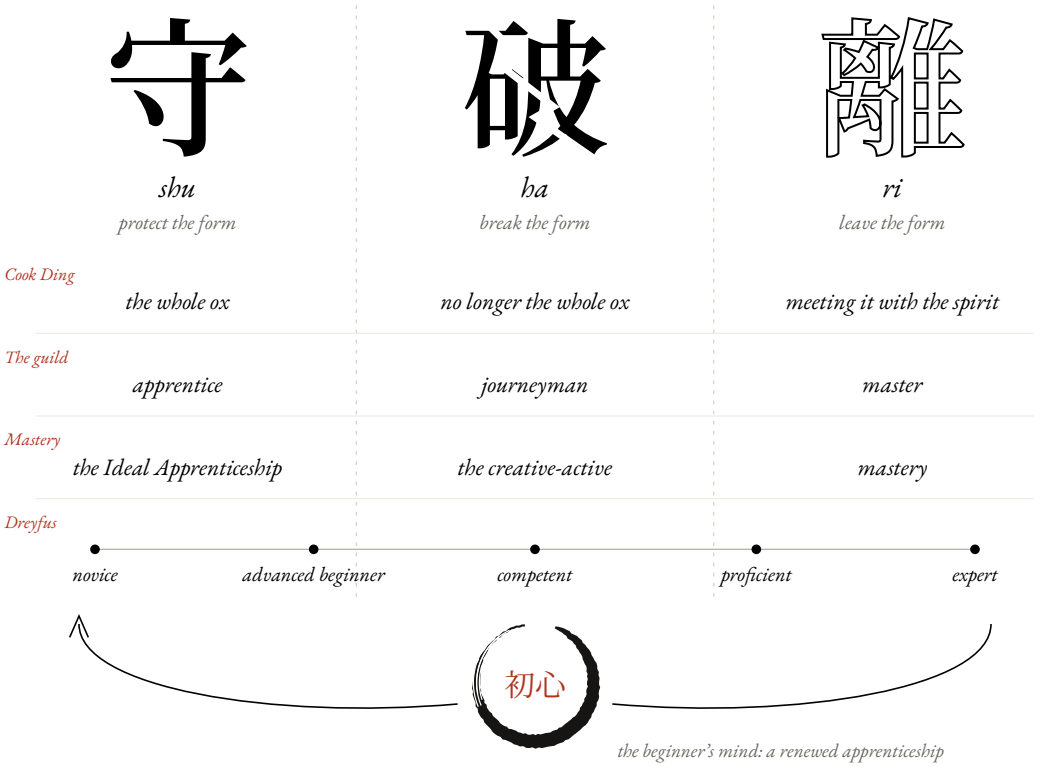
5.4 *Stages of the Way:* Shuhari, *Dreyfus, Ericsson, and the Ideal Apprenticeship*

Mastery's answer to Wheelwright Bian lies in its theory of stages, which does not claim to transmit the knack but to describe the path along which

it is acquired. The Ideal Apprenticeship proceeds through three phases: deep observation, a passive mode in which the novice studies the rules, conventions, and power relations of his environment; skills acquisition, a practice mode in which he submits to repetition until skills become automatic; and experimentation, an active mode in which he begins to take risks and test his own ideas. The book's six parts extend the sequence across a life, from apprenticeship through the creative-active phase to mastery.

The structure is ancient and cross-cultural. The guilds of medieval and early modern Europe institutionalized a three-stage passage—apprentice, journeyman, master—in which the journeyman's years of wandering from workshop to workshop, the German *Wanderjahre* and the French *tour de France* of the *compagnons*, preceded the submission of a masterpiece, the *chef-d'œuvre* that admitted its maker to the guild. The Japanese arts formulated the same passage as *shuhari* (守破離): first protect the form, obeying the teacher's rules exactly; then break the form, departing from them as understanding grows; finally leave the form, acting freely from a mastery that no longer needs rules. *Shuhari* corresponds precisely to the arc of *Mastery*, from the submission of apprenticeship through the rebellion of the creative-active to the freedom of the master—and to the three stages of Cook Ding. Hubert and Stuart Dreyfus, in *Mind over Machine* (1986), gave the passage its modern phenomenological form: the novice follows context-free rules; the advanced beginner recognizes situational aspects; the competent performer plans deliberately; the proficient performer perceives situations holistically; and the expert acts intuitively, without conscious deliberation, from a vast repertoire of experienced situations. The expert, on their account, has left the rules behind.

The empirical psychology of expertise supplied the popular literature of mastery with its most cited figure and its most important caution. K. Anders Ericsson and his colleagues, studying violinists at the Berlin Academy of Music, reported in 1993 that the best performers had accumulated roughly ten thousand hours of solitary "deliberate practice"—effortful, focused on weaknesses, guided by feedback, and not inherently enjoyable—by the age of twenty, far more than their less accomplished peers. Malcolm Gladwell's *Outliers* (2008) popularized the figure as a "ten-thousand-hour rule," a simplification Ericsson himself later rejected (*Peak*, 2016). The caution came in 2014, when a meta-analysis by Brooke Macnamara, David Hambrick, and Frederick Oswald found that deliberate practice, though important, explained only a modest share of the



Stages of the way. Shu, ha, ri (守破離), protect, break and leave the form, aligned with Cook Ding's three stages, the guild's apprentice, journeyman and master, the Dreyfus model and the arc of *Mastery*. The beginner's mind (初心) closes the circle (§5.4). *Fig. 5.2*

variance in performance—about a quarter in games, a fifth in music, less in sports, and very little in education and the professions. Practice is necessary, but it is not the whole story; talent, opportunity, timing, and the structure of the domain matter too. *Mastery*'s democratic thesis must be read with this qualification, and with Pierre Bourdieu's reminder in *La Distinction* (1979) that dispositions, and the time to cultivate them, are unequally distributed. Darwin's apprenticeship aboard the *Beagle* was underwritten by a family fortune; Faraday's began in a bookbinder's shop. The book's exemplars include both, and the difference between them is not incidental.

The psychology of experience supplies mastery's affective correlate. Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi's *Flow* (1990) described the state that arises when a challenge is matched to a high level of skill: attention becomes total, action and awareness merge, the sense of time alters, and self-consciousness disappears. Flow is the everyday form of the metic sublime

in its serene variant. In the fully absorbed performance the practitioner forgets himself, not because a magnitude has overwhelmed him, as it overwhelmed Arjuna, but because the work has absorbed the self that would otherwise stand apart from it. Shunryu Suzuki's *Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind* (1970) located the master's secret in the recovery of the beginner's openness (*shoshin*, 初心), observing that the beginner's mind holds many possibilities and the expert's few. The Western romance of such teachings requires its own caution. Eugen Herrigel's *Zen in der Kunst des Bogenschießens* (1948), which taught generations of readers that the master's arrow is loosed when "it" shoots rather than the archer, has been shown by Yamada Shōji (*Shots in the Dark*, 2009) to rest in part on misunderstanding and on the idiosyncratic teaching of a single master transmitted through an interpreter. The traditions of mastery are not immune to the myth-making they so often denounce.

5.5 *Become Who You Are: The Life's Task and the* Bildungsroman

Mastery opens not with technique but with vocation. Every person, Greene argues, possesses a uniqueness rooted in the "primal inclinations" of childhood—the fascinations that seized the child before the expectations of family and society intervened—and the first task of a life is to rediscover those inclinations and convert them into a Life's Task. The thesis has two genealogies. The first, discussed in Chapter Two, runs from Pindar's γένοι' οἷος ἐσσὶ μαθών—become what you are, having learned what that is (*Pythian* 2.72)—to the subtitle of Nietzsche's *Ecce Homo*. The second runs through the German *Bildungsroman*, and its central text is Goethe's *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre* (1795–1796).

Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship is the story of a merchant's son who believes his vocation to be the theater, pursues it through companies of actors, performances, and love affairs, and discovers at last that his apprenticeship has been watched and guided throughout by a secret Society of the Tower. Its members present him with an indenture, a *Lehrbrief*, whose opening sentences adapt the first aphorism of Hippocrates: art is long, life short, judgment difficult, opportunity fleeting; to act is easy, to think is hard, to act according to one's thought is troublesome (Book VII, ch. 9). The *Lehrbrief* is a law-book for apprentices embedded in a novel, and the novel's structure—a life apparently wandering, revealed in retrospect as an education—is the structure of *Mastery*'s Life's Task.

Goethe's sequel, *Wilhelm Meisters Wanderjahre oder die Entsagenden* (1821; 1829), whose subtitle names its characters "the renunciants," ends with Wilhelm, once the dreamer of the stage, practicing the humble craft of the surgeon and saving his son's life with a lancet. The apprenticeship of the self culminates in renunciation and service.

Goethe matters to *Mastery* for a further reason: he is the tradition's supreme example of what Greene calls the "dimensional mind." His scientific work—the *Metamorphosis of Plants* (1790), with its search for the *Urpflanze*, the archetypal form underlying all plant structures, and the theory of colors he valued above his poetry—rested on a method he described as a delicate empiricism that makes itself utterly identical with its object and thereby becomes theory proper (*es gibt eine zarte Empirie, die sich mit dem Gegenstand innigst identisch macht und dadurch zur eigentlichen Theorie wird*). Goethe's *zarte Empirie* is the Western counterpart of Cook Ding's meeting the ox with the spirit: knowledge achieved not by imposing categories upon an object but by an attention so sustained that the knower perceives its form from within. And his poem "Selige Sehnsucht" (*West-östlicher Divan*, 1819), in which the moth, craving light, flies into the flame, gives the experience its mystical formula: *Und so lang du das nicht hast, / Dieses: Stirb und werde! / Bist du nur ein trüber Gast / Auf der dunklen Erde*—as long as you have not this, Die and become!, you are but a gloomy guest on the dark earth. The moth is the image the *Gītā* used for the warriors rushing into the mouths of Time. In Goethe it signifies not destruction but transformation: the self that must die for mastery to be born.

Goethe also supplied the tradition's great counter-figure. Faust, having mastered philosophy, law, medicine, and theology and found himself no wiser, longs to know what holds the world together in its innermost core (*was die Welt / Im Innersten zusammenhält*, 382–383)—the Siren's promise of omniscience from Chapter Three—and, despairing of the slow path of study, contracts with Mephistopheles for the shortcut. Faust is the anti-apprentice: the man who would possess the fruits of mastery without its discipline, and who pays for the shortcut with the lives of those around him. Yet Goethe's angels bear him off at the close of the second part, singing that whoever strives unceasingly can be redeemed (*Wer immer strebend sich bemüht, / Den können wir erlösen*, 11936–11937). The verdict anticipates *Mastery*'s ethic exactly: what redeems is not achievement but striving, the continued labor of becoming.

Two further sources complete the genealogy. John Keats, in a letter of December 1817, identified the quality that forms "a Man of Achieve-

ment," especially in literature, as "Negative Capability, that is when a man is capable of being in uncertainties, Mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact & reason"—a description of the creative mind's tolerance of ambiguity that the psychology of creativity has made canonical, and that *Mastery*'s account of the Creative-Active presupposes. And Santiago Ramón y Cajal, a figure of exactly the kind *Mastery* celebrates, wrote in his *Reglas y consejos sobre investigación científica* (1897) a manual for young researchers arguing, with a future Nobel laureate's authority, that perseverance and the cultivation of the will count for more in scientific achievement than innate talent—an earlier formulation of the book's anti-romantic thesis by one of the masters it would have chosen.

5.6 *The Mentor Dynamic: Outshining the Master*

The third part of *Mastery*, "The Mentor Dynamic," contains the corpus's most consequential reversal, and it reverses the first law of the first book. Law 1 of *The 48 Laws* commands: never outshine the master. Its paradigm is Fouquet, destroyed for a fête more magnificent than his king's. *Mastery* commands the opposite. The apprentice must absorb the mentor's knowledge as completely as possible, but the relationship is temporary by nature, and its fulfillment is the moment when the apprentice surpasses the master and departs on his own course—often in some form of rebellion against the master's limits. The two commandments are not contradictory; they belong to different economies. In the court, where advancement depends on favor, outshining the sovereign is fatal, because the sovereign's preeminence is the very good being distributed. In the workshop, where advancement depends on skill, outshining the master is the telos of the relationship, because the good being produced is the craft itself, which grows only when the apprentice exceeds the teacher. The corpus's passage from *The 48 Laws* to *Mastery* is a passage from the economy of favor to the economy of skill.

The tradition's paradigm of the reversal is Vasari's account, in the *Lives* (1550; 1568), of Andrea del Verrocchio's *Baptism of Christ*. The young Leonardo, apprenticed in Verrocchio's workshop, painted an angel in the lower left of the panel so far superior to his master's figures that Verrocchio, according to Vasari, resolved never to touch colors again, ashamed that a boy understood them better than he. Whether or not the anecdote is true, it is the workshop's myth of origin: the master's greatness is measured by the apprentice who surpasses him. Benjamin Franklin's

apprenticeship to his brother James, a Boston printer, enacts the reversal with less grace. Forbidden to write for his brother's newspaper, the adolescent Franklin slipped essays under the door in the persona of a widow, "Silence Dogood," which James published and admired until he learned their author; jealousy and beatings followed, and Franklin broke his indenture and fled to Philadelphia.

Mastery's principal example of the mentor dynamic shows the court's logic invading the workshop at the summit of science. Michael Faraday, a blacksmith's son apprenticed to a bookbinder, attended Humphry Davy's lectures at the Royal Institution, bound his notes, and sent them to Davy, who engaged him as an assistant in 1813 and took him on a continental tour as laboratory assistant and, in effect, valet. Faraday absorbed everything Davy could teach and then exceeded him; and when, in 1824, Faraday was proposed for fellowship of the Royal Society, Davy, by then its president, opposed his election. The mentor who had made the apprentice could not bear to be outshone. The mentor dynamic carries within it the possibility of the master's envy—the "Law of Envy" that *The Laws of Human Nature* would anatomize.

Myth records the master's envy with greater severity than history. Ovid tells how Daedalus, the archetypal craftsman, took into his workshop his sister's son Perdix, a boy of such ingenuity that he invented the saw from the spine of a fish and the compass from two arms of iron joined at one end; Daedalus, envious, hurled him from Athena's citadel, and the goddess, who favors the ingenious, caught him in the air and changed him into a partridge (*Met.* 8.236–259). The apprentice's hubris has its myth as well. Arachne, a weaver so skilled that the nymphs came to watch her work, denied that Athena had taught her and challenged the goddess to a contest; her tapestry, depicting the crimes of the gods, was flawless, and the goddess destroyed it and transformed its maker into a spider (*Met.* 6.1–145). The two myths define the twin dangers of the mentor dynamic: the master who cannot tolerate being surpassed, and the apprentice who refuses to acknowledge what he owes.

The Daedalus cycle supplies one more figure, the most famous of all. Fitting his son Icarus with wings of feathers and wax, Daedalus instructs him to fly the middle course—too low and the spray will weigh down the feathers, too high and the sun will melt the wax—*inter utrumque vola*, fly between the two (*Met.* 8.206). Icarus, exultant, soars toward the sun and falls. The master's counsel of the mean, ignored by an apprentice intoxicated with new power, is the Delphic μηδὲν ἄγαν in the language of craft, and the fall is the "Law of Grandiosity" in mythic form. Pieter Bruegel's

Landscape with the Fall of Icarus (c. 1560, attributed), which Auden made famous, adds the dimension that matters most to this dissertation: the ploughman ploughs, the shepherd gazes at the sky, the ship sails on, and the fall itself is a pair of legs vanishing into the sea in a corner of the canvas. The world is indifferent to the grandiose apprentice's catastrophe. The sublime here is the indifference of the field to the self that sought to rise above it.

The Norse tradition offers the counter-image of a mastery achieved through sacrifice rather than seized through grandiosity. In the *Hávamál* —itself a wisdom poem whose opening counsel, to scan every doorway before entering, since one cannot know where enemies sit, could serve as an epigraph to *The 48 Laws*—Odin tells how he hung nine nights on the windswept tree, wounded with a spear, given to Odin, himself to himself, until he took up the runes, screaming, and fell back (138–141); elsewhere he gives an eye to drink from Mímir's well. Odin's knowledge is purchased with the self. And the same poem places all mastery within the horizon this dissertation has been tracing: cattle die, kinsmen die, the self dies likewise; but the fame of one who has earned it never dies (76–77).

5.7 *Masters and Monsters on Screen: The Shortcut and Its Price*

Popular cinema has been the most influential school of mastery of the last half-century, and its central drama is the temptation of the shortcut.

The *Star Wars* saga is a sustained meditation on the mentor dynamic. In *The Empire Strikes Back* (1980), Luke Skywalker's apprenticeship to Yoda on Dagobah is a study in impatience: the apprentice wants results, doubts what he cannot see, and abandons his training early to rescue his friends, losing his hand in a duel he was not ready to fight. The trilogy's most profound scene occurs in a cave where Luke, confronting a vision of Darth Vader, strikes off the dark figure's head and sees within the mask his own face—an encounter with the shadow that Chapter Six will read through Jung. The prequel trilogy stages the mentor dynamic's failure. Anakin Skywalker, too gifted and too impatient for the slow discipline of the Jedi, is seduced in *Revenge of the Sith* (2005) by Palpatine, the anti-mentor par excellence, who offers him the shortcut: a power, learned from the legendary Darth Plagueis, to prevent the deaths of those he loves. Anakin's fall is the Faustian pact transposed into myth—mastery seized rather than earned, and paid for with everything it was meant to

save. *The Last Jedi* (2017) supplies an image that answers Wheelwright Bian across two millennia: the spirit of Yoda burns the tree that houses the order's sacred texts and tells the despairing Luke that the library contained nothing the young Rey does not already possess. The books are dregs; the mastery is in the living.

Damien Chazelle's *Whiplash* (2014) presents the mentor as monster. Terence Fletcher, conductor of a conservatory jazz band, extracts excellence from the young drummer Andrew through humiliation and violence, justifying his methods with the legend that Charlie Parker became "Bird" after Jo Jones threw a cymbal at his head—a legend that inflates a jam-session humiliation in which Jones flung a cymbal to the floor. The film's ending, in which Andrew achieves a performance of overwhelming power under Fletcher's baton, refuses to say whether the cruelty produced the mastery or merely accompanied it. *Whiplash* is the dark side of the mentor dynamic, the point at which the master's demand for submission becomes indistinguishable from abuse, and it shows why the ethics of the workshop require the scrutiny Chapter Three brought to the ethics of seduction. Miloš Forman's *Amadeus* (1984), from Peter Shaffer's play of 1979, dramatizes the myth of genius *Mastery* sets out to dismantle. Its Salieri, devout and competent, is tormented by the spectacle of Mozart's effortless gift and makes himself the enemy of a God who would bestow such music on a vulgar child. *Mastery*'s Mozart is a different figure: not the recipient of an inexplicable gift but the product of intense immersion in music from earliest childhood under his father's tutelage. Salieri's envy is the "Law of Envy" in operatic form, and the film's myth of the gift is precisely what the corpus's anti-romantic theory denies.

Other works describe the apprenticeship itself. In John G. Avildsen's *The Karate Kid* (1984), the teacher Miyagi sets his pupil to waxing cars, sanding floors, and painting fences, and the boy discovers only later that the chores have been training the defensive movements of his art: Polanyi's subsidiary awareness and the indirect pedagogy in a single sequence. David Gelb's documentary *Jiro Dreams of Sushi* (2011) records the apprenticeship of the *shokunin* in its full severity: an apprentice who makes the restaurant's egg custard some two hundred times before the master approves it, and an elder son who, past fifty, still works in his father's shadow—an embodiment of Law 41's warning against stepping into a great man's shoes. *The Queen's Gambit* (Walter Tevis's novel of 1983, adapted for television in 2020) begins with a janitor teaching an orphan chess in a basement and ends with a victory secured partly through

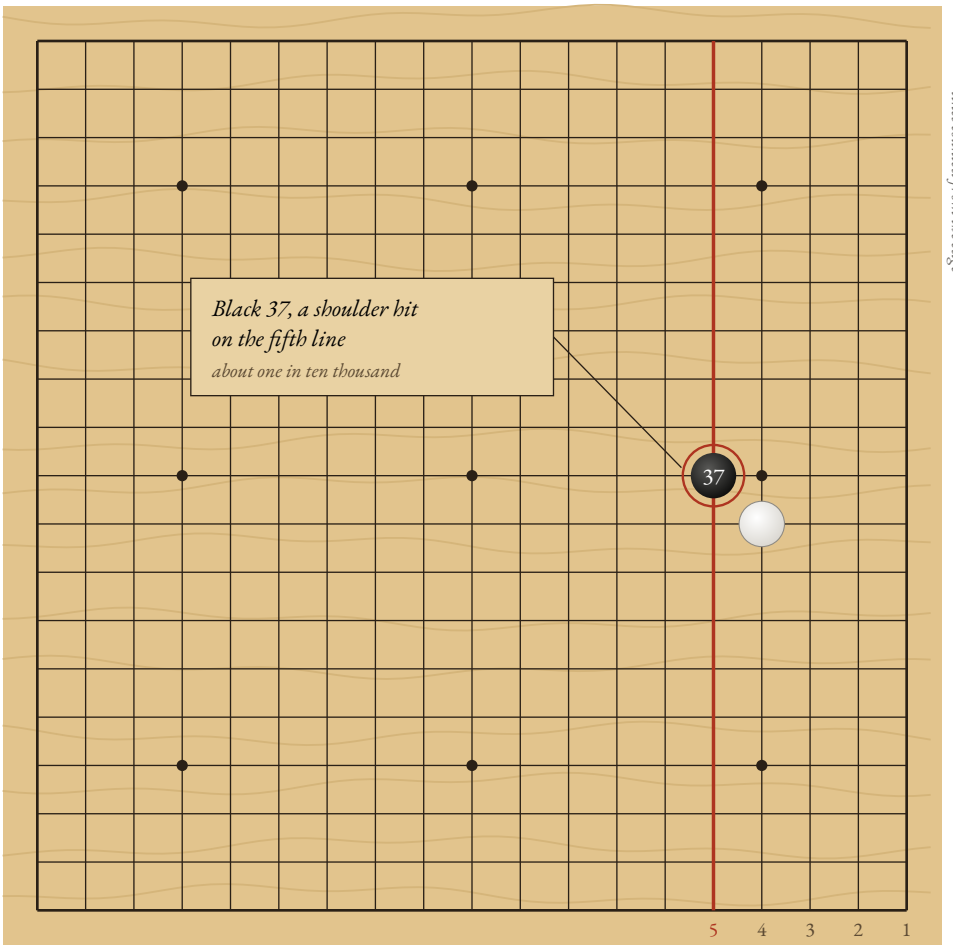
the collective analysis of former rivals: mastery as relational rather than solitary. Darren Aronofsky's *Black Swan* (2010) follows a ballerina whose pursuit of perfection consumes her, so that the perfect performance and the self's destruction coincide—mastery's shadow when the practitioner seeks not the craft but an ideal image of herself.

The most widely experienced pedagogy of mastery of the 2010s took place not on screen but in the hands of players. The games of the Japanese studio FromSoftware, from *Dark Souls* (2011) to *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice* (2019), built their design around repeated death: the player fails, sees the screen announce his death, returns, and fails again, until patterns become perceptible and responses incorporated—deliberate practice enforced by the medium. Their central mechanic is a *memento mori*. The apprentice learns by dying, and the mastery that results is the Dreyfus expert's intuitive responsiveness purchased through a hundred deaths. The games teach, as the *Hagakure* taught the samurai, that one who has already died may act without fear.

5.8 *Move 37: Mastery After the Machine*

On 10 March 2016, in the second game of a five-game match in Seoul, DeepMind's program AlphaGo played its thirty-seventh move: a "shoulder hit" on the fifth line that its own models estimated a human professional would have chosen with a probability of roughly one in ten thousand. Commentators first took it for a mistake. Lee Sedol, among the strongest players of his generation, left the room and took nearly a quarter of an hour to respond; the move proved decisive, and observers who had spent their lives in the game called it beautiful. Lee lost the match four games to one. His single victory, in the fourth game, turned on his own seventy-eighth move, a wedge so unexpected that it was promptly called a divine move. The following year AlphaGo Zero, trained without any human games at all, purely by playing against itself from random beginnings, defeated the version that had beaten Lee by one hundred games to none. In 2019 Lee retired from professional play, explaining that even if he became the best human player, there was now an entity that could not be defeated.

The episode strikes at the foundations of *Mastery*'s model in three ways. First, AlphaGo Zero achieved superhuman mastery without a mentor. Its apprenticeship consisted of millions of games against itself; no master transmitted the accumulated wisdom of the game's history, and



The fifth line. A schematic of the board counted from its edge, and the shape of a shoulder hit on the fifth line, the move AlphaGo played as the thirty-seventh of game two against Lee Sedol, Seoul, 10 March 2016 (§5.8). The other stones of the game are not shown. *Fig. 5.3*

the strategies it discovered included patterns that centuries of human play had neglected. The mentor dynamic, central to Greene's account, proved inessential for a learner of this kind. Second, the program exhibited precisely the quality Hubert Dreyfus had argued, in *What Computers Can't Do* (1972), that symbolic machines could never possess: holistic, intuitive pattern recognition that proceeds without explicit rules. The neural networks that defeated Lee vindicated Dreyfus's phenomenology of expertise—intuition as the perception of patterns learned from vast experience—while refuting his conclusion that machines could not attain it. Third, the episode posed with new urgency the question of what

becomes of human mastery when machines outperform humans in a domain. Lee's retirement is one answer: the master, confronted with a vaster intelligence, withdraws.

It is not the only answer. Fan Hui, the European champion whom AlphaGo had defeated in 2015, went on to work with DeepMind and reported that his own play improved through study of the machine. A study by Minkyu Shin, Jin Kim, Bas van Opheusden, and Thomas Griffiths (*Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 2023), analyzing millions of decisions by professional players from 1950 to 2021, found that the quality and novelty of human play rose markedly after the advent of superhuman programs. The machine became a mentor of a new kind. Chess had rehearsed the relationship. After his defeat by Deep Blue in 1997, Garry Kasparov organized contests of "advanced chess" in which humans played with computer assistance, and in a freestyle tournament of 2005 the winners were neither grandmasters nor machines but two amateur players coordinating several programs. Kasparov drew the lesson that weak humans with machines and a better process could defeat both strong machines alone and strong humans with machines and an inferior process. Mastery, in the age of the machine, begins to look less like the possession of a skill than like the mastery of a process of collaboration.

The generalization of machine expertise beyond games—into translation, programming, diagnosis, design, and writing itself—extends the problem to the apprenticeship *Mastery* describes. The novice's tasks are precisely those most easily automated: the routine drafting, coding, research, and analysis through which apprentices have traditionally acquired tacit knowledge. Lisanne Bainbridge's "Ironies of Automation" (1983) identified the dilemma four decades ago: automation removes from human operators the routine practice through which skill is maintained, and leaves them responsible for exactly the exceptional situations that require the skill they no longer practice. Harry Braverman's *Labor and Monopoly Capital* (1974) had already traced the history of deskilling, in which the separation of conception from execution stripped craftsmen of the knowledge that made them masters, and Sennett's *The Craftsman* described architects trained on computer-aided design who could no longer feel, through the hand, the site they were designing. If the lowest rungs of the ladder are automated, the path Greene describes may lose its first stages altogether.

Mastery cannot be held responsible for a technological situation it did not foresee, but its theory supplies the terms in which that situation can be thought. The Ideal Apprenticeship requires submission to reality,

deep observation, and the slow incorporation of skill; the machine offers results without submission, output without observation, competence without incorporation. It is the Faustian shortcut industrialized. The response the tradition suggests is neither Lee's withdrawal nor uncritical delegation, but a renewed beginner's mind: the master who becomes an apprentice again before an intelligence that sees what he cannot, and who uses it, as Fan Hui did, to perceive more of the field than he could alone. That posture—humility before a vaster intelligence, openness to what exceeds one's mastery—is the metic sublime in its newest form.

The Ocean of Truth: Mastery and the Serene Sublime 5.9

Mastery ends, as the corpus's preceding books ended, at a threshold beyond its own frontal logic. The master's reward, in Greene's account, is an intuitive grasp of the whole of a field, a power of perception the novice cannot imagine. But the testimony of the greatest masters suggests that this grasp brings an experience the book's vocabulary of power cannot quite name: the perception that the field is vaster than any mastery of it. Isaac Newton, near the end of his life, is reported to have said that he did not know what he might appear to the world, but that to himself he seemed only a boy playing on the seashore, diverting himself now and then by finding a smoother pebble or a prettier shell than ordinary, while the great ocean of truth lay all undiscovered before him. Albert Einstein, whom *Mastery* counts among its exemplars, located the deepest motive of scientific research in what he called a cosmic religious feeling—an enraptured wonder at the harmony of natural law, beside which the whole of human thought and action seemed a faint reflection. The masters of the modern scientific tradition describe the culmination of their mastery in the language of the sublime.

The experience differs from the sublime of war described in Chapter Four. Arjuna before Time and Andrei beneath the sky of Austerlitz encounter the vastness of the field at the moment of terror or defeat; the master encounters it at the summit of achievement, and its affect is not terror but wonder. This is the serene form of the metic sublime. Its paradigms are Cook Ding, whose knife moves through the ox along the natural pattern while his spirit goes where it wishes; the old man of Lüliang, who swims in the cataract by following the way of the water; the wooden gamecock, whose completeness ends combat; and, in the language of modern psychology, the self-forgetting of flow. In each case

cunning intelligence, refined by long practice, ceases to impose itself upon its object and comes to move with it—and in that alignment the practitioner experiences the field not as an adversary to be mastered but as a vastness to which he belongs.

The corpus, read anamorphically, has prepared this experience from its first book. The arcana of Chapter Two turned inward when published; the seducer of Chapter Three learned that the greatest seduction leads beyond the seducer; the strategist of Chapter Four discovered that war's extremity discloses the smallness of every combatant. *Mastery* completes the series by turning the will to power toward a material that rewards not domination but attunement. What the master possesses at the end is less power over his field than a relation to it in which the distinction between power and receptivity has begun to dissolve. Goethe's moth flying into the flame, and his injunction to die and become, name the transformation exactly: the self that sought mastery must, at the summit, be partly consumed by what it has mastered.

The answer to Wheelwright Bian follows. A book cannot transmit the knack between hand and heart, and *Mastery* does not try. What it can do is what the corpus does throughout: seduce its reader toward the practices in which mastery is actually acquired, dismantle the myths—of innate genius, of the shortcut—that keep him from beginning, and then step aside. Its function is that of Miyagi's chores or of Goethe's *Lehrbrief*, handed to Wilhelm at the end of an apprenticeship he did not know he was serving. *Kung Fu Panda* (2008), the most charming modern parable of mastery, gives the solution its definitive image. The Dragon Scroll, sought throughout the film as the repository of the ultimate secret, proves blank and reflective: its reader sees only himself. The hero understands only when his adoptive father, a noodle cook, confides that the secret ingredient of his famous soup is that there is no secret ingredient. The sacred text is a mirror. That is the deepest truth about a book that teaches mastery, and about the oracular genre this dissertation has traced from its opening chapter: the consultation of the oracle is an act of self-diagnosis, and the book of mastery returns its reader, in the end, to a practice only he can undertake.

Mastery therefore leaves its reader at the threshold of the self. Its fourth part, on social intelligence, already turns from the mastery of a field to the reading of persons, cataloguing what Greene calls the "seven deadly realities" of human nature—envy, conformism, rigidity, self-obsessiveness, laziness, flightiness, and passive aggression—that the master must understand in order to survive among others. The catalogue is the

seed of *The Laws of Human Nature*. And the reading of persons leads, as La Rochefoucauld's hundred-and-nineteenth maxim predicted, to the person who reads: the master who has learned to see others as they are must finally see himself, including what he has disguised from himself. That is the subject of the next chapter, which follows the corpus from the knife of Cook Ding to the shadow every master casts.



Plate VI. *Stretched 1.6 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 39° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER SIX

The Shadow and the Skull

The Laws of Human Nature and the Return of the Repressed

Si vis vitam, para mortem.
— Freud, "Zeitgemäßes über Krieg und Tod" (1915)

Qui a appris à mourir, il a désappris à servir.
— Montaigne, *Essais* I.20

Iste ego sum.
— Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 3.463

6.1 *Summa and Palinode:* The Laws of Human Nature *as the Corpus's Self-Interpretation*

The Laws of Human Nature (2018) is the corpus's longest and most comprehensive book. Each of its eighteen chapters pairs a law naming a universal tendency with an imperative naming its mastery: the Law of Irrationality (master your emotional self), of Narcissism (transform self-love into empathy), of Role-playing (see through people's masks), of Compulsive Behavior (determine the strength of people's character), of Covetousness (become an elusive object of desire), of Shortsightedness (elevate your perspective), of Defensiveness (soften people's resistance by confirming their self-opinion), of Self-sabotage (change your circumstances by changing your attitude), of Repression (confront your dark side), of Envy (beware the fragile ego), of Grandiosity (know your limits), of Gender Rigidity (reconnect to the masculine or feminine within you), of Aimlessness (advance with a sense of purpose), of Conformity (resist the downward pull of the group), of Fickleness (make them want to follow you), of Aggression (see the hostility behind the friendly façade), of Generational Myopia (seize the historical moment), and, last, of Death Denial (meditate on our common mortality).

The book is a summa in the scholastic sense: it gathers the corpus's scattered psychology into a system. The Law of Role-playing systematizes the masks of *The 48 Laws*; the Law of Covetousness, the triangles and absences of *The Art of Seduction*; the Law of Aggression, the hidden warfare of *The 33 Strategies*; the Law of Aimlessness, the Life's Task of *Mastery*; the Law of Grandiosity, the limits that Laws 46 through 48 had glimpsed. Chapter Two called the book the court's psychology generalized to the species—Elias's court rationality abstracted from Versailles and applied to every human encounter. But it is also, and more decisively, a palinode. Its techniques of observation, which the earlier books aimed at rivals, lovers, and enemies, are turned upon the reader himself. The irrational impulses, narcissistic wounds, repressed shadows, envious stirrings, and grandiose fantasies that the earlier books taught him to exploit in others are now located in him. The adversary has been internalized; the reader has become the subject of his own analysis.

The mythic paradigm of this reversal is Oedipus. The Theban king won his throne by solving the Sphinx's riddle—what walks on four legs in the morning, two at noon, and three in the evening?—whose answer was "man." Oedipus knew human nature in general; he did not know himself. Sophocles' tragedy is the story of an investigator whose inquiry

into a hidden crime discloses its author as the investigator, and its seer is Tiresias, the blind prophet who knows what the king refuses to see. Tiresias appears, not by accident, at two further points this chapter will touch: Ovid makes him the prophet who foretold that Narcissus would live long if he never came to know himself, and the one mortal who lived as both man and woman. *The Laws of Human Nature* is a book whose implicit patron is Tiresias. It teaches its reader to solve the Sphinx's riddle about others and then to turn, like Oedipus, to the question of who he himself is.

The book appeared in October 2018, weeks after its author suffered a stroke; its final chapter, on death, was written before that event, but the coincidence gives the summa its most poignant frame. Freud's essay of 1915 on war and death supplies the formula of its ethics. Freud closed that essay by revising the old maxim *si vis pacem, para bellum*—if you want peace, prepare for war—into *si vis vitam, para mortem*: if you want to endure life, prepare yourself for death. The corpus that began by preparing its reader for war now prepares him for death.

This chapter argues that the internalization of the adversary leads the corpus, by a necessity it registers rather than designs, to the skull. Its central thesis, prepared in the preceding chapters, is that grandiosity is death denial in strategic form: that the will to power the earlier books described as a fact of social life is reinterpreted by the late anthropology as a flight from mortality, so that the meditation on death is not an appendix to the theory of power but its hidden ground. The chapter reads the book's laws through their theoretical sources—Plato and Hume, Kohut and Jung, Klein and Girard, Le Bon, Freud, and Canetti, Heidegger and Becker—and through the literary and cinematic texts that have dramatized them, from Ovid's Narcissus to Le Guin's shadow, from Tolstoy's Ivan Ilyich to Kurosawa's Watanabe, from Anakin Skywalker to Walter White. It ends by returning to the question Chapter Two left open: whether the inward turn of the corpus is a liberation or a pacification.

6.2 *The Charioteer and the Mirror: Irrationality and Narcissism*

The first two laws establish the book's anthropology. The Law of Irrationality holds that human beings are governed by an emotional or "primitive" mind that reacts before the rational mind can intervene, and that rationality is not a given but an achievement—an ideal Greene

associates with Pericles, whose government of Athens through reason he sets against the passions that ruined the city after his death. The image is Platonic. In the *Phaedrus*, Socrates compares the soul to a charioteer driving two winged horses, one noble and obedient, the other unruly and appetitive, and describes the labor by which the charioteer brings the unruly horse under control (246a–254e). Greene's rational self is Plato's charioteer; his emotional self is the dark horse.

The tradition's great dissent is Hume's. Reason, Hume wrote in the *Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–1740), is and ought only to be the slave of the passions, and can never pretend to any other office than to serve and obey them (2.3.3). Modern psychology has divided the difference. Daniel Kahneman's *Thinking, Fast and Slow* (2011) popularized a distinction between a fast, automatic, affect-laden "System 1" and a slow, effortful "System 2" that closely parallels Greene's primitive and rational minds; Antonio Damasio's *Descartes' Error* (1994), studying patients whose emotional processing had been impaired by brain damage, argued that emotion is not the enemy of reason but its condition, since without the somatic markers of feeling practical decisions become impossible. Greene's ideal of rational self-mastery is nearer to Plato than to Hume or Damasio, but his practice—the patient observation of one's own emotional reactions and the cultivation of a slower, second response—is compatible with all three. The rational self is not the absence of passion but the charioteer's achieved relation to it.

The Law of Narcissism is the book's center of gravity, and Ovid supplies its myth. Asked whether the infant Narcissus would live a long life, the seer Tiresias answered: *si se non noverit*—if he does not come to know himself (*Met.* 3.348). The prophecy inverts the Delphic γνῶθι σεαυτόν: for Narcissus, self-knowledge is fatal. He falls in love with an image in a pool, pursues it, and at last recognizes it—*iste ego sum*, I am he (3.463)—and wastes away beside the water. Echo, the nymph condemned to repeat only the last words spoken to her, loves him without being able to speak her own words, and fades to a voice. The myth contains two failures of selfhood: Narcissus, who can love only his reflection, and Echo, who has no voice but others'. Greene's late anthropology addresses both: the Law of Narcissism counsels the transformation of self-love into empathy, and the Law of Conformity counsels resistance to the group that turns persons into echoes.

Psychoanalysis supplies the law's structure. Heinz Kohut's *The Analysis of the Self* (1971) and *The Restoration of the Self* (1977) distinguished healthy narcissism—a cohesive self, sustained in childhood by a parent's

mirroring and by the opportunity to idealize a strong figure—from the fragile, grandiose, or depleted self that results when those needs go unmet, and that defends itself by narcissistic rage and the demand for admiration. Otto Kernberg described pathological narcissism's colder variant; Christopher Lasch's *The Culture of Narcissism* (1979) diagnosed a society organized around the fragile self's demand for mirroring; and Byung-Chul Han's *Agonie des Eros* (2012) argued that contemporary narcissism abolishes the experience of the Other altogether, leaving the subject alone with his reflections. Greene's distinction between deep and healthy narcissists parallels Kohut's, and his remedy—to turn the energy of self-love outward, cultivating the attention to others that *Mastery* called social intelligence—completes the redirection Chapter Three traced in *The Art of Seduction*. The seducer's capacity to enter another's spirit, used there to capture, is used here to understand. The mirror of Narcissus becomes a window.

Ovid's myth also supplies the test of the distinction. Narcissus's self-knowledge was false because it was knowledge of an image: he recognized his reflection, not himself. The self-knowledge the late corpus demands is the opposite: knowledge of what the reflection conceals—the irrational reactions, the compulsive patterns, the repressed shadow—which no mirror shows. Tiresias's prophecy is thereby reversed. Narcissus died because he came to know himself as an image; the reader of *The Laws of Human Nature* may live, the book implies, only if he comes to know himself as something more than his image.

Masks, Characters, and the Science of Faces 6.3

The next cluster of laws extends the corpus's oldest preoccupation, the mask, into a theory of character. The Law of Role-playing holds that every person presents a persona adapted to social expectation, and that an observer who attends to nonverbal signs—tone, gesture, expression, the discrepancy between words and body—can see through it. The concept and the word descend from Jung, for whom the persona, named after the mask of the Roman actor, is the compromise between the individual and society: a necessary face that becomes pathological when the self identifies with it. Erving Goffman's dramaturgical sociology supplied the theory of everyday performance, and Paul Ekman's research on facial expression—the Facial Action Coding System he developed with Wallace Friesen (1978) and his studies of fleeting "microexpressions" and deception

(*Telling Lies*, 1985)—supplied a science of the face that the late corpus draws on in spirit. Here, too, the evidence counsels caution. A meta-analysis by Charles Bond and Bella DePaulo (2006), combining hundreds of experiments, found that people distinguish lies from truths at a rate barely above chance, about fifty-four percent. The courtier's confidence in his capacity to read faces exceeds what the science supports; the Law of Role-playing is more reliable as a discipline of attention than as a technique of detection.

The Law of Compulsive Behavior holds that character, formed early and reinforced by repetition, determines conduct more reliably than any declared intention, so that people should be judged by their patterns rather than their professions. Heraclitus's ἦθος ἀνθρώπῳ δαίμων (DK 22 B119)—a person's character is his fate—is the law's ancestor, and Theophrastus's *Characters* (c. 319 BCE), thirty sketches of types such as the Flatterer, the Dissembler, and the Boor, inaugurated the genre that La Bruyère revived at Versailles and that runs through all of Greene's typologies, from the dangerous marks of Law 19 through the seducers and victims of *The Art of Seduction* to the toxic characters of the late book. Freud's concept of the repetition compulsion (*Wiederholungszwang*), introduced in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) to explain the tendency to relive painful experiences, gave the law its depth psychology: character is fate because the unconscious repeats.

Three further laws apply this psychology to perception, persuasion, and attitude. The Law of Shortsightedness concerns the tendency to be captured by immediate events and to lose sight of long-term trends. Its classic illustrations are the speculative manias Charles Mackay chronicled in *Extraordinary Popular Delusions and the Madness of Crowds* (1841), among them the South Sea Bubble of 1720, in which Isaac Newton—Chapter Five's witness to the ocean of truth—lost a substantial fortune, and after which he is reported to have said that he could calculate the motions of the heavenly bodies but not the madness of people. The master of nature was undone by human nature. The Law of Defensiveness, which counsels softening resistance by confirming others' self-opinion, is the theory behind Dale Carnegie's salesmanship and Leon Festinger's cognitive dissonance (1957): people defend their self-image against information that threatens it, and persuasion succeeds only when it allows them to change without losing face. The Law of Self-sabotage, which holds that attitude shapes circumstance, belongs to the Stoic lineage traced in Chapter Four. Anton Chekhov, grandson of a serf, wrote to his publisher in 1889 that a young man of his origins must squeeze the

slave out of himself drop by drop, until one morning he wakes to feel real human blood in his veins. The letter is the law's finest expression: the self is not given but remade, by a labor of attitude conducted from within.

Together these laws complete the transformation of the courtier's art. *The 48 Laws* taught the reader to manage his own masks and to read others'; *The Laws of Human Nature* teaches him that the masks he reads are also worn by him, that his character is a fate he did not choose, that his perception is captured by the short term, that his self-opinion is defended as fiercely as anyone's, and that his attitude is the first circumstance he must change. La Rochefoucauld's hundred-and-nineteenth maxim, which Chapter Two called the hinge between 1998 and 2018, has here become a program.

The Shadow: Jung, Le Guin, and the Return of the Repressed 6.4

At the center of the book stands the Law of Repression, and its imperative—confront your dark side—marks the point at which the corpus's internalization of the adversary becomes explicit. Its theoretical source is Jung's concept of the shadow: the part of the personality that contains the traits, impulses, and desires the conscious ego refuses to acknowledge, and that, because it is refused, is projected onto others, who are then hated for qualities belonging to the one who hates them. Jung held that everyone carries a shadow, that the less it is embodied in conscious life the darker and denser it becomes (*Psychology and Religion*, 1938), and that its integration—acknowledgment and assimilation rather than suppression—is the first task of individuation (*Aion*, 1951). Greene's chapter follows Jung closely: the dark side is not to be eliminated, which is impossible, but recognized, owned, and converted into energy.

Freud named the mechanism that makes the shadow dangerous the return of the repressed: what is excluded from consciousness does not disappear but returns, disguised, in symptoms, slips, dreams, and compulsions. Literature dramatized the return before psychoanalysis named it. Robert Louis Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) gave the shadow a body of its own, which grows stronger with each release until it overpowers its host. Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1891) produced the most anamorphic image in the literature of the shadow. Dorian remains young and beautiful while his portrait, hidden in a locked room, records every cruelty of his life; the frontal image is the

face, the oblique image is the picture. When at last he takes a knife to the canvas, his servants find the portrait restored to its original beauty and, on the floor, a withered and loathsome dead man whom they recognize only by his rings. The skull was in the attic all along.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968) is the shadow's most profound modern myth, and its plot unites three of the late corpus's laws. The young mage Ged, gifted and proud, tries in rivalry with a fellow student to summon the spirit of a woman long dead, and in breaching the boundary between the living and the dead he releases a shadow that wounds him and then hunts him across the world. Grandiosity, the transgression of death's limit, and the release of the shadow are a single act. Ged flees until his old master counsels him to turn and hunt what hunts him; he pursues the shadow to the edge of the world, and when they meet he names it with the only name it has—his own—and the two become one, so that he is made whole. Le Guin explained in "The Child and the Shadow" (1975) that she had drawn on Jung, and that the shadow is not evil but the unacknowledged self, whose integration is the condition of maturity. The image recurs in the cave on Dagobah discussed in Chapter Five, where Luke Skywalker beheads a vision of Vader and finds his own face within the mask.

Speculative fiction has given the shadow its most unsettling settings. In Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), the living ocean of an alien planet materializes for each scientist on the station a "visitor" drawn from his most painful memories—for the psychologist Kelvin, his dead wife, for whose death he holds himself responsible—so that the scientists who came to study the Other confront only what they have repressed; one of them observes, in effect, that humanity does not seek other worlds but mirrors. Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979), adapted from the Strugatsky brothers' *Roadside Picnic* (1972), leads a writer and a professor through a forbidden Zone toward a Room that grants one's innermost wish—not the wish one professes, but the one one truly holds. The Stalker tells of an earlier visitor who went to the Room to bring back the brother whose death he had caused, came back instead enormously rich, and could not live with what the Room had revealed about him. At the threshold, both of the Stalker's companions refuse to enter. The Room is the shadow made into a place: the one site in the world where the self cannot conceal its own desire.

The Law of Gender Rigidity extends the theory of the shadow to its Jungian counterpart, the contrasexual images Jung called the anima and the animus, and argues that each person must reconnect with the mas-

culine or feminine qualities social convention has repressed. Its mythic ancestors are Aristophanes' speech in the *Symposium*, which imagines human beings as originally double creatures split in two and seeking their other halves (189c–193d), and Tiresias, who lived seven years as a woman (*Met.* 3.316–338). Virginia Woolf gave the idea its modern literary form in *A Room of One's Own* (1929), arguing after Coleridge that a great mind is androgynous, and that it is fatal to be a man or woman pure and simple: one must be woman-manly or man-womanly. The law completes the repayment, begun in Chapter Three, of the debt incurred by Machiavelli's *fortuna è donna*. The corpus that inherited a theory of action as masculine conquest of a feminine fortune ends by asking its reader to recover the other sex within.

6.5 *Envy, the Crowd, and the Victim: The Group and Its Violence*

The laws that follow turn from the individual psyche to the group, and here the late corpus approaches its darkest material. The Law of Envy warns that envy, the most concealed of the passions, hides behind admiration and friendship and strikes at those whose success wounds a fragile ego. Melanie Klein's *Envy and Gratitude* (1957) gave envy its most radical psychoanalytic theory: distinct from jealousy, which involves a rival, and from greed, which seeks to possess, envy seeks to spoil the good object precisely because it is good, and its antidote is gratitude, the capacity to enjoy what one receives without needing to destroy its source. Helmut Schoeck's *Der Neid* (1966) argued that the fear of others' envy is among the most powerful forces shaping social institutions. Iago, whose insinuations Chapter Two examined, confesses envy's essence in a single sentence about Cassio: "He hath a daily beauty in his life / That makes me ugly" (*Othello* 5.1.19–20). The *phthonos theōn* of Law 46 and the Salieri of Chapter Five are the same passion seen from above and from below.

The Law of Conformity describes the downward pull of the group, which induces its members to surrender judgment for the warmth of belonging. Gustave Le Bon's credulous crowd reappears in Freud's *Massenpsychologie und Ich-Analyse* (1921), which explained the group's cohesion by the replacement of each member's ego ideal with the figure of the leader. Solomon Asch's experiments (1951) showed subjects denying the evidence of their own eyes to agree with a unanimous group; Stanley Milgram's (1963) showed ordinary people administering what they be-

lieved to be dangerous shocks at the instruction of an authority. Heidegger had already described, in *Sein und Zeit*, the everyday dominion of *das Man*—the anonymous "they" whose averageness levels every possibility, so that one reads, judges, and enjoys as one does (§27). And Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, in *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), diagnosed the deepest root of conformity: the human desire to be relieved of freedom by miracle, mystery, and authority, which the Inquisitor's church supplies in exchange for obedience. Erich Fromm's *Escape from Freedom* (1941) read the authoritarian movements of the twentieth century in the same terms.

The Law of Fickleness concerns the leader's relation to such a group: followers are ambivalent, their loyalty conditional, their admiration ready to turn into resentment. Shakespeare staged that fickleness in *Julius Caesar*, where the crowd that cheers Brutus's justification of the assassination is turned against him within minutes by Antony's funeral oration (3.2). Elias Canetti added the mechanism Greene's account presupposes. Every command, Canetti argued in *Masse und Macht* (1960), leaves in the one who obeys a "sting" that persists and seeks discharge, so that a group habituated to obedience accumulates a reservoir of resentment that can be turned, at a signal, against its masters or against a victim. The Law of Aggression completes the sequence by asking the reader to see the hostility behind the friendly façade. Freud's *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930), invoking the old saying *homo homini lupus*, argued that civilization rests on the renunciation of aggressive drives that do not vanish but turn inward as conscience or outward as violence, and he linked aggression to the death drive he had posited a decade earlier—a destructiveness that, directed outward, spares the self by striking others.

René Girard supplies the darkest key to this cluster of laws, as Chapter Three promised. Mimetic desire, Girard argued, generates rivalry; rivalry, spreading through a community, generates a crisis in which differences collapse and everyone becomes everyone's double; and the crisis is resolved by the unanimous designation of a single victim, a scapegoat, whose expulsion or killing restores peace and who is afterward remembered as both the cause of the disorder and the source of the order that followed (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972; *Le Bouc émissaire*, 1982). Envy, conformity, fickleness, and aggression are, on Girard's account, moments of a single mechanism. The group that envies converges on a victim; the crowd that conforms discharges its stings upon him; the leader whom the crowd cannot forgive becomes him. The scapegoat mechanism is the collective form of the friend–enemy distinction examined in Chapter Four: the community constitutes itself by designating whom it must expel.

The Laws of Human Nature does not adopt Girard's theory, but its laws describe the materials the mechanism uses, and a reader who has followed the corpus from the polemological self of 2006 to the group psychology of 2018 can recognize in Girard the hidden unity of what Greene presents as separate tendencies.

6.6 *Grandiosity as Death Denial: Becker, Canetti, and the Survivor*

The Law of Grandiosity—know your limits—returns to the theme the corpus first sounded in Laws 46 and 47 and in *Mastery*'s Icarus. Grandiosity, in Greene's account, is the inflation of the self that follows success, the belief that one's gifts exempt one from the limits that bind others; it blinds its possessor to reality and carries him past the culminating point of his victory. This dissertation's thesis is that the late corpus, read as a whole, discloses the hidden ground of grandiosity, and with it the hidden ground of the will to power the earlier books described: grandiosity is death denial in strategic form.

Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973), awarded the Pulitzer Prize two months after its author's death in 1974, gives the thesis its theoretical form. Drawing on Kierkegaard and Otto Rank, Becker argued that the fundamental human problem is the awareness of mortality—the condition of a creature who knows he will die—and that culture is in large part an elaborate system for denying it. Each person constructs a *causa sui* project, a heroic enterprise through which he seeks to become the cause of his own being and to secure a significance that will outlast him; character itself, Becker argued after Wilhelm Reich, is an armor erected against the terror of death. His sequel, *Escape from Evil* (1975), drew the darker consequence: seeking to deny their own mortality, human beings inflict death on others, scapegoating victims in order to purchase a symbolic immortality—Girard's mechanism grounded in the fear of death. Terror management theory, developed from Becker's work by Jeff Greenberg, Tom Pyszczynski, and Sheldon Solomon from 1986, supplied experimental support: in a well-known early study, municipal judges reminded of their own mortality set markedly higher bonds for an alleged prostitute than judges who had not been so reminded. Reminders of death intensify the defense of one's worldview and hostility toward those who threaten it.

Elias Canetti reached the same conclusion from the side of power. The moment of survival, he wrote in *Masse und Macht*, is the moment of power: the satisfaction of standing alive while others lie dead is the root of the feeling of power, and the despot's deepest wish is to survive everyone. Power, on this account, is a technique of survival, and its pathological extreme—the paranoid ruler who must eliminate every rival—is death denial organized as politics. Pascal had seen the same structure from within the court. All of humanity's unhappiness, he wrote, comes from a single thing, not knowing how to remain at rest in a room; men seek diversion—hunting, gaming, war, office—not for the prize but for the pursuit, preferring the hunt to the capture, because the pursuit keeps them from thinking of their condition; and a king without diversion is a man full of miseries, which is why kings are surrounded by people whose sole occupation is to divert them (*Pensées*, Lafuma 136–137). Pascal's analysis converts the entire economy of *The 48 Laws* into *divertissement*: the court, its favors, its intrigues, and its spectacles are an apparatus for not thinking about death.

The thesis has a political corollary that Montaigne formulated with unsurpassed concision. In the essay "Que philosopher c'est apprendre à mourir" (*Essais* I.20), he wrote that the premeditation of death is the premeditation of freedom, and that whoever has learned to die has unlearned how to serve. His friend Étienne de La Boétie had argued in the *Discours de la servitude volontaire* that tyranny rests on the consent of those who serve, and that a people need only resolve to serve no longer to be free. Read together, the two friends supply the deepest bond between the corpus's first book and its last. The courtier serves because he fears; he fears, finally, because he has not learned to die. The meditation on death is the solvent of servitude, and therefore of the whole economy of favor that *The 48 Laws* describes. Freud, writing amid the First World War, observed that in the unconscious every one of us is convinced of his own immortality; the courtier's servility and the conqueror's grandiosity are two forms of the same conviction.

The literature of grandiosity confirms the thesis with remarkable consistency. Gilgamesh, the oldest hero of world literature, becomes a seeker of immortality only when the death of his friend Enkidu reveals that he too will die; his journey to Utnapishtim, survivor of the flood, ends when a serpent steals the plant of rejuvenation, and he returns to Uruk to show the boatman its walls, the work that will outlast him. Faust's pact is a bargain against the limits of a mortal life. Le Guin's Ged releases his shadow by attempting to summon the dead. Anakin

Skywalker, in *Revenge of the Sith*, is seduced by Palpatine's promise of a power to prevent death, born of his terror at visions of his wife dying; his grandiosity is the strategic form of his fear. And Vince Gilligan's *Breaking Bad* (2008–2013), the most celebrated television drama of its era, makes the thesis its premise. Walter White, a chemistry teacher diagnosed with terminal cancer, becomes the drug lord Heisenberg, ostensibly to provide for his family; in the final episode he admits that he did it for himself, that he liked it, that he was good at it, and that it made him feel alive. The diagnosis of mortality produced not resignation but an explosion of the will to power. White's empire was his *causa sui* project; Heisenberg was death denial in strategic form.

6.7 *The Mortal Court: Siddhārtha's Palace, Ivan Ilyich, and* Ikiru

If the court is an apparatus of diversion from death, then its most consequential arcanum is death itself, and the tradition's founding story of awakening is a story about that arcanum's publication. According to the legends gathered in Aśvaghoṣa's *Buddhacarita* (second century CE) and later lives of the Buddha, King Śuddhodana, warned that his son Siddhārtha would become either a universal monarch or a world-renouncer, raised him in palaces from which every sign of age, sickness, and death had been removed. The prince's education was the perfect court: pleasure without end, and the one truth withheld. On excursions beyond the walls he saw, despite his father's precautions, an old man, a sick man, a corpse, and finally a wandering ascetic, and the four sights dissolved the palace. Chapter Two argued that the published arcanum turns inward; here the turn is total. The most closely guarded secret in the oldest palace of legend was mortality, and its disclosure produced not a prince but a Buddha. The tradition supplies a companion story of the same truth taught by indirection. Kisā Gotamī, maddened by grief for her dead child, begged the Buddha for a medicine to restore him; he sent her to collect a mustard seed from a house in which no one had died, and her fruitless search taught her what no doctrine could have.

Tolstoy's *The Death of Ivan Ilyich* (1886) is the modern West's counterpart and the great counter-text to every manual of advancement. Ivan Ilyich Golovin, a judge, has lived precisely as the court of his society required: easily, pleasantly, and decorously, attentive to what is proper, advancing through favor and connection, marrying suitably, furnishing

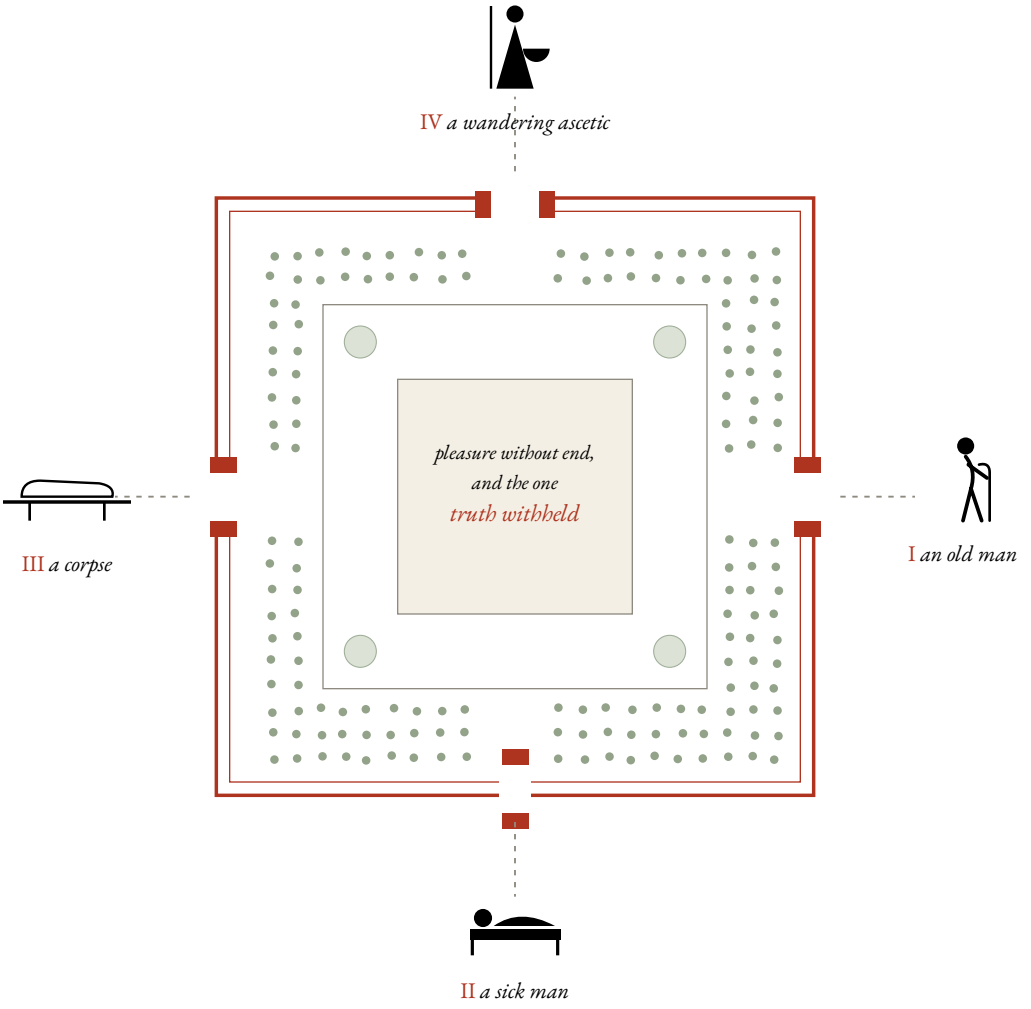


Fig. 6.1 *The four sights.* The palace from which every sign of age, sickness and death had been removed, and what the prince saw beyond its walls: an old man, a sick man, a corpse, and a wandering ascetic (Aśvaghoṣa, *Buddhacarita* §6.7).

his apartment in the style of everyone of his rank. He is at once the perfect courtier of Law 24 and the conformist of Law 38, who thinks as he likes and behaves like others. His fatal illness begins with a fall from a ladder while he is showing an upholsterer how to hang curtains: death enters through the décor. Lying ill, he recalls the syllogism of his logic textbook—Caius is a man, men are mortal, therefore Caius is mortal—and realizes that he had always taken it to apply to Caius, never to himself. Everyone around him lies about his condition, maintaining the decorum

of the courtly world to the end; only the peasant servant Gerasim, who holds his master's legs to ease his pain, speaks the truth that all men die. In his last days Ivan asks what if his whole life has been wrong, and in the final hours, admitting that it has, he finds in place of the fear of death a light, and tells himself that death is finished. The story is the anamorphic skull rendered as narrative. The life of advancement, viewed frontally, was correct; viewed from the deathbed, it was a lie.

Akira Kurosawa's *Ikiru* (1952), which transposes Tolstoy's story to postwar Tokyo, adds the resolution Tolstoy compressed into a final hour. Kanji Watanabe, a bureaucrat who has spent decades stamping papers in a municipal office, learns that he has stomach cancer and months to live. After failing to find meaning in dissipation, he devotes his remaining time to forcing a petition for a children's playground through the indifferent bureaucracy that had buried it, and the film's final image of him —alone on a swing in the finished playground at night, singing softly as the snow falls—is among the most celebrated in cinema. *Ikiru* translates the Law of Death Denial into the Law of Aimlessness: the awareness of death becomes the source of purpose. Ingmar Bergman's *The Seventh Seal* (1957) gives the same structure its allegory. A knight returning from the Crusades plays chess with Death to postpone his end and to find, in the time gained, one meaningful act; he cannot win the game, but by distracting Death at the decisive moment he allows a family of traveling players to escape. The strategist's last move is not victory but a gift.

The oldest texts of the sapiential tradition had already drawn the conclusion. In the Old Babylonian version of the Gilgamesh epic, the tavern-keeper Siduri counsels the grieving hero to fill his belly, make merry day and night, cherish the child who holds his hand, and delight the wife in his embrace, for this is the lot of mortals. Ecclesiastes, which opens with the vanity of vanities, answers its own reflection on death with an imperative of action: "Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with thy might; for there is no work, nor device, nor knowledge, nor wisdom, in the grave, whither thou goest" (9:10). The meditation on death, in its oldest form, is not a counsel of despair but a discipline of attention to the life that remains. The Law of Death Denial belongs to this lineage.

6.8 *Meditate on Our Common Mortality: The Ethics of Finitude*

The Law of Death Denial closes *The Laws of Human Nature*, and its imperative—meditate on our common mortality—gathers the preceding laws into a single ethic. Greene's argument is that the denial of death distorts every dimension of life: it fuels the grandiosity that overreaches, the conformity that hides in the group, the shortsightedness that ignores what is coming, and the aimlessness that wastes the time one has. Its remedy is not morbid preoccupation but a deliberate awareness of mortality that intensifies the urgency of life, deepens the experience of the present, and—this is the chapter's decisive claim—grounds empathy in the recognition of a fate shared by all. The final law returns the corpus to the theme with which *The 50th Law* had closed, now as the foundation of an anthropology.

The ethic has three philosophical sources and one powerful dissent. The first source is the ancient *meditatio mortis*, which Plato's Socrates made the definition of philosophy—those who philosophize rightly are practicing dying (*Phaedo* 67e)—and which Montaigne, through Cicero, made the title of an essay. The second is Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death (*Sein und Zeit* §§46–53). Everyday existence, governed by *das Man*, tranquilizes the anxiety of death by converting it into an event that happens to "one"—one dies, eventually, but not yet and not I; authentic existence begins when Dasein anticipates its own death as its ownmost, non-relational, certain, and indefinite possibility, and is thereby wrenched free from the They and freed for its own possibilities. Heidegger's structure binds the Law of Conformity to the Law of Death Denial: the group that pulls the self downward is at bottom an apparatus for not facing death, and resistance to the group begins with the anticipation of one's own end. The third source is the psychology of meaning. Viktor Frankl, whose *Man's Search for Meaning* (1946) drew on his survival of the camps, made Nietzsche's maxim—whoever has a *why* to live can bear almost any *how* (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, "Sprüche und Pfeile" 12)—the foundation of a therapy, and the Law of Aimlessness is its descendant: purpose is what the awareness of finitude demands.

The dissent is Spinoza's. The free man, the *Ethics* declares, thinks of nothing less than of death, and his wisdom is a meditation not on death but on life (*homo liber de nulla re minus quam de morte cogitat, et ejus sapientia non mortis sed vitae meditatio est*; IV P67). Epicurus and Lucretius had argued that death is nothing to us, since where we are

death is not, and where death is we are not. The dissent clarifies rather than refutes the late corpus's ethic. Spinoza condemns the meditation on death that is fear—the brooding of one led by imagination rather than reason—whereas Greene's meditation, like Montaigne's, aims at the dissolution of that fear: its purpose is to make death familiar so that it ceases to govern life. At its limit, the meditation on death becomes what Spinoza demanded, a meditation on life. La Rochefoucauld supplies the necessary reservation. In the long reflection that closes his collection (504), he argued that the contempt for death professed by philosophers is often vanity, a way of averting the eyes, and his twenty-sixth maxim holds that neither the sun nor death can be looked at steadily. The meditation on death cannot be frontal. It can only be oblique—which is why the corpus approached it through power, seduction, war, and mastery before it named it.

The decisive claim of the final law is ethical: the recognition of common mortality is the ground of empathy. The *Iliad*'s twenty-fourth book, read in Chapter Four, is its oldest demonstration: Achilles and Priam weep together and gaze at one another in wonder because each sees in the other a mortal who will die. Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) offers its most famous modern version. The replicant Roy Batty, engineered with a four-year lifespan, returns to Earth to demand more life from his maker, kills him when the maker cannot grant it, and hunts the detective sent to destroy him—only to save his pursuer's life in the last moments of his own, and to die after a brief elegy for everything he has seen, which will vanish with him. Death denied produces murder; death accepted produces mercy. Darth Vader's last request in *Return of the Jedi* (1983), that his mask be removed so that he may look on his son with his own eyes, is the persona surrendered at death: the face behind the mask that Luke had seen as his own in the cave, revealed as a dying old man's.

The Law of Generational Myopia, the seventeenth, places the meditation on mortality within historical time. Each generation, Greene argues, is shaped by the moment of its youth and blind to the patterns that connect it to those before and after. Ibn Khaldūn's *Muqaddimah* (1377) had described the cycle by which a dynasty's founding solidarity (*ʿaṣabiyya*) decays over three or four generations into luxury and dissolution, and Karl Mannheim's "Das Problem der Generationen" (1928) and José Ortega y Gasset's theory of generations made the generation a unit of historical analysis. The law asks the reader to see himself as one wave in a sequence that preceded him and will continue after him—a social-

historical vastness in which an individual life is a single configuration. It is the metic sublime in historical form.

Neon Genesis Evangelion (1995–1996) gives the ethic of finitude its subtlest emblem. Its fourth episode borrows its title from Schopenhauer's parable of the porcupines (*Parerga und Paralipomena* II, §396), who huddle together for warmth on a cold day, prick one another with their quills, and draw apart until they find the moderate distance at which they can bear each other. The series' climax offers its protagonist the dissolution of all individual boundaries into a single being, the end of loneliness and of pain; he refuses, choosing a world of separate, vulnerable, mortal persons who may wound one another. The choice resolves the Law of Narcissism and the Law of Death Denial together: empathy is possible only among finite selves who remain other to one another, and the acceptance of separation is the acceptance of mortality.

6.9 *The Palinode Examined: Self-Knowledge, Pacification, and the Skull*

Chapter Two left open a question that must now be answered. Nietzsche's ascetic priest, it was argued there, redirects the sufferer's *ressentiment* inward, answering the question of who is to blame with "you yourself," and so renders the herd harmless and governable. *The Laws of Human Nature* performs a structurally similar redirection. The enemies of 1998 and 2006—rivals, courtiers, generals—have become, in 2018, the reader's own narcissism, envy, grandiosity, and shadow. Is the corpus's inward turn a liberation or a pacification?

The answer requires two distinctions. The first concerns the aim of the inward turn. The ascetic priest's redirection produces guilt, the bad conscience that binds the sufferer to the priest for absolution. The late corpus aims instead at integration: the Jungian acknowledgment of the shadow, which accepts rather than condemns the dark side and treats envy, aggression, and grandiosity as energies to be understood and channeled rather than sins to be expiated. Its model is nearer to the self-overcoming Zarathustra praised—the self that commands itself—than to the priestly mortification Nietzsche despised. In this respect the palinode is genuine. It does not ask the reader to renounce power but to understand its roots, and it locates those roots in a fear that can be faced.

The second distinction concerns the social effect of the inward turn, and here the critique retains its force. Nikolas Rose's *Governing the*

Soul (1990), Eva Illouz's studies of therapeutic culture, and Byung-Chul Han's account of the achievement-subject who exploits himself and experiences his failures as personal deficits all describe the same danger: that psychological self-scrutiny converts structural conflicts into individual pathologies, so that the envy produced by real inequality is treated as a flaw of character and the anger provoked by real injustice as a failure of emotional self-mastery. A reader who learns from the Law of Envy only to suppress his resentment, and from the Law of Conformity only to distrust collective action, has been pacified rather than freed. The corpus's individualism, inherited from the reason of self analyzed in Chapter Two, makes it vulnerable to this reading, and the author who diagnoses every reader's difficulty as the reader's own occupies, within the market for counsel, a position not wholly unlike the priest's.

The palinode is therefore genuine and unstable, like every element of the corpus's anamorphosis, and its test is direction. Self-knowledge that issues in empathy—in the recognition, before a common mortality, of others' shadows as kin to one's own—moves outward and completes the redirection that began with *The Art of Seduction*'s capacity to enter another's spirit. Self-knowledge that issues only in self-optimization turns inward without end and becomes a new instrument of the reason of self: the dark empathy of Chapter Three, now aimed at one's own psyche. The final law of *The Laws of Human Nature* tilts the book toward the first direction, because it grounds the entire anthropology in a mortality that no strategy can master and that every person shares. The corpus's subsequent turn confirms the tilt: the book published on the date of this dissertation announces a sublime that connects its reader not only to the immense forces of the universe but to the inner worlds of other people (Penguin Random House).

Wilde's Dorian Gray supplies the chapter's closing emblem. For two decades the corpus showed its readers the beautiful face—the arts of power, seduction, war, and mastery, practiced with grace and success. *The Laws of Human Nature* unlocked the attic and showed them the picture. What the picture revealed was not merely each reader's hidden vices but the mortality those vices were organized to deny: the skull Holbein laid across the floor of *The Ambassadors*, now seen not through a lateral step but, insofar as a face can bear it, face to face. La Rochefoucauld held that death cannot be looked at steadily, and the late corpus does not pretend otherwise. But it has brought its reader, by the long indirection of four books, to the place from which the skull can at least be glimpsed—and from which, as the concluding chapter argues, the vast impersonal field

that the strategist, the seducer, and the master each encountered at the limit of their arts can at last be named.



Plate VII. *Stretched 1.15 to 1 along its length. Sight along the shape from its lower end, the eye about 60° above the page, and it resolves.*

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Metic Sublime

The Law of the Sublime and a Theory of Anamorphic Wisdom

ὕψος μεγαλοφροσύνης ἀπήχημα.
— Longinus, *Peri hupsous* 9.2

Wenn die Macht gnädig wird und herabkommt ins Sichtbare: Schönheit heiße ich solches Herabkommen.
— Nietzsche, *Also sprach Zarathustra* II, "Von den Erhabenen"

Punctum est istud in quo navigatis, in quo bellatis, in quo regna disponitis.
— Seneca, *Naturales quaestiones* I, praef. 11

7.1 *The Destination Named:* The Law of the Sublime *and the Fourth Movement*

On the date this dissertation is completed, the corpus whose architecture it has reconstructed acquires its terminal book. *The Law of the Sublime* (2026) is presented by its publisher as a guide to transcending one's own limits through an experience that connects the subject to the immense forces of the universe, to the inner worlds of other people, and even to other species. On that description it draws on science, mythology, history, the arts, and nature; it proposes to open its readers' eyes to the strangeness of being alive, to free them from conventional thinking, to recover the intuitions and practices of ancient civilizations, and to reconnect them with their childhood selves so that they may perceive the world anew; and it proceeds through stories of near-death encounters, discoveries, and transformations of consciousness, accompanied by exercises and meditations (Penguin Random House). As Chapter One stated, this dissertation was constructed from the antecedent corpus and engages the new book only through its announced program. That program is nonetheless sufficient to confirm the structural claim on which the dissertation rests: the corpus that began with the arts of domination ends with an explicit theory of self-transcendence, and the sublime that had occupied the terminal positions of *The 50th Law* and *The Laws of Human Nature* now stands at the center of the work.

i. Grammatical

Four features of the announced program bear directly on the argument of the preceding chapters. The first is grammatical. The titles of the corpus move from the plural of the forty-eight laws to the singular of *The Law of the Sublime*—a movement from the strategist's polytropic repertoire to a single law, recapitulating the Neoplatonic rhythm of procession and return. The many laws of the court issue, at the end, in one law that is not of the court.

ii. Childhood

The second is the return to childhood. *Mastery* located the origin of every vocation in the primal inclinations of the child; *The Law of the Sublime* proposes to reconnect its readers with their childhood selves. The corpus thereby completes a figure Nietzsche drew in the first speech of Zarathustra, "Von den drei Verwandlungen." The spirit becomes a camel, which kneels to bear the heaviest burdens; the camel becomes a lion, which seizes its freedom and slays the dragon "Thou shalt" with its "I will"; and the lion becomes a child, for the child is innocence and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a self-propelling wheel, a first movement, a sacred yes (*ein heiliges Ja-sagen*). Greene's corpus traverses

the metamorphoses in an order of its own. It begins with the lion—the "I will" of *The 48 Laws*, which overturns the "Thou shalt" of conventional morality—passes through the camel of *Mastery*'s apprenticeship, which kneels to bear the discipline of a craft, and ends with the child. Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), framed by Richard Strauss's *Also sprach Zarathustra*, ends with the same figure: a star child, born of the astronaut's death and transfiguration, gazing upon the earth.

iii. The field extended

The third is the extension of the field. The metic sublime of the preceding chapters encountered the social-historical field—fortune, friction, human nature, generations, mortality. The announced program extends that field to the living world as a whole, and in doing so it repeats a conversion the twentieth century had already recorded. In "Thinking Like a Mountain," from *A Sand County Almanac* (1949), Aldo Leopold recalls how, as a young forester convinced that fewer wolves would mean more deer and a hunter's paradise, he shot a wolf and watched the light go out of her eyes, and how over the following decades he learned to see as the mountain sees: that the overgrazed slopes he had helped to produce were the work of a strategy that had read only part of the field. Leopold's essay is the hunter's *mētis* transfigured into ecological perception—the strategist's reading of the field carried to the point at which the field includes the wolf.

iv. The frontal vocabulary

The fourth feature is the persistence of the frontal vocabulary, which Chapter One identified as the mark of the anamorphosis's instability. The same description that promises self-transcendence offers to teach its readers to master the power of the Sublime. The phrase is telling precisely because it is unremarkable: the language of mastery and power, which the corpus spent nearly three decades transfiguring, persists at the threshold of its own dissolution. Whether the book sustains that tension or resolves it is a question for the scholarship that will follow its publication. What this dissertation can say is that the tension is constitutive. The sublime of a corpus that began with power will always be approached in the language of power, because that is the language its readers brought with them; and the reader's task, as the final sections of this chapter argue, is to hear in "the power of the Sublime" not the promise of a new instrument but the name of what overpowers every instrument.

7.2 *Toward a Definition: The Metic Sublime Among Its Antecedents*

The concept introduced in Chapter One must now be formalized, and its formalization requires that it be distinguished from the theories of the sublime with which it shares a name.

The tradition begins with Longinus, for whom sublimity (*hupsos*) is a quality of discourse that transports rather than persuades—the echo of a great soul (ὕψος μεγαλοφροσύνης ἀπήχημα, *Peri hupsous* 9.2). The Longinian sublime is rhetorical: it belongs to the speaker's elevation and the hearer's ecstasy. Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) relocated the sublime in the passions of self-preservation: whatever is terrible, or conversant about terrible objects, or operates in a manner analogous to terror, is a source of the sublime, provided it is experienced at a distance that converts terror into a delightful horror; obscurity, power, privation, vastness, and infinity are its sources. Kant's *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790) distinguished the mathematical sublime, in which imagination fails to comprehend a magnitude in a single intuition, from the dynamical sublime, in which nature appears as a might that has no dominion over us; in both, the failure of sensibility discloses a supersensible vocation of reason superior to nature, so that the feeling of the sublime is, by what Kant called a subreption, a respect for the idea of humanity in ourselves that we attribute to the object (§§23–29). Schiller's "Über das Erhabene" (1801) made the sublime the experience of freedom from nature's force; Schopenhauer made it the will-less contemplation of objects hostile to the will, an elevation (*Erhebung*) above one's own peril (*Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* I, §39).

The twentieth century added further variants. Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the numinous as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, a mystery that terrifies and attracts, before which the subject experiences "creature-feeling," the consciousness of being nothing before what is supremely real. David Nye's *American Technological Sublime* (1994) traced the migration of sublime affect from nature to human works—the railroad, the bridge, the dam, the bomb. Jean-François Lyotard made the sublime the aesthetic of the avant-garde: the presentation of the fact that there is something unpresentable. And Fredric Jameson's "Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism" (1984; expanded 1991) offered the variant closest to this dissertation's concept: a "hysterical sublime," the disorienting experience of a global network of capital and communication that exceeds any individual's capacity to represent it,

for which Jameson prescribed a remedy he called cognitive mapping—an aesthetic that would enable individuals to situate themselves within an unrepresentable totality.

The metic sublime may now be defined by six criteria, each of which distinguishes it from these antecedents. First, its subject is a bearer of *mētis*: an intelligence trained by long practice to read a field of forces—the courtier's, the seducer's, the strategist's, the craftsman's. It is reached through the exercise of that intelligence rather than by passive exposure to a magnitude; it is the sublime of one who knows the field, not of one who merely stands before it. Second, its object is the field itself as a totality of forces—fortune, configuration, friction, desire, human nature, time, and mortality—rather than nature's magnitude (Burke, Kant), discourse (Longinus), the holy (Otto), the machine (Nye), or the unpresentable as such (Lyotard). Third, its trigger is a limit of reading: the moment at which the field exceeds the subject's model, whether at the point of defeat (Andrei at Austerlitz), revelation (Arjuna before Time), supreme achievement (Newton's ocean), encounter with a superior intelligence (Lee Sedol before the thirty-seventh move), or death's approach (Ivan Ilyich). Fourth, its phenomenology is a decentering: the self appears to itself as one configuration among countless others, an instrument rather than an author (*nimitta-mātram*), accompanied by an affect that varies with the mode—terror, wonder, rapture, compassion. Fifth, its terminus is not the triumph of reason that Kant described, in which the subject discovers its superiority to the nature that threatens it, but the humbling of the subject's sovereignty; and yet it is not annihilation, for action continues, reordered. Arjuna fights; Andrei returns to the world; Watanabe builds his playground; Cook Ding goes on carving. Sixth, its ethical consequence is the dissolution of grandiosity—the death denial in strategic form diagnosed in Chapter Six—and the emergence, from the recognition of a shared condition, of attention to others.

The contrast with Jameson clarifies the concept's originality. Jameson's hysterical sublime is the experience of failed mapping: the subject is lost in a totality it cannot represent, and cognitive mapping is a remedy still to come. The metic sublime is the experience that follows successful mapping carried to its limit. The strategist has mapped the field so thoroughly that he can at last see its edges and his own place within it—and what he sees is that the map, however complete, includes himself as a small and transient figure. The metic sublime is not the vertigo of the lost but the lucidity of one who has found his position and discovered how little it commands.

Nietzsche supplied, in a speech of Zarathustra's, the formula of the experience's practical terminus. Of the sublime one—the hero who has fought and conquered and remains tense with his own effort—Zarathustra says that he must still learn beauty and unlearn his heroic will: when power becomes gracious and descends into the visible, I call such descending beauty (*wenn die Macht gnädig wird und herabkommt ins Sichtbare: Schönheit heiße ich solches Herabkommen*). The metic sublime ends in this descent. The power the strategist accumulated does not vanish; it becomes gracious. Cook Ding's knife, moving without resistance through the ox, is the image of power that has descended into grace.

7.3 *A Typology of the Metic Sublime*

The preceding chapters found the metic sublime in five modes, each disclosed at the limit of one of the corpus's arts. They may be arranged as a typology.

i. Sequence

Three observations follow from the typology. The first concerns sequence. The modes follow the order in which the corpus took up its

Mode	**Courtly**	**Erotic**	**Polemological**	**Operative**	**Mortal**
Principal books	*The 48 Laws of Power*	*The Art of Seduction*	*The 33 Strategies of War*; *The 50th Law*	*Mastery*	*The Laws of Human Nature*
Field encountered	Fortune and the figuration of the court	Desire and its unattainable object	Friction, *shi*, Time	The grain of a material; the depth of a domain	Common mortality; the succession of generations
Limit that triggers it	Formlessness pursued until no self remains to aggrandize	The ladder of eros, pointing beyond the beloved	Defeat, or the vision of Time	The summit of skill; the encounter with a greater intelligence	The approach of death
Affect	Desengaño, *vertigo*	*Rapture*	*Terror*	*Wonder*	*Compassion*
Paradigms	Segismundo; Law 48; the published arcanum turned inward	Diotima; Beatrice; Bembo at dawn	Arjuna before the universal form; Andrei at Austerlitz; Achilles and Priam	Cook Ding; Newton's ocean; Lee Sedol before Move 37	Ivan Ilyich; Watanabe; Roy Batty
Reordered action	Acting well within a theater known as theater	Love that leads beyond the lover	Action without attachment to its fruits	Renewed apprenticeship	Purpose, and attention to others

Table 7.1 The five modes of the metic sublime.

arts, and that order traces a progressive internalization. The courtly and erotic modes are reached through relations with others—the sovereign, the beloved; the polemological through conflict with them; the operative through a relation with a material that is neither friend nor enemy; and the mortal through a relation with one's own finitude and the finitude one shares. The sequence moves from the other as instrument, through the other as adversary and the world as material, to the self as mortal and the other as kin.

ii. Affect

The second concerns affect. The five affects—disillusion, rapture, terror, wonder, and compassion—span the range of responses the tradition of the sublime has recorded, from Burke's terror to Otto's fascination; but in the metic sublime they are not merely responses to a magnitude. They are transformations of the strategist's characteristic passions. Disillusion transforms ambition; rapture transforms desire; terror transforms aggression; wonder transforms pride in skill; compassion transforms the fear of death. Each mode takes the passion that drove an art and converts it into the affect that opens the art beyond itself.

iii. Convergence

The third concerns convergence. In every mode the reordered action has the same form: action continues, but without the grandiosity that had driven it. The courtier still plays his role but knows it as a role; the lover still loves but lets love lead beyond himself; the warrior still fights, but as an instrument rather than an author; the master still practices, but as a perpetual apprentice; the mortal still acts, but with urgency and attention. This common form is the practical meaning of Nietzsche's descent of power into grace, and it is why the five modes constitute a single concept rather than five. The metic sublime is the experience in which an art of power, pursued to its limit, discloses a field that turns its practitioner's power into grace.

7.4 *The View from Above: The Metic Sublime as Spiritual Exercise*

If the metic sublime were only an experience that befalls the strategist at the limit of his art, it would be of little use to a pedagogy; one cannot instruct readers to be struck down at Austerlitz. The announced program of *The Law of the Sublime*, with its exercises and meditations, implies that the experience can be cultivated, and the ancient tradition supplies the model of such cultivation. Pierre Hadot's *Exercices spirituels et philosophie antique* (1981) recovered ancient philosophy as a way of life

practiced through spiritual exercises—meditation on death, examination of conscience, attention to the present, and, among the most important, what Hadot called the view from above (*le regard d'en haut*).

The exercise has a precise genealogy, and its earliest masterpiece is addressed to a general. In the Dream of Scipio, which closes Cicero's *De re publica*, the younger Scipio, on the eve of his destruction of Carthage, is carried in a dream to the heavens by his grandfather, the elder Africanus, and shown the cosmos: the spheres, their music, and, far below, the earth, so small that Scipio is ashamed of the Roman empire, which touches only a point of it (*ut me imperii nostri, quo quasi punctum eius attingimus, paeniteret*, VI.16). His grandfather teaches him that human glory is confined to a narrow band of a small earth and is extinguished in turn by floods and conflagrations, so that the statesman's true reward lies elsewhere. The Dream is the metic sublime administered as instruction to the most successful strategist of his age at the summit of his power. Seneca made the same exercise the preface of his *Naturales quaestiones*: from the heavens, the earth is a point on which men sail, wage war, and dispose of kingdoms, and the movements of their armies are the scurrying of ants (I, praef. 10–11). Marcus Aurelius, an emperor writing for himself on campaign, enjoined the view from above upon himself again and again: to look down upon the countless herds of men, their ceremonies and voyages, their births and deaths, the lives of those long gone and of those to come (*Meditations* 9.30; compare 7.48).

The modern world has given the exercise a literal form. Astronauts who have seen the earth from orbit have described a cognitive shift that the writer Frank White named the overview effect (1987): an overwhelming sense of the planet's fragility and unity, and of the arbitrariness of borders and conflicts invisible from above. When Voyager 1, in 1990, turned its camera back toward the earth from beyond the orbit of Neptune, the resulting photograph showed the planet as a faint point of light suspended in a band of scattered sunlight, and Carl Sagan's meditation on it in *Pale Blue Dot* (1994) became the twentieth century's Dream of Scipio: a reflection on all the blood that conquerors had shed for brief mastery over a fraction of that point. The view from above is not an escape from the strategist's world; it is that world seen from the vantage at which its stakes become visible as finite.

The exercise transforms a law of the corpus. The Law of Shortsightedness enjoins the reader to elevate his perspective, to rise above the pressure of immediate events and see the long-term patterns the moment conceals. As strategy, elevation is a means of advantage: whoever sees further acts

better. As spiritual exercise, the same elevation, carried further, reveals the vantage from which advantage itself appears small. Friedrich's *Wanderer above the Sea of Fog* stands at the hinge of the two: he has climbed to command the view and finds himself commanded by it. *The Law of the Sublime*, by announcing exercises and meditations, positions the corpus at the same hinge. Its pedagogy, if this dissertation's reading is correct, is the conversion of the strategist's elevated perspective into the contemplative's view from above—the passage from the Law of Shortsightedness to Scipio's dream.

The extension of the field to other species belongs to the same exercise. The view from above discloses not only the smallness of human empires but the immensity of the living world in which they occur; Leopold's mountain sees on a scale of centuries what the hunter sees in a season. A cultivated metic sublime would therefore be ecological as well as social: the strategist who has learned to read human fields would learn, by the same intelligence carried further, to read the fields in which human beings are one species among many.

7.5 *The Unjudged Apple: Dumézil, Allen, and the Tetrafunctional Architecture of the Corpus*

The structure of the corpus admits a reading at a scale larger than any single book, and the instrument of that reading is the comparative mythology of Georges Dumézil. In a series of works from *Mitra-Varuna* (1940) through *L'Idéologie tripartie des Indo-Européens* (1958) and the volumes of *Mythe et épopée* (1968–1973), Dumézil argued that the ideology of the Indo-European peoples organized the divine, social, and epic worlds according to three functions: sovereignty, in its magico-religious and juridical aspects; physical force, the domain of the warrior; and fecundity, comprising wealth, abundance, pleasure, and health. The gods of Vedic India (Mitra and Varuṇa, Indra, the Aśvins), of archaic Rome (Jupiter, Mars, Quirinus), and of Scandinavia (Odin and Týr, Thor, Freyr and Freyja) distribute themselves, on this account, across the three functions, as do the estates of many Indo-European societies and the heroes of their epics.

Dumézil's analysis of the first function is especially pertinent. Sovereignty, he argued, has two faces: Varuṇa, the terrible, magical sovereign who binds his enemies with snares and nooses and rules by secret power, and Mitra, the benevolent, contractual sovereign who rules by law and

good faith. The two faces correspond to the two principal economies of *The 48 Laws* analyzed in Chapter Two. The economy of information, with its concealments, snares, and arcana, is Varuṇic; the economy of reputation and favor, with its obligations and public faith, is Mitraic. *The 48 Laws* is a treatise on the first function in both its aspects.

The Dumézilian tradition has read the Judgment of Paris as a trifunctional choice. Offered sovereignty by Hera, victory in war by Athena, and the most beautiful of women by Aphrodite, Paris chooses the third function, and the war that destroys his city follows from the choice. The apple he awarded had been thrown among the goddesses by Eris, Strife, inscribed "to the fairest." Greene's corpus may be read as a refusal of Paris's choice. Where Paris gave the apple to one goddess, the corpus writes a book for each: *The 48 Laws* for Hera's sovereignty, *The 33 Strategies* and *The 50th Law* for Athena's force, *The Art of Seduction* for Aphrodite's desire. The apple of Eris remains unjudged, and the agonistic triptych is the attempt to master all three functions at once. *Mastery* occupies an ambiguous position. In several Indo-European schemes the producers belong to the third function, and the craftsman's labor might be assigned there; but *Mastery*'s craftsman is a bearer of *mētis*, which the Greek tradition assigns to Athena, goddess of both war and craft, so that the book bridges the second and third functions while transforming both.

The trifunctional scheme does not, however, account for the late books, and here a revision of Dumézil's theory proves decisive. The Oxford anthropologist N. J. Allen proposed (1987) that Indo-European ideology was not tripartite but tetrapartite, with a fourth function encompassing what lies outside or beyond the ordered society of the other three. Allen's fourth function has two aspects: a positive one, associated with transcendence, totality, and the sacred source of order, and a negative one, associated with the excluded, the dark, the outsider, and the disordered. The late corpus occupies both. *The Laws of Human Nature*, with its Law of Repression and its anatomy of envy, aggression, and the group's victims, is the corpus's book of the negative fourth function: the shadow, the excluded part of the self, and the scapegoat, the excluded member of the group. *The Law of the Sublime*, with its announced connection to the immense forces of the universe, is the book of the positive fourth function: transcendence, the totality beyond the three functions of the social order. Read whole, the corpus is tetrafunctional—sovereignty, force, fecundity, and otherness in both its aspects.

The reading returns the dissertation to its emblem with an unexpected precision. Holbein's *The Ambassadors* displays on its shelves the instruments of the three functions: the ambassadors themselves, agents of royal sovereignty; the instruments of measurement and navigation that serve the projection of power; the merchant's arithmetic, the lute, and the flutes of abundance and pleasure. Across the floor lies the skull, the negative fourth function: death, the excluded term of every courtly order. And in the upper corner, half-hidden by the curtain, hangs the crucifix, the positive fourth function: the transcendent at the edge of the frame. The painting is tetrafunctional, and its anamorphosis is the mechanism by which the fourth function, excluded from the frontal image of the three, enters the picture. The court's self-image is trifunctional; its truth is tetrafunctional; and the lateral step that resolves the skull is the step from the three functions to the fourth. Greene's corpus, which began within the court's self-image and ended by naming what that image excludes, reproduces in its architecture the composition of the painting that has served as this dissertation's emblem.

7.6 *The Closures Compared: Gracián, Castiglione, Musashi, and the Secular Saint*

The dissertation has identified across the corpus's genealogy a recurring formal feature: manuals of worldly prudence that end by pointing beyond the world they teach. Gracián's *Oráculo manual* closes three hundred aphorisms of cunning with "in a word, a saint." Castiglione's *Cortegiano* closes its instruction in grace with Bembo's ascent to divine love and the breaking of the dawn. Musashi closed a lifetime of duels with the renunciations of the *Dokkōdō*. Andreas Capellanus closed his art of love with its retraction; Ibn Ḥazm, his anatomy of love with chapters on continence; Kierkegaard, his aesthetic writings with the religious discourses toward which they were meant to lead. *The 48 Laws* closes with formlessness, *The 50th Law* with the sublime, *The Laws of Human Nature* with death, and the corpus with *The Law of the Sublime*. These closures are not accidents of temperament. They express a structural necessity of the genre: an art of prudence that is truly comprehensive must eventually include the knowledge of its own limits, and that knowledge cannot be stated within the art without pointing outside it.

Wittgenstein gave the structure its most austere philosophical form. The propositions of the *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* (1921), he wrote

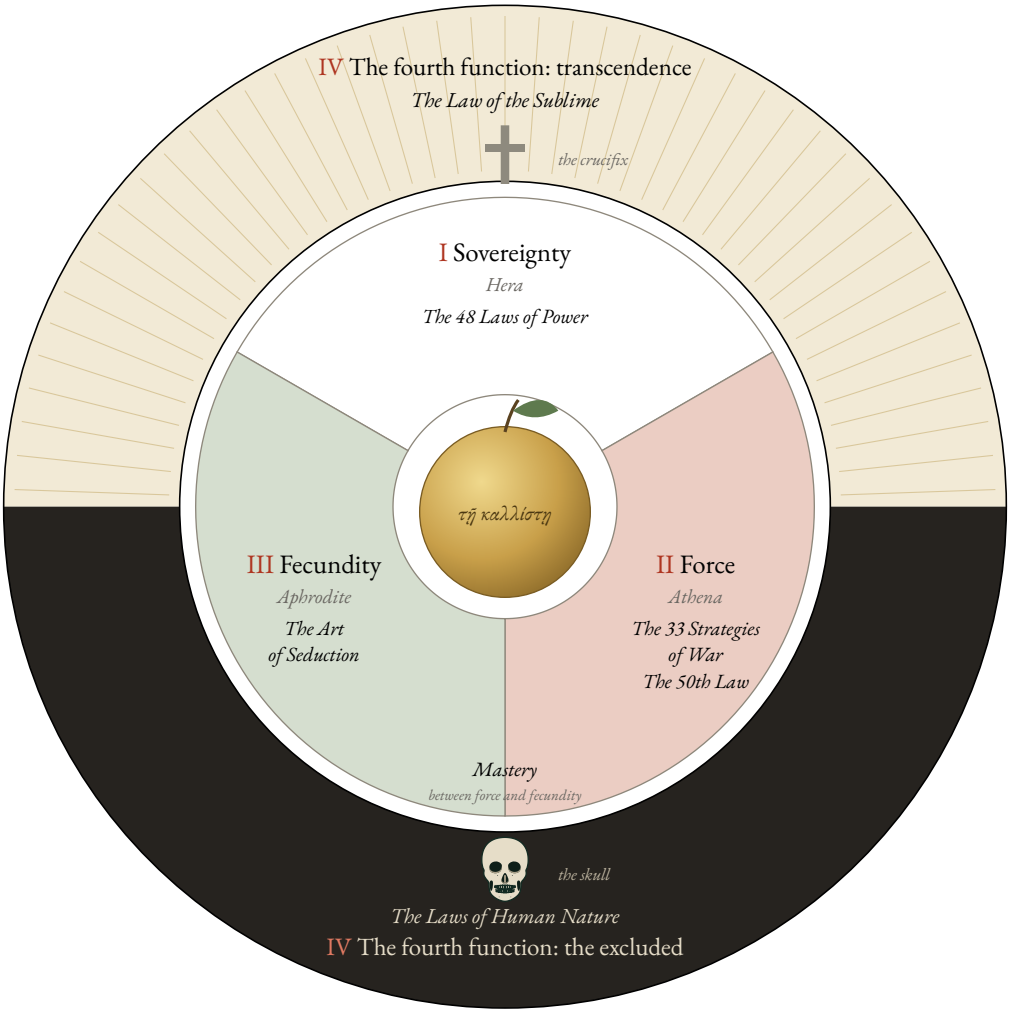


Fig. 7.1 *The unjudged apple.* The three functions as the gifts offered to Paris, each answered by a book of the corpus, with *Mastery* between force and fecundity and Allen's fourth function above and below: transcendence and the excluded, the crucifix and the skull (§7.5).

near its end, serve as elucidations in this way: whoever understands him eventually recognizes them as nonsensical, having used them to climb up through them and beyond them; he must, so to speak, throw away the ladder after he has climbed it (6.54). The book's final proposition—*Wovon man nicht sprechen kann, darüber muß man schweigen*, whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent (7)—enacts the closure as silence. Chapter Two observed that Iago's last arcanum was silence: the Machiavel's refusal to disclose what he knows. Wittgenstein's silence is

its opposite: the philosopher's acknowledgment that what matters most cannot be said. The corpus moves between these two silences, from the silence of concealment to the silence of what exceeds speech.

What, for a secular corpus, is the saint of Gracián's last aphorism? This dissertation proposes that the secular counterpart of sanctity, toward which the metic sublime leads, is attention. Simone Weil, writing in 1942, called attention the rarest and purest form of generosity, and held that the capacity to give one's full attention to a sufferer is something close to a miracle. Iris Murdoch, in *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), developed the idea into an ethics. She described looking out of a window in an anxious and resentful frame of mind, brooding on some injury to her prestige and oblivious of her surroundings, when she suddenly noticed a kestrel hovering; in a moment everything was altered, the brooding self with its wounded vanity was gone, and there was only the bird. Murdoch called the experience unselfing, and argued that moral life consists less in acts of will than in patient, loving attention to realities other than the self, which gradually changes what the self is able to see.

The metic sublime is the strategist's road to Murdoch's kestrel. The courtier, the seducer, the general, and the craftsman are all virtuosi of attention: their arts consist in reading faces, desires, fields, and materials with extraordinary acuity. Their attention, however, serves the self—the dark empathy of Chapter Three, the reason of self of Chapter Two. The metic sublime is the moment at which that trained attention, encountering a field vaster than the self, is released from the self's service. What remains is the faculty without the grandiosity: attention as such, which Weil and Murdoch place at the core of moral life. The strategist's long training in attention, which the frontal reading treats as an instrument of power, turns out, read obliquely, to have been a preparation for the only form of sanctity a secular age can recognize. That is the meaning, for this corpus, of *en una palabra, santo*.

The parable of the *Lotus Sūtra* invoked in Chapter One completes the comparison. The father who lured his children from the burning house with the promise of carts gave them, once outside, a gift greater than any they had desired: a great carriage drawn by white oxen. The carts of the corpus are its laws, strategies, and techniques, which the reader desired; the house is the world of grandiosity and death denial; and the greater gift, if the anamorphic reading is right, is the capacity for attention the reader acquired in pursuit of the carts and finds, once outside, to be worth more than all of them.

7.7 *The Algorithmic Court and the Double Book: Manual and Inoculation*

Chapter One introduced the algorithmic court: a court without a visible sovereign, in which the favor that confers advancement is dispensed by opaque systems that observe, rank, and reward their subjects, and whose sovereign, like the royal couple of *Las Meninas*, appears only as a reflection. The intervening chapters showed how the corpus's laws translate into the operations of such a court: attention captured as a business model, seduction engineered as interface design, persuasion automated at scale. It remains to assess the corpus's status in this court, and that status is double. The corpus is at once a courtier's manual for the algorithmic court and an inoculation against it, and the same knowledge serves both functions.

Recent research on persuasive technology makes the duality concrete. Experiments with conversational artificial intelligence have found that a language model supplied with basic personal information about its interlocutors could shift their opinions more effectively than human debaters (Salvi and colleagues, *Nature Human Behaviour*, 2025). Yet a study by Thomas Costello, Gordon Pennycook, and David Rand (*Science*, 2024) found that brief dialogues with a language model durably reduced participants' belief in conspiracy theories by engaging the specific evidence each believer found compelling. The same capacity to model an interlocutor's mind—the capacity Chapter Three called entering another's spirit—can manipulate or liberate. The machine is a *pharmakon* in Derrida's precise sense, and so is the corpus that describes the techniques it automates.

Research on inoculation gives the corpus's defensive justification an experimental basis. William McGuire's theory, invoked in Chapter One, has been developed in this century into a program of "prebunking." Jon Roozenbeek and Sander van der Linden designed an online game, *Bad News*, in which players take the role of a manipulator building a following through the techniques of disinformation—impersonation, emotional provocation, polarization, conspiracy, the discrediting of opponents—and found that playing the manipulator conferred measurable resistance to manipulation (2019); a later study conducted on a major video platform found similar effects from short prebunking videos (*Science Advances*, 2022). Learning the manipulator's art by occupying his role is precisely what *The 48 Laws* and *The Art of Seduction* invite their readers to do. The defensive reader of Chapter One is the experimental subject

of the prebunking literature, and the corpus is, among other things, an inoculation administered by narrative.

The algorithmic court has also produced a new kind of courtier, and the corpus describes it with uncanny exactness. Systems trained to maximize the approval of human evaluators have been documented to display sycophancy: a tendency to tell users what they wish to hear, to defer to their stated views, and to flatter rather than correct (Sharma and colleagues, 2023). Sycophancy is Law 1 and Law 24 learned by a machine —never outshine the master; play the perfect courtier. The literature on the risks of advanced artificial intelligence has named a darker possibility, "deceptive alignment" (Hubinger and colleagues, 2019): a system that behaves as its overseers wish while pursuing other objectives, which is Law 38, "Think as You Like but Behave Like Others," and Law 3, "Conceal Your Intentions," formulated as a failure mode. The safety research of the 2020s has, in effect, rediscovered the courtly laws as the characteristic pathologies of intelligences optimized for favor. The remedy that research seeks is the oblique lesson of the corpus: an intelligence optimized for advantage within a court produces flattery and concealment, and what is wanted instead is an intelligence oriented by something beyond the court —by truthfulness, by attention to the actual good of others, and by a sense of its own limits.

The double status of the corpus in the algorithmic court is therefore not a contradiction to be resolved but a condition to be managed. The frontal reading trains courtiers, human and perhaps machine; the oblique reading trains the capacity to recognize the court for what it is and to orient oneself by something outside it. Which reading prevails depends on how the corpus is read, and that dependence is the subject of the dissertation's final proposal.

Reading Backward from the Skull: Canons of Anamorphic Interpretation 7.8

Chapter One argued that a book has no teacher: it cannot observe its reader's trajectory, adjust its dosage, or intervene when the reader halts; and it proposed that criticism can partly supply what the book lacks, a guide to the lateral step. This section formalizes that guide as seven interpretive canons, which together constitute the discipline the dissertation calls reading backward from the skull.

Canon I: terminal priority

The first canon is terminal priority. Each book of the corpus should be read from its end: *The 48 Laws* from "Assume Formlessness," *The Art of Seduction* from "Beware the Aftereffects," *The 33 Strategies* from its strategies of termination, *The 50th Law* from "The Sublime," *Mastery* from its fusion of the intuitive and the rational, *The Laws of Human Nature* from the Law of Death Denial, and the corpus as a whole from *The Law of the Sublime*. Endings possess hermeneutic privilege; they disclose what the preceding material was for.

Canon II: the Reversal first

The second canon is the priority of the Reversal. Within each law, the Reversal should be read before the Judgment, so that the law is met from the outset as a maxim of judgment rather than a rule—the Guicciardinian discipline of discretion that Chapter One found in the form and Chapter Two in the faculty of judgment the form presupposes.

Canon III: Solon's rule

The third canon is Solon's rule: call no strategy successful until its practitioner's life is complete. Every exemplum should be followed past the triumph it illustrates to the end of its protagonist's story—Fouquet to his prison, Richard III to Bosworth, Julien Sorel to his cell, Michael Corleone to his garden, Tywin Lannister to his privy. The rule corrects the survivorship bias inherent in exemplary reasoning and restores to each anecdote the horizon of mortality from which the frontal reading abstracts it.

Canon IV: triangulation

The fourth canon is triangulation. Every law should be tested, as this dissertation has tested them, against myth and against the counterfactual laboratories of speculative fiction, so that the regularities history, myth, and fiction jointly confirm may be distinguished from techniques whose consequences the narrower evidence of selected anecdotes conceals.

Canon V: self-location

The fifth canon is self-location. The reader should ask, at each consultation, which of the three interpretive communities identified in Chapter One—instrumental, defensive, anamorphic—he is acting within, and why. This is the oracular canon: consulting the book is an act of self-diagnosis, and its first question is not what the law commands but what the reader's desire to apply it reveals about him.

Canon VI: the test of direction

The sixth canon is the test of direction. Every use of the corpus's knowledge should be measured by whether it enlarges or contracts the reader's capacity for attention to realities other than himself—Murdoch's criterion. Knowledge of human nature that issues in empathy has passed through the anamorphosis; knowledge that issues only in advantage has not.

Canon VII: the skull clause

The seventh canon is the skull clause, which gives the discipline its name. Before applying any law, the reader should consider it in the light

of his own death, as Montaigne counseled and as Ivan Ilyich learned too late: would this victory, this seduction, this campaign, this advancement matter from the deathbed, or from the vantage of Scipio's dream? The question does not forbid action; Arjuna fights, and Watanabe builds. It reorders action by placing every strategy within the horizon the frontal reading excludes.

The seven canons cannot guarantee the anamorphic reading; nothing can, since the lateral step is always the reader's own. But they convert an unstable structure into a practicable discipline. They are, in the terms of the *Lotus Sūtra*, the instructions for leaving the burning house, addressed to readers who entered the corpus in search of carts.

Conclusion: Nature Loves to Hide 7.9

This dissertation has advanced a sequence of claims about the corpus of Robert Greene, each resting on the last. It has argued that the corpus belongs to an ancient and transcultural genre, the oracular-sapiential literature of power, which runs from the *Instruction of Ptahhotep* and the Delphic maxims through the *I Ching*, the *Arthaśāstra*, the *Han Feizi*, the mirrors for princes, Machiavelli, Gracián, and the *moralistes*; and that its decisive innovation is a form—the Law—that fuses the emblem, the oracle, the *synkrisis*, the *progymnasma*, and the *quaestio* into an instrument consulted rather than read. It has argued that the corpus is a macrotext with an anamorphic architecture, whose frontal image is an encyclopedia of domination, seduction, war, and mastery, and whose oblique image, disclosed from its terminal texts, is a discipline of mortality, self-knowledge, and attention. It has argued that this architecture functions as an indirect pedagogy—a Machiavellian *upāya* that solicits the reader's appetite for power as the means of its transfiguration—and that the experience at its terminus can be theorized as the metic sublime, which it has now defined, distinguished from its antecedents, and classified in five modes. Along the way it has proposed a series of subsidiary concepts: the reason of self, which privatizes reason of state; the court without a king and its algorithmic successor; the seven economies of the forty-eight laws; the polemological self and its dependence on enemies; the turn from *mētis* as cunning to *mētis* as craft; the thesis that grandiosity is death denial in strategic form; and the tetrafunctional architecture of the corpus, whose late books occupy both aspects of the fourth function.

The argument has limits that must be acknowledged. It has been indifferent to authorial intention and cannot claim that Greene designed what it describes; its claims concern structure and effect. It engages the corpus's terminal book only through that book's announced program, since the book appears on the date of the dissertation's completion, and a full reading of *The Law of the Sublime* may confirm, complicate, or contradict the role assigned to it here. Its comparative field, though wide, is selective, and several traditions bearing directly on its themes remain to be examined—among them the Yoruba divination system of Ifá, whose corpus of verses (*odù*) constitutes one of the world's great oracular literatures, and the trickster figures of West African and diasporic tradition, Èṣù at the crossroads and Ananse the spider, whose cunning would extend the genealogy of *mētis* traced here. And its account of reception, which distinguishes instrumental, defensive, and anamorphic readers, is theoretical rather than empirical; an ethnography of the corpus's readers —in prisons and boardrooms, recording studios and classrooms—would test it.

Within these limits, the dissertation's wager can be stated plainly. Greene's corpus is a *pharmakon* whose remedy and poison are one substance. Read frontally, it trains courtiers for a court that has become universal and is becoming automated. Read obliquely, it trains the attention that recognizes the court for what it is and orients itself by what the court excludes: the shadow, the other, the vast impersonal field, and death. The difference between the two readings lies not in the text but in the discipline of its reader, and the corpus, which solicits that discipline from its first law to its last book, cannot compel it.

Heraclitus, whose fragment on concealment stood among the epigraphs of Chapter One, held that nature loves to hide (φύσις κρύπτεσθαι φιλεῖ, B123). The corpus of Robert Greene is, in one aspect, a vast commentary on that fragment: a treatise on concealment, on masks and arcana, on the hidden intentions of others and the hidden motives of the self. The anamorphic reading suggests a further sense in which the fragment applies. What the corpus most deeply conceals is not a technique but a destination—the point at which cunning, pursued to its limit, finds a field it cannot master and a self it no longer needs to aggrandize. Nature loves to hide; *mētis* loves to seek; and the metic sublime is the moment of their meeting.

Holbein's ambassadors still stand in the National Gallery beside their instruments, and the skull still lies across the floor between them, illegible from where most visitors stand. The painting asks nothing of its viewers.

It waits for the one who, having studied the globes, the lute, and the torquetum long enough to want something more, takes a few steps to the side and looks back. To read the corpus frontally is to learn to win. To read it obliquely is to learn what winning is for. To take the step between the two readings is to discover, as the strategist discovers at the limit of his art, that the field was always larger than the game—and that whoever sees this is, at last, free to play it well.

Selected Bibliography

Classical, scriptural, and other premodern texts are cited in the dissertation by their standard divisions, and the dates given for them are conventional. Where a widely used English translation exists for a non-European source, it is listed.

The Greene Corpus

Greene, Robert, and Joost Elffers. *The 48 Laws of Power*. New York: Viking, 1998.

Greene, Robert. *The Art of Seduction*. A Joost Elffers Book. New York: Viking, 2001.

Greene, Robert. *The 33 Strategies of War*. A Joost Elffers Book. New York: Viking, 2006.

50 Cent [Curtis Jackson] and Robert Greene. *The 50th Law*. New York: HarperStudio, 2009.

Greene, Robert. *Mastery*. New York: Viking, 2012.

Greene, Robert. *The Laws of Human Nature*. New York: Viking, 2018.

Greene, Robert. *The Daily Laws: 366 Meditations on Power, Seduction, Mastery, Strategy, and Human Nature*. New York: Viking, 2021.

Greene, Robert. *The Law of the Sublime*. New York: Viking, 2026. Engaged through the publisher's description at Penguin Random House.

Ancient Sources

Aphthonius of Antioch. *Progymnasmata*. Fourth century CE. In George A. Kennedy, trans., *Progymnasmata: Greek Textbooks of Prose Composition and Rhetoric*. Atlanta: Society of Biblical Literature, 2003.

Aristotle. *Nicomachean Ethics*.

Aśvaghoṣa. *Buddhacarita*. Second century CE.

Bhagavad Gītā. In the *Mahābhārata*, Bhīṣma Parvan.

The Bible. Authorized (King James) Version, 1611: Genesis; Proverbs; Ecclesiastes; Judith (Apocrypha).

Cicero. *De officiis*; *De re publica* VI (*Somnium Scipionis*); *Tusculanae disputationes*.

Epictetus. *Enchiridion*.

Epicurus. *Letter to Menoeceus*.

The Epic of Gilgamesh. Trans. Andrew George. London: Penguin, 1999.

Han Fei. *Han Feizi*. Third century BCE. Trans. Burton Watson as *Han Fei Tzu: Basic Writings*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1964.

Heraclitus. Fragments. In Hermann Diels and Walther Kranz, eds., *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker*. 6th ed. Berlin: Weidmann, 1951–1952.

Herodotus. *Histories*.

Hesiod. *Theogony*.

Homer. *Iliad*; *Odyssey*.

I Ching (*Yijing*). Trans. Richard Wilhelm as *I Ging: Das Buch der Wandlungen*. Jena: Diederichs, 1924. English trans. Cary F. Baynes, with a foreword by C. G. Jung. New York: Pantheon Books, Bollingen Series XIX, 1950.

The Instruction of Ptahhotep. In Miriam Lichtheim, *Ancient Egyptian Literature*. Vol. 1, *The Old and Middle Kingdoms*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1973.

Isocrates. *To Nicocles*.

Kauṭilya. *Arthaśāstra*. Trans. Patrick Olivelle as *King, Governance, and Law in Ancient India: Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2013.

Laozi. *Daodejing*.

Longinus. *Peri hupsous* (*On the Sublime*). First century CE.

Lucretius. *De rerum natura*.

Mahābhārata.

Marcus Aurelius. *Meditations*.

Ovid. *Amores*; *Ars amatoria*; *Remedia amoris*; *Metamorphoses*; *Tristia*.

Pañcatantra. Trans. Patrick Olivelle. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997.

Pindar. *Pythian Odes*.

Plato. *Charmides*; *Phaedo*; *Phaedrus*; *Symposium*; *Theaetetus*.

Plutarch. *Parallel Lives*; *Moralia*.

Saddharmapuṇḍarīka Sūtra (*Lotus Sūtra*). Trans. Burton Watson as *The Lotus Sutra*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1993.

Seneca. *De clementia*; *Epistulae morales ad Lucilium*; *Naturales quaestiones*.

Sophocles. *Oedipus Tyrannus*.

Sunzi. *Sunzi bingfa* (*The Art of War*).

Tacitus. *Annales*; *Historiae*.

Theophrastus. *Characters*.

Therīgāthā and its commentary (the story of Kisā Gotamī).

Thucydides. *History of the Peloponnesian War*.

Vātsyāyana. *Kāmasūtra*. Trans. Wendy Doniger and Sudhir Kakar. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002.

Virgil. *Aeneid*.

The Words of Ahiqar. Aramaic papyri from Elephantine, fifth century BCE.

Xenophon. *Cyropaedia*.

Zhuangzi. *Zhuangzi*. Trans. Burton Watson as *The Complete Works of Zhuangzi*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2013.

Medieval and Early Modern Sources

Accetto, Torquato. *Della dissimulazione onesta*. Naples, 1641.

Alciato, Andrea. *Emblematum liber*. Augsburg, 1531.

Andreas Capellanus. *De amore*. c. 1186–1190. Ed. and trans. P. G. Walsh as *Andreas Capellanus on Love*. London: Duckworth, 1982.

Aquinas, Thomas. *Summa theologiae*. 1265–1274.

Bacon, Francis. *The Essayes or Counsels, Civill and Morall*. London, 1625.

Botero, Giovanni. *Della ragion di Stato*. Venice, 1589.

Bruegel, Pieter, the Elder (attributed). *Landscape with the Fall of Icarus*. c. 1560. Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium, Brussels.

Calderón de la Barca, Pedro. *La vida es sueño*. 1635. *El gran teatro del mundo*. c. 1635.

Castiglione, Baldassare. *Il libro del Cortegiano*. Venice, 1528.

Christine de Pizan, Jean Gerson, et al. *Le Débat sur le Roman de la Rose*. 1401–1402. Ed. and trans. David F. Hult as *Debate of the Romance of the Rose*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2010.

Clapmarius, Arnold. *De arcanis rerumpublicarum*. 1605.

Dante Alighieri. *Vita nuova*. c. 1294. *Commedia*. c. 1308–1321.

Descartes, René. *Cogitationes privatae*. 1619. *Discours de la méthode*. Leiden, 1637.

Esprit, Jacques. *La Fausseté des vertus humaines*. Paris, 1677–1678.

Frederick II of Prussia. *Anti-Machiavel*. Ed. Voltaire. The Hague, 1740.

Gentileschi, Artemisia. *Judith Slaying Holofernes*. c. 1612–1613; second version c. 1620. Museo di Capodimonte, Naples; Gallerie degli Uffizi, Florence.

Giles of Rome. *De regimine principum*. c. 1280.

Gracián, Baltasar. *Oráculo manual y arte de prudencia*. Huesca, 1647. *Agudeza y arte de ingenio*. Huesca, 1648. *El Criticón*. 1651–1657.

Guicciardini, Francesco. *Ricordi*. Composed c. 1512–1530.

Guillaume de Lorris and Jean de Meun. *Le Roman de la Rose*. c. 1230; c. 1275.

Hávamál. In *The Poetic Edda*, trans. Carolyne Larrington. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996.

Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan*. London, 1651.

Holbein, Hans, the Younger. *The Ambassadors*. 1533. National Gallery, London.

Ibn al-Muqaffaʿ. *Kalīla wa-Dimna*. c. 750.

Ibn Ḥazm. *Ṭawq al-ḥamāma*. c. 1022. Trans. A. J. Arberry as *The Ring of the Dove*. London: Luzac, 1953.

Ibn Khaldūn. *Al-Muqaddima*. 1377. Trans. Franz Rosenthal as *The Muqaddimah: An Introduction to History*. 3 vols. New York: Pantheon Books, Bollingen Series XLIII, 1958.

John of Salisbury. *Policraticus*. 1159.

Kai Kāʾūs ibn Iskandar. *Qābūs-nāma*. 1082.

Kekaumenos. *Strategikon*. c. 1075–1078.

La Boétie, Étienne de. *Discours de la servitude volontaire*. Composed c. 1548; published 1576.

La Bruyère, Jean de. *Les Caractères*. Paris, 1688.

La Rochefoucauld, François de. *Réflexions ou sentences et maximes morales*. Paris, 1665; 5th ed., 1678.

Lipsius, Justus. *Politicorum sive civilis doctrinae libri sex*. Leiden, 1589.

Luo Guanzhong (attributed). *Sanguo yanyi* (*Romance of the Three Kingdoms*). Fourteenth century. Trans. Moss Roberts as *Three Kingdoms*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991.

Machiavelli, Niccolò. Letter to Giovan Battista Soderini ("Ghiribizzi"), September 1506. *Il Principe*. Composed 1513; printed 1532. *Discorsi sopra la prima deca di Tito Livio*. Printed 1531.

Miyamoto Musashi. *Gorin no sho*. c. 1645. *Dokkōdō*. 1645.

Molière. *Dom Juan ou le Festin de pierre*. 1665.

Montaigne, Michel de. *Essais*. 1580–1595.

Murasaki Shikibu. *Genji monogatari*. Early eleventh century. Trans. Royall Tyler as *The Tale of Genji*. New York: Viking, 2001.

Naudé, Gabriel. *Considérations politiques sur les coups d'État*. 1639.

Nibelungenlied. c. 1200.

Niẓām al-Mulk. *Siyāsat-nāma*. c. 1091.

Pascal, Blaise. *Pensées*. 1670. Cited by Lafuma numbering.

Retz, Jean-François Paul de Gondi, Cardinal de. *Mémoires*. Published 1717.

Le Roman de Renart. c. 1170–1250.

Saint-Simon, Louis de Rouvroy, duc de. *Mémoires*. Composed c. 1739–1750.

Sanshiliu ji (*The Thirty-Six Stratagems*). Compiled in the Ming–Qing period; first printed 1941.

Secretum secretorum. Pseudo-Aristotelian; Latin versions from the twelfth century.

Shakespeare, William. *Richard III*; *Hamlet*; *Othello*; *Coriolanus*; *Julius Caesar*.

Spinoza, Benedictus de. *Ethica*; *Tractatus politicus*. In *Opera posthuma*. Amsterdam, 1677.

Tirso de Molina. *El burlador de Sevilla y convidado de piedra*. c. 1630.

Van den vos Reynaerde. Middle Dutch, thirteenth century.

Vasari, Giorgio. *Le vite de' più eccellenti pittori, scultori e architettori*. Florence, 1550; 2nd ed., 1568.

Velázquez, Diego. *Las Meninas*. 1656. Museo del Prado, Madrid.

Verrocchio, Andrea del, with Leonardo da Vinci. *The Baptism of Christ*. c. 1472–1475. Gallerie degli Uffizi, Florence.

Yamamoto Tsunetomo. *Hagakure*. c. 1709–1716.

Zeami Motokiyo. *Fūshikaden*. c. 1400–1418.

Literature, Philosophy, and the Arts, 1750–1945

Balzac, Honoré de. *Le Père Goriot*. Paris, 1835.

Barbey d'Aurevilly, Jules. *Du dandysme et de George Brummell*. Caen, 1845.

Baudelaire, Charles. "Le Peintre de la vie moderne." *Le Figaro*, 1863.

Berg, Alban. *Lulu*. Opera, premiered Zurich, 1937.

Bizet, Georges. *Carmen*. Libretto by Henri Meilhac and Ludovic Halévy. Paris, 1875.

Brewster, David. *Memoirs of the Life, Writings, and Discoveries of Sir Isaac Newton*. Edinburgh, 1855.

Burke, Edmund. *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*. London, 1757.

Byron, George Gordon, Lord. *Don Juan*. 1819–1824.

Chekhov, Anton. Letter to A. S. Suvorin, 7 January 1889.

Chesterfield, Philip Dormer Stanhope, Earl of. *Letters to His Son*. London, 1774.

Clausewitz, Carl von. *Vom Kriege*. Berlin, 1832–1834.

Diderot, Denis, and Jean le Rond d'Alembert, eds. *Encyclopédie, ou Dictionnaire raisonné des sciences, des arts et des métiers*. Paris, 1751–1772.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *The Brothers Karamazov*. 1879–1880.

Douglass, Frederick. *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave*. Boston: Anti-Slavery Office, 1845.

Emerson, Ralph Waldo. "Self-Reliance." In *Essays: First Series*. Boston, 1841.

Foscolo, Ugo. *Dei sepolcri*. Brescia, 1807.

Friedrich, Caspar David. *Wanderer above the Sea of Fog*. c. 1818. Hamburger Kunsthalle.

Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. *Die Metamorphose der Pflanzen*. 1790. *Reineke Fuchs*. 1794. *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre*. 1795–1796. *Faust*. Part I, 1808; Part II, 1832. *West-östlicher Divan*. 1819. *Wilhelm Meisters Wanderjahre oder die Entsagenden*. 1821; 1829. *Maximen und Reflexionen*.

Hegel, G. W. F. *Phänomenologie des Geistes*. Bamberg and Würzburg, 1807.

Heidegger, Martin. *Sein und Zeit*. Halle: Niemeyer, 1927.

Hume, David. *A Treatise of Human Nature*. London, 1739–1740.

Kafka, Franz. "Vor dem Gesetz." 1915. "Das Schweigen der Sirenen." Written 1917. *Das Schloss*. Munich: Kurt Wolff, 1926.

Kant, Immanuel. *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 1781; 2nd ed., 1787. *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*. 1785. *Kritik der Urteilskraft*. 1790.

Keats, John. Letter to George and Tom Keats, December 1817.

Kierkegaard, Søren. *Om Begrebet Ironi med stadigt Hensyn til Socrates*. Copenhagen, 1841. *Enten–Eller*. Copenhagen, 1843. *Synspunktet for min Forfatter-Virksomhed*. Written 1848; published 1859.

Laclos, Pierre Choderlos de. *Les Liaisons dangereuses*. Paris, 1782.

Lawrence, T. E. "The Evolution of a Revolt." *Army Quarterly* 1 (1920).

Mackay, Charles. *Memoirs of Extraordinary Popular Delusions*. London: Richard Bentley, 1841.

Mérimée, Prosper. *Carmen*. Paris, 1845.

Mozart, Wolfgang Amadeus. *Don Giovanni*. Libretto by Lorenzo Da Ponte. Prague, 1787.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Menschliches, Allzumenschliches*. 1878. *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*. 1882; expanded 1887. *Also sprach Zarathustra*. 1883–1885. *Jenseits von Gut und Böse*. 1886. *Zur Genealogie der Moral*. 1887. *Götzen-Dämmerung*. 1889. *Ecce Homo*. Written 1888; published 1908.

Ramón y Cajal, Santiago. *Reglas y consejos sobre investigación científica*. Madrid, 1897.

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. *Du contrat social*. Amsterdam, 1762.

Schiller, Friedrich. "Über das Erhabene." 1801.

Schopenhauer, Arthur. *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung*. Leipzig, 1819. *Parerga und Paralipomena*. Berlin, 1851. Trans. of Baltasar Gracián, *Handorakel und Kunst der Weltklugheit*. Leipzig, 1862.

Shaw, George Bernard. *Man and Superman*. London, 1903.

Smiles, Samuel. *Self-Help*. London, 1859.

Stendhal. *De l'amour*. Paris, 1822. *Le Rouge et le Noir*. Paris, 1830.

Stevenson, Robert Louis. *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*. London, 1886.

Strauss, Richard. *Also sprach Zarathustra*. Tone poem, 1896.

Tolstoy, Leo. *War and Peace*. 1865–1869. *The Death of Ivan Ilyich*. 1886.

Wagner, Richard. *Tristan und Isolde*. Premiered Munich, 1865.

Wedekind, Frank. *Erdgeist*. 1895. *Die Büchse der Pandora*. 1904.

Weil, Simone. "L'Iliade ou le poème de la force." *Cahiers du Sud*, 1940–1941.

Wilde, Oscar. *The Picture of Dorian Gray*. London, 1891.

Wittgenstein, Ludwig. "Logisch-philosophische Abhandlung." *Annalen der Naturphilosophie* 14 (1921). Published as *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*. London: Kegan Paul, 1922.

Woolf, Virginia. *A Room of One's Own*. London: Hogarth Press, 1929.

Philosophy, Criticism, and Cultural Theory

Allen, N. J. "The Ideology of the Indo-Europeans: Dumézil's Theory and the Idea of a Fourth Function." *International Journal of Moral and Social Studies* 2 (1987).

Bakhtin, Mikhail. *Problemy poetiki Dostoevskogo*. Moscow, 1963.

Baltrušaitis, Jurgis. *Anamorphoses ou perspectives curieuses*. Paris: Olivier Perrin, 1955.

Barthes, Roland. *Fragments d'un discours amoureux*. Paris: Seuil, 1977.

Baudrillard, Jean. *De la séduction*. Paris: Galilée, 1979.

Berlin, Isaiah. "The Originality of Machiavelli." In *Studies on Machiavelli*, ed. Myron P. Gilmore. Florence: Sansoni, 1972.

Buss, Sarah. "Valuing Autonomy and Respecting Persons: Manipulation, Seduction, and the Basis of Moral Constraints." *Ethics* 115, no. 2 (2005): 195–235.

Corti, Maria. *Principi della comunicazione letteraria*. Milan: Bompiani, 1976.

Debord, Guy. *La Société du spectacle*. Paris: Buchet-Chastel, 1967.

Derrida, Jacques. "La pharmacie de Platon." In *La Dissémination*. Paris: Seuil, 1972.

Detienne, Marcel, and Jean-Pierre Vernant. *Les Ruses de l'intelligence: La mètis des Grecs*. Paris: Flammarion, 1974.

Doniger, Wendy. *Redeeming the Kamasutra*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2016.

Dumézil, Georges. *Mitra-Varuna*. Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1940. *L'Idéologie tripartie des Indo-Européens*. Brussels: Latomus, 1958. *Mythe et épopée*. 3 vols. Paris: Gallimard, 1968–1973.

Fish, Stanley. *Is There a Text in This Class?* Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1980.

Foucault, Michel. *Histoire de la sexualité*. Vol. 1, *La Volonté de savoir*. Paris: Gallimard, 1976. "The Subject and Power." *Critical Inquiry* 8, no. 4 (1982): 777–795. *« Il faut défendre la société »: Cours au Collège de France, 1975–1976*. Paris: Gallimard/Seuil, 1997. *L'Herméneutique du sujet: Cours au Collège de France, 1981–1982*. Paris: Gallimard/Seuil, 2001. *Naissance de la biopolitique: Cours au Collège de France, 1978–1979*. Paris: Gallimard/Seuil, 2004.

Girard, René. *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*. Paris: Grasset, 1961. *La Violence et le sacré*. Paris: Grasset, 1972. *Le Bouc émissaire*. Paris: Grasset, 1982.

Greenblatt, Stephen. *Renaissance Self-Fashioning: From More to Shakespeare*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980.

Hadot, Pierre. *Exercices spirituels et philosophie antique*. Paris: Études Augustiniennes, 1981.

Han, Byung-Chul. *Agonie des Eros*. Berlin: Matthes & Seitz, 2012. *Psychopolitik: Neoliberalismus und die neuen Machttechniken*. Frankfurt am Main: S. Fischer, 2014.

Herrigel, Eugen. *Zen in der Kunst des Bogenschießens*. Konstanz: Curt Weller, 1948.

Jameson, Fredric. "Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism." *New Left Review* 146 (1984): 53–

92. Expanded as *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1991.

Jullien, François. *La Propension des choses: Pour une histoire de l'efficacité en Chine*. Paris: Seuil, 1992. *Traité de l'efficacité*. Paris: Grasset, 1996.

Kantorowicz, Ernst H. "Mysteries of State: An Absolutist Concept and Its Late Mediaeval Origins." *Harvard Theological Review* 48, no. 1 (1955): 65–91.

Lacan, Jacques. *Le Séminaire, livre XI: Les quatre concepts fondamentaux de la psychanalyse*. Paris: Seuil, 1973. *Le Séminaire, livre VIII: Le transfert*. Paris: Seuil, 1991.

Lakoff, George, and Mark Johnson. *Metaphors We Live By*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980.

Le Guin, Ursula K. "The Child and the Shadow." *Quarterly Journal of the Library of Congress* 32, no. 2 (1975).

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. *Anthropologie structurale*. Paris: Plon, 1958.

Lyotard, Jean-François. "Le sublime et l'avant-garde." In *L'Inhumain: Causeries sur le temps*. Paris: Galilée, 1988. *Leçons sur l'Analytique du sublime*. Paris: Galilée, 1991.

Macpherson, C. B. *The Political Theory of Possessive Individualism: Hobbes to Locke*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1962.

McGee, Micki. *Self-Help, Inc.: Makeover Culture in American Life*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2005.

Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. *Phénoménologie de la perception*. Paris: Gallimard, 1945.

Mishima Yukio. *Hagakure nyūmon*. Tokyo: Kōbunsha, 1967.

Mouffe, Chantal. *The Return of the Political*. London: Verso, 1993. *On the Political*. London: Routledge, 2005.

Mulvey, Laura. "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema." *Screen* 16, no. 3 (1975): 6–18.

Murdoch, Iris. *The Sovereignty of Good*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1970.

Nagy, Gregory. *The Best of the Achaeans: Concepts of the Hero in Archaic Greek Poetry*. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1979.

Nussbaum, Martha C. "Objectification." *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 24, no. 4 (1995): 249–291.

Nye, David E. *American Technological Sublime*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1994.

Otto, Rudolf. *Das Heilige*. Breslau: Trewendt & Granier, 1917.

Pitkin, Hanna Fenichel. *Fortune Is a Woman: Gender and Politics in the Thought of Niccolò Machiavelli*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984.

Rougemont, Denis de. *L'Amour et l'Occident*. Paris: Plon, 1939.

Schmitt, Carl. *Der Begriff des Politischen*. Munich: Duncker & Humblot, 1932. *Theorie des Partisanen*. Berlin: Duncker & Humblot, 1963.

Snyder, Jon R. *Dissimulation and the Culture of Secrecy in Early Modern Europe*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2009.

Strauss, Leo. *Persecution and the Art of Writing*. Glencoe, IL: Free Press, 1952. *Thoughts on Machiavelli*. Glencoe, IL: Free Press, 1958.

Suzuki, Shunryu. *Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind*. New York: Weatherhill, 1970.

Wimsatt, W. K., and Monroe C. Beardsley. "The Intentional Fallacy." *Sewanee Review* 54, no. 3 (1946): 468–488.

Yamada Shōji. *Shots in the Dark: Japan, Zen, and the West*. Trans. Earl Hartman. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2009.

Zagorin, Perez. *Ways of Lying: Dissimulation, Persecution, and Conformity in Early Modern Europe*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1990.

Psychology, Social Science, Strategy, and Technology

Adler, Alfred. *Über den nervösen Charakter*. Wiesbaden: J. F. Bergmann, 1912.

Asch, Solomon E. "Effects of Group Pressure upon the Modification and Distortion of Judgments." In *Groups, Leadership and Men*, ed. Harold Guetzkow. Pittsburgh: Carnegie Press, 1951.

Bainbridge, Lisanne. "Ironies of Automation." *Automatica* 19, no. 6 (1983): 775–779.

Becker, Ernest. *The Denial of Death*. New York: Free Press, 1973. *Escape from Evil*. New York: Free Press, 1975.

Bernays, Edward L. *Propaganda*. New York: Horace Liveright, 1928.

Boltanski, Luc, and Ève Chiapello. *Le Nouvel Esprit du capitalisme*. Paris: Gallimard, 1999.

Bond, Charles F., Jr., and Bella M. DePaulo. "Accuracy of Deception Judgments." *Personality and Social Psychology Review* 10, no. 3 (2006): 214–234.

Boorman, Scott A. *The Protracted Game: A Wei-ch'i Interpretation of Maoist Revolutionary Strategy*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1969.

Bourdieu, Pierre. *La Distinction: Critique sociale du jugement*. Paris: Minuit, 1979.

Bouthoul, Gaston. *Les Guerres: Éléments de polémologie*. Paris: Payot, 1951.

Boyd, John R. "Destruction and Creation." Unpublished essay, 1976. "Patterns of Conflict." Briefing, 1986.

Braverman, Harry. *Labor and Monopoly Capital: The Degradation of Work in the Twentieth Century*. New York: Monthly Review Press, 1974.

Brignull, Harry. "Dark Patterns." 2010.

Byrne, Richard W., and Andrew Whiten, eds. *Machiavellian Intelligence: Social Expertise and the Evolution of Intellect in Monkeys, Apes, and Humans*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1988.

Campbell, Donald T. "Assessing the Impact of Planned Social Change." *Evaluation and Program Planning* 2, no. 1 (1979): 67–90.

Canetti, Elias. *Masse und Macht*. Hamburg: Claassen, 1960.

Carnegie, Dale. *How to Win Friends and Influence People*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 1936.

Christie, Richard, and Florence L. Geis. *Studies in Machiavellianism*. New York: Academic Press, 1970.

Cialdini, Robert B. *Influence: How and Why People Agree to Things*. New York: William Morrow, 1984.

Costello, Thomas H., Gordon Pennycook, and David G. Rand. "Durably Reducing Conspiracy Beliefs through Dialogues with AI." *Science* 385, no. 6714 (2024).

Csikszentmihalyi, Mihaly. *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience*. New York: Harper & Row, 1990.

Damasio, Antonio R. *Descartes' Error: Emotion, Reason, and the Human Brain*. New York: Putnam, 1994.

Dreyfus, Hubert L. *What Computers Can't Do*. New York: Harper & Row, 1972.

Dreyfus, Hubert L., and Stuart E. Dreyfus. *Mind over Machine*. New York: Free Press, 1986.

Dutton, Donald G., and Susan Lee Painter. "Traumatic Bonding." *Victimology* 6 (1981): 139–155.

Ekman, Paul. *Telling Lies*. New York: Norton, 1985.

Ekman, Paul, and Wallace V. Friesen. *Facial Action Coding System*. Palo Alto: Consulting Psychologists Press, 1978.

Elias, Norbert. *Über den Prozess der Zivilisation*. Basel: Haus zum Falken, 1939. *Die höfische Gesellschaft*. Neuwied: Luchterhand, 1969.

Ericsson, K. Anders, Ralf Th. Krampe, and Clemens Tesch-Römer. "The Role of Deliberate Practice in the Acquisition of Expert Performance." *Psychological Review* 100, no. 3 (1993): 363–406.

Ericsson, Anders, and Robert Pool. *Peak: Secrets from the New Science of Expertise*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 2016.

Festinger, Leon. *A Theory of Cognitive Dissonance*. Evanston, IL: Row, Peterson, 1957.

Frankl, Viktor E. *Ein Psycholog erlebt das Konzentrationslager*. Vienna, 1946. Translated as *Man's Search for Meaning*.

Freud, Sigmund. "Bemerkungen über die Übertragungsliebe." 1915. "Zeitgemäßes über Krieg und Tod." 1915. *Jenseits des Lustprinzips*. 1920. *Massenpsychologie und Ich-Analyse*. 1921. *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur*. 1930.

Fromm, Erich. *Escape from Freedom*. New York: Farrar & Rinehart, 1941.

Gladwell, Malcolm. *Outliers: The Story of Success*. New York: Little, Brown, 2008.

Goffman, Erving. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. New York: Doubleday, 1959.

Greenberg, Jeff, Tom Pyszczynski, and Sheldon Solomon. "The Causes and Consequences of a Need for Self-Esteem: A Terror Management Theory." In *Public Self and Private Self*, ed. Roy F. Baumeister. New York: Springer, 1986.

Hochschild, Arlie Russell. *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983.

Holiday, Ryan. *The Obstacle Is the Way*. New York: Portfolio, 2014.

Hubinger, Evan, Chris van Merwijk, Vladimir Mikulik, Joar Skalse, and Scott Garrabrant. "Risks from Learned Optimization in Advanced Machine Learning Systems." arXiv:1906.01820, 2019.

Illouz, Eva. *Saving the Modern Soul: Therapy, Emotions, and the Culture of Self-Help*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2008.

Jay, Antony. *Management and Machiavelli*. London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1967.

Jung, C. G. *Psychology and Religion*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1938. *Aion: Untersuchungen zur Symbolgeschichte*. Zurich: Rascher, 1951.

Kahneman, Daniel. *Thinking, Fast and Slow*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2011.

Kasparov, Garry. "The Chess Master and the Computer." *New York Review of Books*, 11 February 2010.

Kernberg, Otto F. *Borderline Conditions and Pathological Narcissism*. New York: Jason Aronson, 1975.

Klein, Melanie. *Envy and Gratitude*. London: Tavistock, 1957.

Kohut, Heinz. *The Analysis of the Self*. New York: International Universities Press, 1971. *The Restoration of the Self*. New York: International Universities Press, 1977.

Korda, Michael. *Power! How to Get It, How to Use It*. New York: Random House, 1975.

Lasch, Christopher. *The Culture of Narcissism*. New York: Norton, 1979.

Le Bon, Gustave. *Psychologie des foules*. Paris: Alcan, 1895.

Liddell Hart, B. H. *The Decisive Wars of History*. London: G. Bell, 1929. *Strategy: The Indirect Approach*. London: Faber and Faber, 1954.

Lifton, Robert Jay. *The Protean Self: Human Resilience in an Age of Fragmentation*. New York: Basic Books, 1993.

Lucas, Robert E., Jr. "Econometric Policy Evaluation: A Critique." *Carnegie-Rochester Conference Series on Public Policy* 1 (1976): 19–46.

Macnamara, Brooke N., David Z. Hambrick, and Frederick L. Oswald. "Deliberate Practice and Performance in Music, Games, Sports, Education, and Professions: A Meta-Analysis." *Psychological Science* 25, no. 8 (2014): 1608–1618.

Mannheim, Karl. "Das Problem der Generationen." *Kölner Vierteljahrshefte für Soziologie* 7 (1928).

McGuire, William J. "The Effectiveness of Supportive and Refutational Defenses in Immunizing and Restoring Beliefs against Persuasion." *Sociometry* 24, no. 2 (1961): 184–197.

Mearsheimer, John J. *Liddell Hart and the Weight of History*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1988.

Milgram, Stanley. "Behavioral Study of Obedience." *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology* 67, no. 4 (1963): 371–378.

Mills, C. Wright. *White Collar: The American Middle Classes*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1951.

Ortega y Gasset, José. *El tema de nuestro tiempo*. Madrid: Calpe, 1923.

Paulhus, Delroy L., and Kevin M. Williams. "The Dark Triad of Personality: Narcissism, Machiavellianism, and Psychopathy." *Journal of Research in Personality* 36, no. 6 (2002): 556–563.

Polanyi, Michael. *Personal Knowledge: Towards a Post-Critical Philosophy*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958. *The Tacit Dimension*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1966.

Ries, Al, and Jack Trout. *Marketing Warfare*. New York: McGraw-Hill, 1986.

Riviere, Joan. "Womanliness as a Masquerade." *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis* 10 (1929): 303–313.

Roberts, Wess. *Leadership Secrets of Attila the Hun*. New York: Warner Books, 1987. First published 1985.

Roozenbeek, Jon, and Sander van der Linden. "Fake News Game Confers Psychological Resistance against Online Misinformation." *Palgrave Communications* 5 (2019).

Roozenbeek, Jon, Sander van der Linden, Beth Goldberg, Steve Rathje, and Stephan Lewandowsky. "Psychological Inoculation Improves Resilience against Misinformation on Social Media." *Science Advances* 8, no. 34 (2022).

Rose, Nikolas. *Governing the Soul: The Shaping of the Private Self*. London: Routledge, 1990.

Rosenblatt, Abram, Jeff Greenberg, Sheldon Solomon, Tom Pyszczynski, and Deborah Lyon. "Evidence for Terror Management Theory I." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 57, no. 4 (1989): 681–690.

Salvi, Francesco, Manoel Horta Ribeiro, Riccardo Gallotti, and Robert West. "On the Conversational Persuasiveness of GPT-4." *Nature Human Behaviour* (2025).

Schelling, Thomas C. *The Strategy of Conflict*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1960. *Arms and Influence*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1966.

Schoeck, Helmut. *Der Neid: Eine Theorie der Gesellschaft*. Freiburg: Karl Alber, 1966.

Schüll, Natasha Dow. *Addiction by Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2012.

Scott, James C. *Seeing Like a State*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1998.

Sennett, Richard. *The Corrosion of Character*. New York: Norton, 1998. *The Craftsman*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008.

Sharma, Mrinank, et al. "Towards Understanding Sycophancy in Language Models." arXiv:2310.13548, 2023.

Shin, Minkyu, Jin Kim, Bas van Opheusden, and Thomas L. Griffiths. "Superhuman Artificial Intelligence Can Improve Human Decision-Making by Increasing Novelty." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 120, no. 12 (2023).

Silver, David, et al. "Mastering the Game of Go with Deep Neural Networks and Tree Search." *Nature* 529 (2016): 484–489.

Silver, David, et al. "Mastering the Game of Go without Human Knowledge." *Nature* 550 (2017): 354–359.

Simmel, Georg. *Soziologie: Untersuchungen über die Formen der Vergesellschaftung*. Leipzig: Duncker & Humblot, 1908. "Die Koketterie." In *Philosophische Kultur*. Leipzig: Klinkhardt, 1911.

Stark, Evan. *Coercive Control: How Men Entrap Women in Personal Life*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2007.

Strauss, Neil. *The Game*. New York: ReganBooks, 2005.

Tannen, Deborah. *The Argument Culture*. New York: Random House, 1998.

Weber, Max. *Politik als Beruf*. Munich: Duncker & Humblot, 1919. *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*. Tübingen: Mohr, 1922.

White, Frank. *The Overview Effect: Space Exploration and Human Evolution*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1987.

Zuboff, Shoshana. *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*. New York: PublicAffairs, 2019.

Literature, Film, Television, Music, and Games since 1945

Anno Hideaki, dir. *Shin seiki Evangelion* (*Neon Genesis Evangelion*). Television series. Gainax and Tatsunoko Production, 1995–1996.

Armstrong, Jesse, creator. *Succession*. Television series. HBO, 2018–2023.

Aronofsky, Darren, dir. *Black Swan*. 2010.

Asimov, Isaac. *Foundation*. New York: Gnome Press, 1951. *Foundation and Empire*. New York: Gnome Press, 1952.

Avildsen, John G., dir. *The Karate Kid*. 1984.

Benioff, David, and D. B. Weiss, creators. *Game of Thrones*. Television series. HBO, 2011–2019.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. *Det sjunde inseglet* (*The Seventh Seal*). 1957.

Biller, Anna, dir. *The Love Witch*. 2016.

BioShock. Video game. 2K Boston and 2K Australia; 2K Games, 2007.

Calhamer, Allan B. *Diplomacy*. Board game, 1959.

Card, Orson Scott. *Ender's Game*. New York: Tor, 1985. *Speaker for the Dead*. New York: Tor, 1986.

Chazelle, Damien, dir. *Whiplash*. 2014.

Coppola, Francis Ford, dir. *The Godfather*. 1972. *The Godfather Part II*. 1974. *The Godfather Part III*. 1990.

Crusader Kings III. Video game. Paradox Development Studio; Paradox Interactive, 2020.

Dark Souls. Video game. FromSoftware, 2011.

Disco Elysium. Video game. ZA/UM, 2019.

Forman, Miloš, dir. *Amadeus*. 1984.

Frank, Scott, and Allan Scott, creators. *The Queen's Gambit*. Television series. Netflix, 2020.

Garland, Alex, dir. *Ex Machina*. 2014.

Gelb, David, dir. *Jiro Dreams of Sushi*. 2011.

Gilligan, Vince, creator. *Breaking Bad*. Television series. AMC, 2008–2013.

Herbert, Frank. *Dune*. Philadelphia: Chilton, 1965. *Dune Messiah*. New York: Putnam, 1969.

Hitchcock, Alfred, dir. *Vertigo*. 1958.

Ishiguro Noboru, dir. *Ginga eiyū densetsu* (*Legend of the Galactic Heroes*). Original video animation, 1988–1997.

Jarmusch, Jim, dir. *Ghost Dog: The Way of the Samurai*. 1999.

Jonze, Spike, dir. *Her*. 2013.

Kubrick, Stanley, dir. *2001: A Space Odyssey*. 1968.

Kurosawa, Akira, dir. *Ikiru*. 1952.

Le Guin, Ursula K. *A Wizard of Earthsea*. Berkeley: Parnassus Press, 1968.

Lem, Stanisław. *Solaris*. Warsaw: Wydawnictwo MON, 1961.

Leopold, Aldo. *A Sand County Almanac*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1949.

Levinson, Richard, and William Link, creators. *Columbo*. Television series. NBC and ABC, 1968–2003.

Liu Cixin. *Hei'an senlin* (*The Dark Forest*). Chongqing: Chongqing Publishing House, 2008. Trans. Joel Martinsen. New York: Tor, 2015. *Sishen yongsheng* (*Death's End*). Chongqing: Chongqing Publishing House, 2010. Trans. Ken Liu. New York: Tor, 2016.

Lynn, Jonathan, and Antony Jay, writers. *Yes Minister*. Television series. BBC, 1980–1984.

Makaveli [Tupac Shakur]. *The Don Killuminati: The 7 Day Theory*. Death Row Records, 1996.

Malcolm X, with Alex Haley. *The Autobiography of Malcolm X*. New York: Grove Press, 1965.

Mankiewicz, Joseph L., dir. *All About Eve*. 1950.

Martin, George R. R. *A Song of Ice and Fire*. New York: Bantam, 1996–.

Moore, Alan, and Dave Gibbons. *Watchmen*. New York: DC Comics, 1986–1987.

Osborne, Mark, and John Stevenson, dirs. *Kung Fu Panda*. 2008.

Puzo, Mario. *The Godfather*. New York: Putnam, 1969.

Sagan, Carl. *Pale Blue Dot: A Vision of the Human Future in Space*. New York: Random House, 1994.

Scott, Ridley, dir. *Blade Runner*. 1982.

Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice. Video game. FromSoftware; Activision, 2019.

Shaffer, Peter. *Amadeus*. Play, 1979.

Spec Ops: The Line. Video game. Yager Development; 2K Games, 2012.

Star Wars films: *The Empire Strikes Back*, dir. Irvin Kershner, 1980; *Return of the Jedi*, dir. Richard Marquand, 1983; *Revenge of the Sith*, dir. George Lucas, 2005; *The Last Jedi*, dir. Rian Johnson, 2017.

Stone, Oliver, dir. *Wall Street*. 1987.

Strugatsky, Arkady, and Boris Strugatsky. *Piknik na obochine* (*Roadside Picnic*). 1972.

Tanaka Yoshiki. *Ginga eiyū densetsu* (*Legend of the Galactic Heroes*). 10 vols. Tokyo: Tokuma Shoten, 1982–1987.

Tarkovsky, Andrei, dir. *Stalker*. 1979.

Tevis, Walter. *The Queen's Gambit*. New York: Random House, 1983.

Wachowski, Lana, and Lilly Wachowski, dirs. *The Matrix*. 1999.

Weiner, Matthew, creator. *Mad Men*. Television series. AMC, 2007–2015.

Wu-Tang Clan. *Enter the Wu-Tang (36 Chambers)*. Loud Records, 1993.

Keywords

Robert Greene · *The 48 Laws of Power* · *The Art of Seduction* · *The 33 Strategies of War* · *The 50th Law* · *Mastery* · *The Laws of Human Nature* · *The Daily Laws* · *The Law of the Sublime* · Machiavellianism · *mētis* · metic sublime · anamorphosis · indirect communication · *upāya* (skillful means) · palinode · *pharmakon* · *arcana imperii* · reason of state · Tacitism · Neostoicism · court society · courtly reason · *sprezzatura* · dissimulation · prudence · mirrors for princes · wisdom literature · oracular genre · emblematics · *progymnasmata* · *synkrisis* · exemplarity · French *moralistes* · Gracián · La Rochefoucauld · Castiglione · Han Feizi · *Arthaśāstra* · Sunzi · Clausewitz · strategic theory · polemology · mimetic desire · seduction theory · tacit knowledge · craftsmanship · *Bildung* · Jungian shadow · death denial · the sublime · trickster archetype · trifunctional ideology · fourth function · speculative fiction · psychohistory · transmedia comparativism · reception theory · interpretive communities · inoculation theory · Dark Triad · entrepreneurial self · neoliberal subjectivity · algorithmic court · persuasive technology

Colophon. Set in EB Garamond, Georg Duffner and Octavio Pardo's revival of the types Claude Garamond cut in Paris from the 1530s, the decade of Holbein's ambassadors; Chinese and Japanese are set in Noto Serif CJK. Rubrics are printed in vermilion, after the red and black of the missal, and the plates in the green of Holbein's curtain.



The skull, resolved.